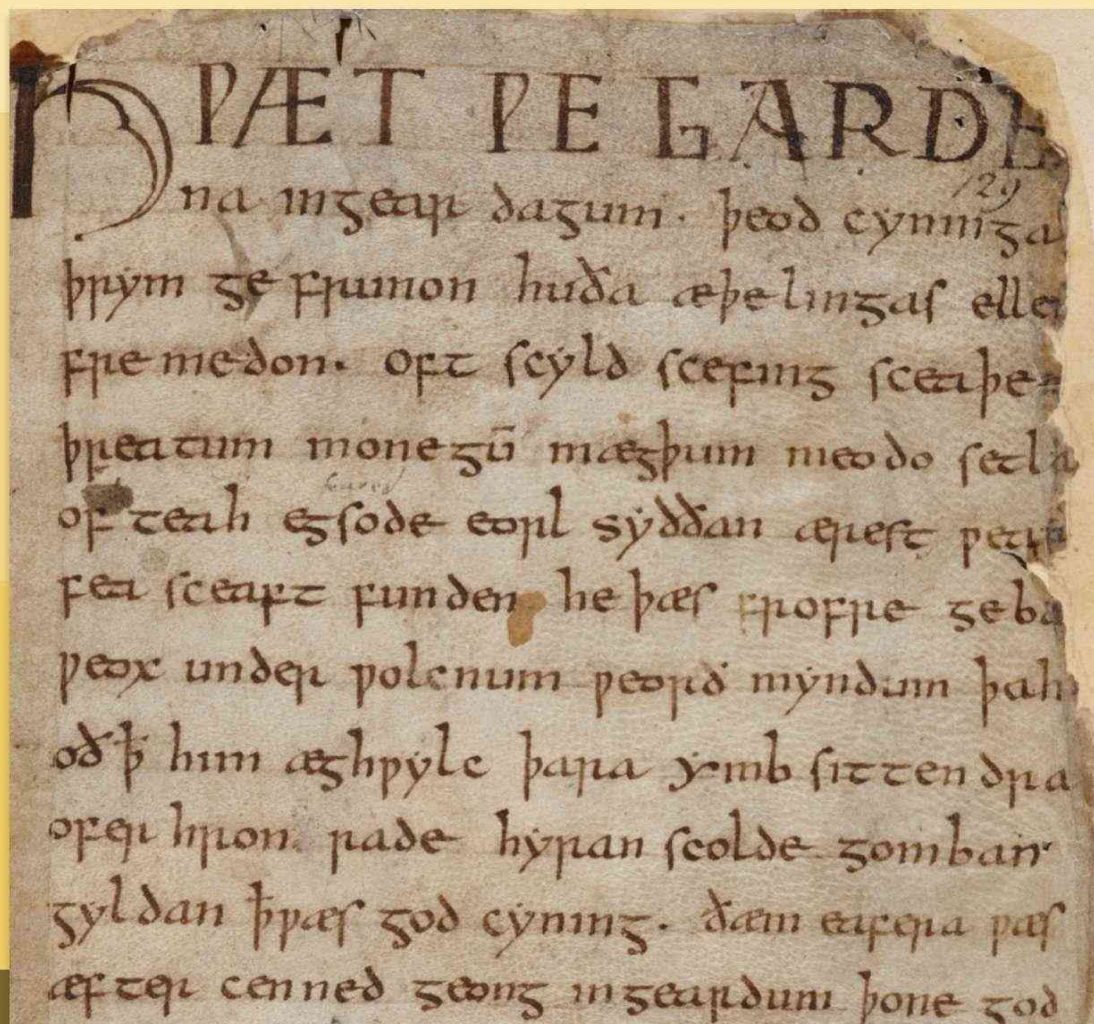


BEOWULF

An Anglo-Saxon Epic Poem

as translated by

J. Lesslie Hall

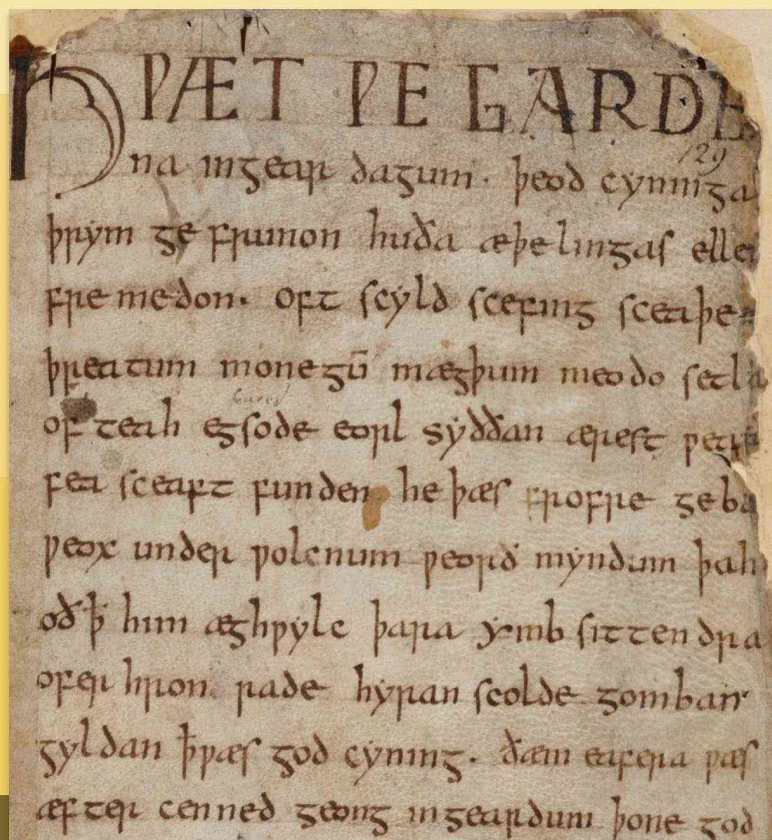


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BEOWULF

AN ANGLO- SAXON EPIC POEM

*TRANSLATED
FROM THE HEYNE-SOCIN TEXT*

BY

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TO
My Wife

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PREFACE.

THE present work is a modest effort to reproduce approximately, in modern measures, the venerable epic, Beowulf. *Approximately*, I repeat; for a very close reproduction of Anglo-Saxon verse would, to a large extent, be prose to a modern ear.

The Heyne-Socin text and glossary have been closely followed. Occasionally a deviation has been made, but always for what seemed good and sufficient reason. The translator does not aim to be an editor. Once in a while, however, he has added a conjecture of his own to the emendations quoted from the criticisms of other students of the poem.

This work is addressed to two classes of readers. From both of these alike the translator begs sympathy and co-operation. The Anglo-Saxon scholar he hopes to please by adhering faithfully to the original. The student of English literature he aims to interest by giving him, in modern garb, the most ancient epic of our race. This is a bold and venturesome undertaking; and yet there must be some students of the Teutonic past willing to follow even a daring guide, if they may read in modern phrases of the sorrows of Hrothgar, of the prowess of Beowulf, and of the feelings that stirred the hearts of our forefathers in their primeval homes.

In order to please the larger class of readers, a regular cadence has been used, a measure which, while retaining the essential characteristics of the original, permits the reader to see ahead of him in reading.

Perhaps every Anglo-Saxon scholar has his own theory as to how Beowulf should be translated. Some have given us prose versions of what we believe to be a great poem. Is it any reflection on our honored Kemble and Arnold to say that their translations fail to show a layman that Beowulf is justly called our first *epic*? Of those translators who have used verse, several have written from what would seem a mistaken point of view. Is it proper, for instance, that the grave and solemn speeches of Beowulf and Hrothgar be put in ballad measures, tripping lightly and airily along? Or, again, is it fitting that the rough martial music of Anglo-Saxon verse be interpreted to us in the smooth measures of modern blank verse? Do we hear what has been beautifully called “the clanging tread of a warrior in mail”?

Of all English translations of Beowulf, that of Professor Garnett alone gives any adequate idea of the chief characteristics of this great Teutonic epic.

The measure used in the present translation is believed to be as near a reproduction of the original as modern English affords. The cadences closely resemble those used by Browning in some of his most striking poems. The four stresses of the Anglo-Saxon verse are retained, and as much thesis and anacrusis is allowed as is consistent with a regular cadence. Alliteration has been used to a large extent; but it was thought that modern ears would hardly tolerate it on every line. End-rhyme has been used occasionally; internal rhyme, sporadically. Both have some warrant in Anglo-Saxon poetry. (For end-rhyme, see 1 53, 1 54; for internal rhyme, 2 21, 6 40.)

What Gummere¹ calls the “rime-giver” has been studiously kept; viz., the first accented syllable in the second half-verse always carries the alliteration; and the last accented syllable alliterates only sporadically. Alternate alliteration is occasionally used as in the original. (See 7 61, 8 5.)

No two accented syllables have been brought together, except occasionally after a cæsural pause. (See 2 19 and 12 1.) Or, scientifically speaking, Sievers's C type has been avoided as not consonant with the plan of translation. Several of his types, however, constantly occur; *e.g.* A and a variant (/ x | / x) (/ x x | / x); B and a variant (x / | x /) (x x / | x /); a variant of D (/ x | / x x); E (/ x x | /). Anacrusis gives further variety to the types used in the translation.

The parallelisms of the original have been faithfully preserved. (*E.g.*, 1 16 and 1 17: "Lord" and "Wielder of Glory"; 1 30, 1 31, 1 32; 2 12 and 2 13; 2 27 and 2 28; 3 5 and 3 6.) Occasionally, some loss has been sustained; but, on the other hand, a gain has here and there been made.

The effort has been made to give a decided flavor of archaism to the translation. All words not in keeping with the spirit of the poem have been avoided. Again, though many archaic words have been used, there are none, it is believed, which are not found in standard modern poetry.

With these preliminary remarks, it will not be amiss to give an outline of the story of the poem.

THE STORY.

Hrothgar, king of the Danes, or Scyldings, builds a great mead-hall, or palace, in which he hopes to feast his liegemen and to give them presents. The joy of king and retainers is, however, of short duration. Grendel, the monster, is seized with hateful jealousy. He cannot brook the sounds of joyance that reach him down in his fen-dwelling near the hall. Oft and anon he goes to the joyous building, bent on direful mischief. Thane after thane is ruthlessly carried off and devoured, while no one is found strong enough and bold enough to cope with the monster. For twelve years he persecutes Hrothgar and his vassals.

Over sea, a day's voyage off, Beowulf, of the Geats, nephew of Higelac, king of the Geats, hears of Grendel's doings and of Hrothgar's misery. He resolves to crush the fell monster and relieve the aged king. With fourteen chosen companions, he sets sail for Dane-land. Reaching that country, he soon persuades Hrothgar of his ability to help him. The hours that elapse before night are spent in beer-drinking and conversation. When Hrothgar's bedtime comes he leaves the hall in charge of Beowulf, telling him that never before has he given to another the absolute wardship of his palace. All retire to rest, Beowulf, as it were, sleeping upon his arms.

Grendel comes, the great march-stepper, bearing God's anger. He seizes and kills one of the sleeping warriors. Then he advances towards Beowulf. A fierce and desperate hand-to-hand struggle ensues. No arms are used, both combatants trusting to strength and hand-grip. Beowulf tears Grendel's shoulder from its socket, and the monster retreats to his den,

howling and yelling with agony and fury. The wound is fatal.

The next morning, at early dawn, warriors in numbers flock to the hall Heorot, to hear the news. Joy is boundless. Glee runs high. Hrothgar and his retainers are lavish of gratitude and of gifts.

Grendel's mother, however, comes the next night to avenge his death. She is furious and raging. While Beowulf is sleeping in a room somewhat apart from the quarters of the other warriors, she seizes one of Hrothgar's favorite counsellors, and carries him off and devours him. Beowulf is called. Determined to leave Heorot entirely purified, he arms himself, and goes down to look for the female monster. After traveling through the waters many hours, he meets her near the sea-bottom. She drags him to her den. There he sees Grendel lying dead. After a desperate and almost fatal struggle with the woman, he slays her, and swims upward in triumph, taking with him Grendel's head.

Joy is renewed at Heorot. Congratulations crowd upon the victor. Hrothgar literally pours treasures into the lap of Beowulf; and it is agreed among the vassals of the king that Beowulf will be their next liegeland.

Beowulf leaves Dane-land. Hrothgar weeps and laments at his departure.

When the hero arrives in his own land, Higelac treats him as a distinguished guest. He is the hero of the hour.

Beowulf subsequently becomes king of his own people, the Geats. After he has been ruling for fifty years, his own neighborhood is wofully harried by a fire-spewing dragon. Beowulf determines to kill him. In the ensuing struggle both Beowulf and the dragon are slain. The grief of the Geats is inexpressible. They determine, however, to leave nothing undone to honor the memory of their lord. A great funeral-pyre is built, and his body is burnt. Then a memorial-barrow is made, visible from a great distance, that sailors afar may

be constantly reminded of the prowess of the national hero of Geatland.

The poem closes with a glowing tribute to his bravery, his gentleness, his goodness of heart, and his generosity.

It is the devout desire of this translator to hasten the day when the story of Beowulf shall be as familiar to English-speaking peoples as that of the Iliad. Beowulf is our first great epic. It is an epitomized history of the life of the Teutonic races. It brings vividly before us our forefathers of pre-Alfredian eras, in their love of war, of sea, and of adventure.

My special thanks are due to Professors Francis A. March and James A. Harrison, for advice, sympathy, and assistance.

J.L. HALL.

[\[1\]](#) Handbook of Poetics, page 175, 1st edition.

ABBREVIATIONS USED IN THE NOTES.

B. = Bugge. C. = Cosijn. Gr. = Grein. Grdvtg. = Grundtvig. H. = Heyne. H. and S. = Harrison and Sharp. H.-So. = Heyne-Socin. K.= Kemble. Kl. = Kluge. M.= Müllenhoff. R. = Rieger. S. = Sievers. Sw. = Sweet. t.B. = ten Brink. Th. = Thorpe. W. = Wülcker.

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GLOSSARY OF PROPER NAMES.

[The figures refer to the divisions of the poem in which the respective names occur. The large figures refer to fitts, the small, to lines in the fitts.]

Ælfhere.—A kinsman of Wiglaf.—36 3.

Æschere.—Confidential friend of King Hrothgar. Elder brother of Yrmenlaf. Killed by Grendel.—21 3; 30 89.

Beanstan.—Father of Breca.—9 26.

Beowulf.—Son of Scyld, the founder of the dynasty of Scyldings. Father of Healfdene, and grandfather of Hrothgar.—1 18; 2 1.

Beowulf.—The hero of the poem. Sprung from the stock of Geats, son of Ecgtheow. Brought up by his maternal grandfather Hrethel, and figuring in manhood as a devoted liegeman of his uncle Higelac. A hero from his youth. Has the strength of thirty men. Engages in a swimming-match with Breca. Goes to the help of Hrothgar against the monster Grendel. Vanquishes Grendel and his mother. Afterwards becomes king of the Geats. Late in life attempts to kill a fire-spewing dragon, and is slain. Is buried with great honors. His memorial mound.—6 26; 7 2; 7 9; 9 3; 9 8; 12 28; 12 43; 23 1, etc.

Breca.—Beowulf's opponent in the famous swimming-match.—[9 8](#); [9 19](#); [9 21](#); [9 22](#).

Brondings.—A people ruled by Breca.—[9 23](#).

Brosinga mene.—A famous collar once owned by the Brosings.—[19 7](#).

Cain.—Progenitor of Grendel and other monsters.—[2 56](#); [20 11](#).

Dæghrefn.—A warrior of the Hugs, killed by Beowulf.—[35 40](#).

Danes.—Subjects of Scyld and his descendants, and hence often called Scyldings. Other names for them are Victory-Scyldings, Honor-Scyldings, Armor-Danes, Bright-Danes, East-Danes, West-Danes, North-Danes, South-Danes, Ingwins, Hrethmen.—[1 1](#); [2 1](#); [3 2](#); [5 14](#); [7 1](#), etc.

Ecglaf.—Father of Unferth, who taunts Beowulf.—[9 1](#).

Ecgtheow.—Father of Beowulf, the hero of the poem. A widely-known Wægmunding warrior. Marries Hrethel's daughter. After slaying Heatholaf, a Wylfing, he flees his country.—[7 3](#); [5 6](#); [8 4](#).

Ecgwela.—A king of the Danes before Scyld.—[25 60](#).

Elan.—Sister of Hrothgar, and probably wife of Ongentheow, king of the Swedes.—[2 10](#).

Eagle Cape.—A promontory in Geat-land, under which took place Beowulf's last encounter.—[41 87](#).

Eadgils.—Son of Ohthere and brother of Eanmund.—[34 2](#).

Eanmund.—Son of Ohthere and brother of Eadgils. The reference to these brothers is vague, and variously understood. Heyne supposes as follows: Raising a revolt against their father, they are obliged to leave Sweden. They go to the land of the Geats; with what intention, is not known, but probably to conquer and

plunder. The Geatish king, Heardred, is slain by one of the brothers, probably Eanmund.—[36 10](#); [31 54](#) to [31 60](#); [33 66](#) to [34 6](#).

Eofor.—A Geatish hero who slays Ongentheow in war, and is rewarded by Hygelac with the hand of his only daughter.—[41 18](#); [41 48](#).

Eormenric.—A Gothic king, from whom Hama took away the famous Brosinga mene.—[19 9](#).

Eomær.—Son of Offa and Thrytho, king and queen of the Angles.—[28 69](#).

Finn.—King of the North-Frisians and the Jutes. Marries Hildeburg. At his court takes place the horrible slaughter in which the Danish general, Hnæf, fell. Later on, Finn himself is slain by Danish warriors.—[17 18](#); [17 30](#); [17 44](#); [18 4](#); [18 23](#).

Fin-land.—The country to which Beowulf was driven by the currents in his swimming-match.—[10 22](#).

Fitela.—Son and nephew of King Sigemund, whose praises are sung in XIV.—[14 42](#); [14 53](#).

Folcwalda.—Father of Finn.—[17 38](#).

Franks.—Introduced occasionally in referring to the death of Higelac.—[19 19](#); [40 21](#); [40 24](#).

Frisians.—A part of them are ruled by Finn. Some of them were engaged in the struggle in which Higelac was slain.—[17 20](#); [17 42](#); [17 52](#); [40 21](#).

Freaware.—Daughter of King Hrothgar. Married to Ingeld, a Heathobard prince.—[29 60](#); [30 32](#).

Froda.—King of the Heathobards, and father of Ingeld.—[29 62](#).

Garmund.—Father of Offa.—[28 71](#).

Geats, Geatmen.—The race to which the hero of the poem belongs. Also called Weder-Geats, or Weders, War-

Geats, Sea-Geats. They are ruled by Hrethel, Hæthcyn, Higelac, and Beowulf.—[4 7](#); [7 4](#); [10 45](#); [11 8](#); [27 14](#); [28 8](#).

Gepids.—Named in connection with the Danes and Swedes.—[35 34](#).

Grendel.—A monster of the race of Cain. Dwells in the fens and moors. Is furiously envious when he hears sounds of joy in Hrothgar's palace. Causes the king untold agony for years. Is finally conquered by Beowulf, and dies of his wound. His hand and arm are hung up in Hrothgar's hall Heorot. His head is cut off by Beowulf when he goes down to fight with Grendel's mother.—[2 50](#); [3 1](#); [3 13](#); [8 19](#); [11 17](#); [12 2](#); [13 27](#); [15 3](#).

Guthlaf.—A Dane of Hnæf's party.—[18 24](#).

Half-Danes.—Branch of the Danes to which Hnæf belonged.—[17 19](#).

Halga.—Surnamed the Good. Younger brother of Hrothgar.—[2 9](#).

Hama.—Takes the Brosinga mene from Eormenric.—[19 7](#).

Hæreth.—Father of Higelac's queen, Hygd.—[28 39](#); [29 18](#).

Hæthcyn.—Son of Hrethel and brother of Higelac. Kills his brother Herebeald accidentally. Is slain at Ravenswood, fighting against Ongentheow.—[34 43](#); [35 23](#); [40 32](#).

Helmings.—The race to which Queen Wealhtheow belonged.—[10 63](#).

Heming.—A kinsman of Garmund, perhaps nephew.—[28 54](#); [28 70](#).

Hengest.—A Danish leader. Takes command on the fall of Hnæf.—[17 33](#); [17 41](#).

Herebeald.—Eldest son of Hrethel, the Geatish king, and brother of Higelac. Killed by his younger brother Hæthcyn.—[34 43](#); [34 47](#).

Heremod.—A Danish king of a dynasty before the Scylding line. Was a source of great sorrow to his people.—[14 64](#); [25 59](#).

Hereric.—Referred to as uncle of Heardred, but otherwise unknown.—[31 60](#).

Hetwars.—Another name for the Franks.—[33 51](#).

Healfdene.—Grandson of Scyld and father of Hrothgar. Ruled the Danes long and well.—[2 5](#); [4 1](#); [8 14](#).

Heardred.—Son of Higelac and Hygd, king and queen of the Geats. Succeeds his father, with Beowulf as regent. Is slain by the sons of Ohthere.—[31 56](#); [33 63](#); [33 75](#).

Heathobards.—Race of Lombards, of which Froda is king. After Froda falls in battle with the Danes, Ingeld, his son, marries Hrothgar's daughter, Freaware, in order to heal the feud.—[30 1](#); [30 6](#).

Heatholaf.—A Wylfing warrior slain by Beowulf's father.—[8 5](#).

Heathoremes.—The people on whose shores Breca is cast by the waves during his contest with Beowulf.—[9 21](#).

Heorogar.—Elder brother of Hrothgar, and surnamed 'Weoroda Ræswa,' Prince of the Troopers.—[2 9](#); [8 12](#).

Hereward.—Son of the above.—[31 17](#).

Heort, Heorot.—The great mead-hall which King Hrothgar builds. It is invaded by Grendel for twelve years. Finally cleansed by Beowulf, the Geat. It is called Heort on account of the hart-antlers which decorate it.—[2 25](#); [3 32](#); [3 52](#).

Hildeburg.—Wife of Finn, daughter of Hoce, and related to Hnæf,—probably his sister.—[17 21](#); [18 34](#).

Hnæf.—Leader of a branch of the Danes called Half-Danes. Killed in the struggle at Finn's castle.—[17 19](#); [17 61](#).

Hondscio.—One of Beowulf's companions. Killed by Grendel just before Beowulf grappled with that monster.—[30 43](#).

Hoce.—Father of Hildeburg and probably of Hnæf.—[17 26](#).

Hrethel.—King of the Geats, father of Higelac, and grandfather of Beowulf.—[7 4](#); [34 39](#).

Hrethla.—Once used for Hrethel.—[7 82](#).

Hrethmen.—Another name for the Danes.—[7 73](#).

Hrethric.—Son of Hrothgar.—[18 65](#); [27 19](#).

Hreosna-beorh.—A promontory in Geat-land, near which Ohthere's sons made plundering raids.—[35 18](#).

Hrothgar.—The Danish king who built the hall Heort, but was long unable to enjoy it on account of Grendel's persecutions. Marries Wealhtheow, a Helming lady. Has two sons and a daughter. Is a typical Teutonic king, lavish of gifts. A devoted liegelord, as his lamentations over slain liegemen prove. Also very appreciative of kindness, as is shown by his loving gratitude to Beowulf.—[2 9](#); [2 12](#); [4 1](#); [8 10](#); [15 1](#); etc., etc.

Hrothmund.—Son of Hrothgar.—[18 65](#).

Hrothulf.—Probably a son of Halga, younger brother of Hrothgar. Certainly on terms of close intimacy in Hrothgar's palace.—[16 26](#); [18 57](#).

Hrunting.—Unferth's sword, lent to Beowulf.—[22 71](#); [25 9](#).

Hugs.—A race in alliance with the Franks and Frisians at the time of Higelac's fall.—[35 41](#).

Hun.—A Frisian warrior, probably general of the Hetwars. Gives Hengest a beautiful sword.—[18 19](#).

Hunferth.—Sometimes used for Unferth.

Hygelac, Higlac.—King of the Geats, uncle and liegelord of Beowulf, the hero of the poem.—His second wife is the lovely Hygd, daughter of Hæreth. The son of their union is Heardred. Is slain in a war with the Hugs, Franks, and Frisians combined. Beowulf is regent, and afterwards king of the Geats.—[4 6](#); [5 4](#); [28 34](#); [29 9](#); [29 21](#); [31 56](#).

Hygd.—Wife of Higlac, and daughter of Hæreth. There are some indications that she married Beowulf after she became a widow.—[28 37](#).

Ingeld.—Son of the Heathobard king, Froda. Marries Hrothgar's daughter, Freaware, in order to reconcile the two peoples.—[29 62](#); [30 32](#).

Ingwins.—Another name for the Danes.—[16 52](#); [20 69](#).

Jutes.—Name sometimes applied to Finn's people.—[17 22](#); [17 38](#); [18 17](#).

Lafing.—Name of a famous sword presented to Hengest by Hun.—[18 19](#).

Merewing.—A Frankish king, probably engaged in the war in which Higlac was slain.—[40 29](#).

Nægling.—Beowulf's sword.—[36 76](#).

Offa.—King of the Angles, and son of Garmund. Marries the terrible Thrytho who is so strongly contrasted with Hygd.—[28 59](#); [28 66](#).

Ohthere.—Son of Ongentheow, king of the Swedes. He is father of Eanmund and Eadgils.—[40 35](#); [40 39](#).

Onela.—Brother of Ohthere.—[36 15](#); [40 39](#).

Ongentheow.—King of Sweden, of the Scylfing dynasty. Married, perhaps, Elan, daughter of Healfdene.—

35 26; 41 16.

Oslaf.—A Dane of Hnæf's party.—18 24.

Ravenswood.—The forest near which Hæthcyn was slain.
—40 31; 40 41.

Scefig.—Applied (1 4) to Scyld, and meaning 'son of Scef.'

Scyld.—Founder of the dynasty to which Hrothgar, his father, and grandfather belonged. He dies, and his body is put on a vessel, and set adrift. He goes from Daneland just as he had come to it—in a bark.—1 4; 1 19; 1 27.

Scyldings.—The descendants of Scyld. They are also called Honor-Scyldings, Victory-Scyldings, War-Scyldings, etc. (See 'Danes,' above.)—2 1; 7 1; 8 1.

Scylfings.—A Swedish royal line to which Wiglaf belonged.—36 2.

Sigemund.—Son of Wæls, and uncle and father of Fitela. His struggle with a dragon is related in connection with Beowulf's deeds of prowess.—14 38; 14 47.

Swerting.—Grandfather of Higelac, and father of Hrethel.
—19 11.

Swedes.—People of Sweden, ruled by the Scylfings.—35 13.

Thrytho.—Wife of Offa, king of the Angles. Known for her fierce and unwomanly disposition. She is introduced as a contrast to the gentle Hygd, queen of Higelac.—28 42; 28 56.

Unferth.—Son of Ecglaf, and seemingly a confidential courtier of Hrothgar. Taunts Beowulf for having taken part in the swimming-match. Lends Beowulf his sword when he goes to look for Grendel's mother. In the MS. sometimes written *Hunferth*. 9 1; 18 41.

Wæls.—Father of Sigemund.—[14](#) [60](#).

Wægmunding.—A name occasionally applied to Wiglaf and Beowulf, and perhaps derived from a common ancestor, Wægmund.—[36](#) [6](#); [38](#) [61](#).

Weders.—Another name for Geats or Wedergeats.

Wayland.—A fabulous smith mentioned in this poem and in other old Teutonic literature.—[7](#) [83](#).

Wendels.—The people of Wulfgar, Hrothgar's messenger and retainer. (Perhaps = Vandals.)—[6](#) [30](#).

Wealhtheow.—Wife of Hrothgar. Her queenly courtesy is well shown in the poem.—[10](#) [55](#).

Weohstan, or Wihstan.—A Wægmunding, and father of Wiglaf.—[36](#) [1](#).

Whale's Ness.—A prominent promontory, on which Beowulf's mound was built.—[38](#) [52](#); [42](#) [76](#).

Wiglaf.—Son of Wihstan, and related to Beowulf. He remains faithful to Beowulf in the fatal struggle with the fire-drake. Would rather die than leave his lord in his dire emergency.—[36](#) [1](#); [36](#) [3](#); [36](#) [28](#).

Wonred.—Father of Wulf and Eofor.—[41](#) [20](#); [41](#) [26](#).

Wulf.—Son of Wonred. Engaged in the battle between Higelac's and Ongentheow's forces, and had a hand-to-hand fight with Ongentheow himself. Ongentheow disables him, and is thereupon slain by Eofor.—[41](#) [19](#); [41](#) [29](#).

Wulfgar.—Lord of the Wendels, and retainer of Hrothgar.—[6](#) [18](#); [6](#) [30](#).

Wylfings.—A people to whom belonged Heatholaf, who was slain by Ecgtheow.—[8](#) [6](#); [8](#) [16](#).

Yrmenlaf.—Younger brother of Æschere, the hero whose death grieved Hrothgar so deeply.—[21](#) [4](#).

LIST OF WORDS AND PHRASES NOT IN GENERAL USE.

ATHELING.—Prince, nobleman.

BAIRN.—Son, child.

BARROW.—Mound, rounded hill, funeral-mound.

BATTLE-SARK.—Armor.

BEAKER.—Cup, drinking-vessel.

BEGEAR.—Prepare.

BIGHT.—Bay, sea.

BILL.—Sword.

BOSS.—Ornamental projection.

BRACTEATE.—A round ornament on a necklace.

BRAND.—Sword.

BURN.—Stream.

BURNIE.—Armor.

CARLE.—Man, hero.

EARL.—Nobleman, any brave man.

EKE.—Also.

EMPRISE.—Enterprise, undertaking.

ERST.—Formerly.

ERST-WORTHY.—Worthy for a long time past.

FAIN.—Glad.

FERRY.—Bear, carry.

FEY.—Fated, doomed.

FLOAT.—Vessel, ship.

FOIN.—To lunge (Shaks.).

GLORY OF KINGS.—God.

GREWSOME.—Cruel, fierce.

HEFT.—Handle, hilt; used by synecdoche for ‘sword.’

HELM.—Helmet, protector.

HENCHMAN.—Retainer, vassal.

HIGHT.—Am (was) named.

HOLM.—Ocean, curved surface of the sea.

HIMSEEMED.—(It) seemed to him.

LIEF.—Dear, valued.

MERE.—Sea; in compounds, ‘mere-ways,’ ‘mere-currents,’
etc.

MICKLE.—Much.

NATHLESS.—Nevertheless.

NAZE.—Edge (nose).

NESS.—Edge.

NICKER.—Sea-beast.

QUIT, QUITE.—Requite.

RATHE.—Quickly.

REAVE.—Bereave, deprive.

SAIL-ROAD.—Sea.

SETTLE.—Seat, bench.

SKINKER.—One who pours.

SOOTHLY.—Truly.

SWINGE.—Stroke, blow.

TARGE, TARGET.—Shield.

THOROUGHLY.—Thoroughly.

TOLD.—Counted.

UNCANNY.—Ill-featured, grizzly.

UNNETHE.—Difficult.

WAR-SPEED.—Success in war.

WEB.—Tapestry (that which is ‘woven’).

WEDED.—Clad (cf. widow’s weeds).

WEEN.—Suppose, imagine.

WEIRD.—Fate, Providence.

WHILOM.—At times, formerly, often.

WIELDER.—Ruler. Often used of God; also in compounds,
as ‘Wielder of Glory,’ ‘Wielder of Worship.’

WIGHT.—Creature.

WOLD.—Plane, extended surface.

WOT.—Knows.

YOUNKER.—Youth.

BEOWULF.

I.

THE LIFE AND DEATH OF SCYLD.

Lo! the Spear-Danes' glory through
splendid achievements

The famous
race of Spear-
Danes.

The folk-kings' former fame we have
heard of,

How princes displayed then their prowess-in-battle.

Oft Scyld the Scefing from scathers in
numbers

Scyld, their
mighty king, in
honor of whom
they are often
called
Scyldings. He
is the great-
grandfather of
Hrothgar, so
prominent in
the poem.

5

From many a people their mead-
benches tore.

Since first he found him friendless and
wretched,

The earl had had terror: comfort he got
for it,

Waxed 'neath the welkin, world-honor gained,

Till all his neighbors o'er sea were compelled to

10

Bow to his bidding and bring him their tribute:

An excellent atheling! After was borne him

A son and heir, young in his dwelling,
Whom God-Father sent to solace the
people.

A son is born
to him, who
receives the
name of
Beowulf—a
name
afterwards
made so
famous by the
hero of the
poem.

He had marked the misery malice had
caused them,

15

¹That reaved of their rulers they
wretched had erstwhile²

Long been afflicted. The Lord, in requital,

Wielder of Glory, with world-honor blessed him.
Famed was Beowulf, far spread the glory
Of Scyld's great son in the lands of the Danemen.

20

So the carle that is young, by
 kindnesses rendered

The ideal
Teutonic king
lavishes gifts
on his vassals.

The friends of his father, with fees in
 abundance

Must be able to earn that when age approacheth
Eager companions aid him requitingly,
When war assaults him serve him as liegemen:

25

By praise-worthy actions must honor be got
'Mong all of the races. At the hour that was fated
Scyld then departed to the All-Father's
 keeping

Scyld dies at
the hour
appointed by
Fate.

Warlike to wend him; away then they
 bare him

To the flood of the current, his fond-loving
 comrades,

30

As himself he had bidden, while the friend of the
 Scyldings

Word-sway wielded, and the well-lovèd land-prince
Long did rule them.³ The ring-stemmèd vessel,
Bark of the atheling, lay there at anchor,
Icy in glimmer and eager for sailing;

35

The belovèd leader laid they down
 there,
Giver of rings, on the breast of the
 vessel,

By his own
request, his
body is laid on
a vessel and
wafted
seaward.

The famed by the mainmast. A many of jewels,
Of fretted embossings, from far-lands brought over,

Was placed near at hand then; and heard I not ever

40

That a folk ever furnished a float more superbly
With weapons of warfare, weeds for the battle,
Bills and burnies; on his bosom sparkled
Many a jewel that with him must travel
On the flush of the flood afar on the current.

45

And favors no fewer they furnished him soothly,
Excellent folk-gems, than others had given him

Who when first he was born outward
did send him

He leaves
Daneland on
the breast of a
bark.

Lone on the main, the merest of
infants:

And a gold-fashioned standard they stretched under
heaven

50

High o'er his head, let the holm-currents bear him,
Seaward consigned him: sad was their spirit,
Their mood very mournful. Men are not able

Soothly to tell us, they in halls who
reside,⁴

No one knows
whither the
boat drifted.

Heroes under heaven, to what haven he
hied.

[1] For the 'Ðæt' of verse 15, Sievers suggests 'Ðá' (= which). If this be accepted, the sentence 'He had ... afflicted' will read: *He (i.e. God) had perceived the malice-caused sorrow which they, lordless, had formerly long endured.*

[2] For 'aldor-léase' (15) Gr. suggested 'aldor-ceare': *He perceived their distress, that they formerly had suffered life-sorrow a long while.*

[3] A very difficult passage. 'Áhte' (31) has no object. H. supplies 'geweald' from the context; and our translation is based upon this assumption, though it is far from satisfactory. Kl. suggests 'lændagas' for 'lange': *And the beloved land-prince enjoyed (had)*

his transitory days (i.e. lived). B. suggests a dislocation; but this is a dangerous doctrine, pushed rather far by that eminent scholar.

- [4] The reading of the H.-So. text has been quite closely followed; but some eminent scholars read 'séle-rædenne' for 'sele-rædende.' If that be adopted, the passage will read: *Men cannot tell us, indeed, the order of Fate, etc.* 'Sele-rædende' has two things to support it: (1) v. 1347; (2) it affords a parallel to 'men' in [v. 50](#).

II.

SCYLD'S SUCCESSORS.—
HROTHGAR'S GREAT MEAD-
HALL.

In the boroughs then Beowulf, bairn of the Scyldings, Belovèd land-prince, for long-lasting season	Beowulf succeeds his father Scyld
---	---

Was famed mid the folk (his father departed,
The prince from his dwelling), till afterward sprang

5
Great-minded Healfdene; the Danes in his lifetime
He graciously governed, grim-mooded, agèd.

Four bairns of his body born in succession

Woke in the world, war-troopers' leader
Heorogar, Hrothgar, and Halga the good;

10
Heard I that Elan was Ongentheow's consort,

The well-beloved bedmate of the War-Scylfing leader.

Then glory in battle to Hrothgar was given,
—and a daughter named Elan.

Waxing of war-fame, that willingly
kinsmen

Obeyed his bidding, till the boys grew
to manhood,

15
A numerous band. It burned in his spirit
To urge his folk to found a great building,
A mead-hall grander than men of the era

Ever had heard of, and in it to share
With young and old all of the blessings

20

The Lord had allowed him, save life
and retainers.

He is eager to
build a great
hall in which
he may feast
his retainers

Then the work I find afar was assigned
To many races in middle-earth's regions,
To adorn the great folk-hall. In due time it happened
Early 'mong men, that 'twas finished entirely,

25

The greatest of hall-buildings; Heorot he named it
Who wide-reaching word-sway
wielded 'mong earlmen.

The hall is
completed, and
is called Heort,
or Heorot.

His promise he brake not, rings he
lavished,

Treasure at banquet. Towered the hall up
High and horn-crested, huge between antlers:

30

It battle-waves bided, the blasting fire-demon;
Ere long then from hottest hatred must sword-wrath
Arise for a woman's husband and father.

Then the mighty war-spirit¹ endured for a season,
Bore it bitterly, he who bided in
darkness,

The Monster
Grendel is
madly envious
of the
Danemen's joy.

35

That light-hearted laughter loud in the
building

Greeted him daily; there was dulcet harp-music,
Clear song of the singer. He said that was able
To tell from of old earthmen's beginnings,
That Father Almighty earth had created,

40

The winsome wold that the water encircleth,
Set exultingly the sun's and the moon's beams

To lavish their lustre on land-folk and
races,
And earth He embellished in all her
regions
With limbs and leaves; life He
bestowed too

[The course of
the story is
interrupted by
a short
reference to
some old
account of the
creation.]

45

On all the kindreds that live under heaven.

So blessed with abundance, brimming
with joyance,

The glee of the
warriors is
overcast by a
horrible dread.

The warriors abided, till a certain one
gan to

Dog them with deeds of direfullest malice,

A foe in the hall-building: this horrible stranger²

50

Was Grendel entitled, the march-stepper famous

Who³ dwelt in the moor-fens, the marsh and the
fastness;

The wan-mooded being abode for a season

In the land of the giants, when the Lord and Creator
Had banned him and branded. For that bitter murder,

55

The killing of Abel, all-ruling Father

The kindred of Cain crushed with His
vengeance;

Cain is referred
to as a
progenitor of
Grendel, and
of monsters in
general.

In the feud He rejoiced not, but far
away drove him

From kindred and kind, that crime to
atone for,

Meter of Justice. Thence ill-favored creatures,

60

Elves and giants, monsters of ocean,

Came into being, and the giants that longtime

Grappled with God; He gave them requital.

- [1] R. and t. B. prefer 'ellor-gæst' to 'ellen-gæst' (86): *Then the stranger from afar endured, etc.*
- [2] Some authorities would translate 'demon' instead of 'stranger.'
- [3] Some authorities arrange differently, and render: *Who dwelt in the moor-fens, the marsh and the fastness, the land of the giant-race.*

III.

GRENDDEL THE MURDERER.

When the sun was sunken, he set out to visit
The lofty hall-building, how the Ring-Danes had used it
For beds and benches when the banquet was over.
Then he found there reposing many a noble
5
Asleep after supper; sorrow the heroes,¹
Misery knew not. The monster of evil
Greedy and cruel tarried but little,
Fell and frantic, and forced from their slumbers
Thirty of thanemen; thence he departed
10
Leaping and laughing, his lair to return to,
With surfeit of slaughter sallying homeward.
In the dusk of the dawning, as the day was just
breaking,
Was Grendel's prowess revealed to the warriors:
Then, his meal-taking finished, a moan was uplifted,
15
Morning-cry mighty. The man-ruler famous,
The long-worthy atheling, sat very woful,
Suffered great sorrow, sighed for his liegemen,
When they had seen the track of the hateful pursuer,
The spirit accursèd: too crushing that sorrow,
20
The monster returns the next

Too loathsome and lasting. Not longer night.
he tarried,

But one night after continued his slaughter
Shameless and shocking, shrinking but little
From malice and murder; they mastered him fully.
He was easy to find then who elsewhere looked for

A pleasanter place of repose in the lodges,
A bed in the bowers. Then was brought to his notice
Told him truly by token apparent
The hall-thane's hatred: he held himself after
Further and faster who the foeman did baffle.

2 So ruled he and strongly strove against justice
Lone against all men, till empty uptowered
The choicest of houses. Long was the
season:
Twelve-winters' time torture suffered
The friend of the Scyldings, every
affliction,

King
Hrothgar's
agony and
suspense last
twelve years.

35
Endless agony; hence it after³ became
Certainly known to the children of men
Sadly in measures, that long against Hrothgar
Grendel struggled:—his grudges he cherished,
Murderous malice, many a winter,

40
Strife unremitting, and peacefully wished he

4Life-woe to lift from no liegeman at all of
The men of the Dane-folk, for money to settle,
No counsellor needed count for a moment
On handsome amends at the hands of the murderer;

[illegible]

Grendel is
unremitting in

No praise could they give the Guardian ^{know.}
of Heaven,

The Wielder of Glory. Woe will be his who
Through furious hatred his spirit shall drive to

70

The clutch of the fire, no comfort shall look for,
Wax no wiser; well for the man who,
Living his life-days, his Lord may face
And find defence in his Father's embrace!

- [1] The translation is based on 'weras,' adopted by H.-So.—K. and Th. read 'wera' and, arranging differently, render 119(2)-120: *They knew not sorrow, the wretchedness of man, aught of misfortune.*—For 'unhælo' (120) R. suggests 'unfælo': *The uncanny creature, greedy and cruel, etc.*
- [2] S. rearranges and translates: *So he ruled and struggled unjustly, one against all, till the noblest of buildings stood useless (it was a long while) twelve years' time: the friend of the Scyldings suffered distress, every woe, great sorrows, etc.*
- [3] For 'syððan,' B. suggests 'sárcwidum': *Hence in mournful words it became well known, etc.* Various other words beginning with 's' have been conjectured.
- [4] The H.-So. glossary is very inconsistent in referring to this passage.—'Sibbe' (154), which H.-So. regards as an instr., B. takes as accus., obj. of 'wolde.' Putting a comma after Deniga, he renders: *He did not desire peace with any of the Danes, nor did he wish to remove their life-woe, nor to settle for money.*
- [5] Of this difficult passage the following interpretations among others are given: (1) Though Grendel has frequented Heorot as a demon, he could not become ruler of the Danes, on account of his hostility to God. (2) Hrothgar was much grieved that Grendel had not appeared before his throne to receive presents. (3) He was not permitted to devastate the hall, on account of the Creator; *i.e.* God wished to make his visit fatal to him.—Ne ... wisse (169) W. renders: *Nor had he any desire to do so; 'his' being obj. gen. = danach.*

IV.

BEOWULF GOES TO HROTHGAR'S ASSISTANCE.

So Healfdene's kinsman constantly
mused on

His long-lasting sorrow; the battle-
thane clever

Was not anyway able evils to 'scape
from:

Too crushing the sorrow that came to the people,

5

Loathsome and lasting the life-grinding torture,

Greatest of night-woes. So Higelac's
liegeman,

Good amid Geatmen, of Grendel's
achievements

Heard in his home:¹ of heroes then
living

He was stoutest and strongest, sturdy
and noble.

10

He bade them prepare him a bark that was trusty;

He said he the war-king would seek o'er the ocean,

The folk-leader noble, since he needed retainers.

For the perilous project prudent companions

Chided him little, though loving him dearly;

15

They egged the brave atheling, augured him glory.

The excellent knight from the folk of
the Geatmen

Hrothgar sees
no way of
escape from
the
persecutions of
Grendel.

Beowulf, the
Geat, hero of
the poem,
hears of
Hrothgar's
sorrow, and
resolves to go
to his
assistance.

With fourteen
carefully
chosen
companions,

Had liegemen selected, likest to prove he sets out for
them Dane-land.

Trustworthy warriors; with fourteen companions
The vessel he looked for; a liegeman then showed
them,

20

A sea-crafty man, the bounds of the country.
Fast the days fleeted; the float was a-water,
The craft by the cliff. Clomb to the prow then
Well-equipped warriors: the wave-currents twisted
The sea on the sand; soldiers then carried

25

On the breast of the vessel bright-shining jewels,
Handsome war-armor; heroes outshoved then,
Warmen the wood-ship, on its wished-for adventure.
The foamy-necked floater fanned by The vessel
the breeze, sails like a bird

Likest a bird, glided the waters,

30

Till twenty and four hours thereafter In twenty four
The twist-stemmed vessel had traveled hours they
such distance reach the
That the sailing-men saw the sloping shores of
embankments, Hrothgar's
 dominions

The sea cliffs gleaming, precipitous mountains,
Nesses enormous: they were nearing the limits

35

At the end of the ocean.² Up thence quickly
The men of the Weders clomb to the mainland,
Fastened their vessel (battle weeds rattled,
War burnies clattered), the Wielder they thanked
That the ways o'er the waters had waxen so gentle.

40

They are hailed
by the Danish
coast guard

Then well from the cliff edge the guard of the
Scyldings
Who the sea-cliffs should see to, saw o'er the
gangway
Brave ones bearing beauteous targets,
Armor all ready, anxiously thought he,
Musing and wondering what men were approaching.

45

High on his horse then Hrothgar's retainer
Turned him to coastward, mightily brandished
His lance in his hands, questioned with boldness.
"Who are ye men here, mail-covered His challenge
warriors

Clad in your corslets, come thus a-driving

50

A high riding ship o'er the shoals of the waters,
³And hither 'neath helmets have hied o'er the ocean?
I have been strand-guard, standing as warden,
Lest enemies ever anywise ravage
Danish dominions with army of war-ships.

55

More boldly never have warriors ventured
Hither to come; of kinsmen's approval,
Word-leave of warriors, I ween that ye surely
Nothing have known. Never a greater He is struck by
one Beowulf's
appearance.

Of earls o'er the earth have *I* had a
sight of

60

Than is one of your number, a hero in armor;
No low-ranking fellow⁴ adorned with his weapons,
But launching them little, unless looks are deceiving,
And striking appearance. Ere ye pass on your
journey

As treacherous spies to the land of the Scyldings

65

And farther fare, I fully must know now

What race ye belong to. Ye far-away dwellers,

Sea-faring sailors, my simple opinion

Hear ye and hearken: haste is most fitting

Plainly to tell me what place ye are come from.”

- [1] ‘From hám’ (194) is much disputed. One rendering is: *Beowulf, being away from home, heard of Hrothgar’s troubles, etc.* Another, that adopted by S. and endorsed in the H.-So. notes, is: *B. heard from his neighborhood (neighbors), i.e. in his home, etc.* A third is: *B., being at home, heard this as occurring away from home.* The H.-So. glossary and notes conflict.
- [2] ‘Eoletes’ (224) is marked with a (?) by H.-So.; our rendering simply follows his conjecture.—Other conjectures as to ‘eolet’ are: (1) *voyage*, (2) *toil, labor*, (3) *hasty journey*.
- [3] The lacuna of the MS at this point has been supplied by various conjectures. The reading adopted by H.-So. has been rendered in the above translation. W., like H.-So., makes ‘ic’ the beginning of a new sentence, but, for ‘helmas bæron,’ he reads ‘hringed stefnan.’ This has the advantage of giving a parallel to ‘brontne ceol’ instead of a kenning for ‘go.’—B puts the (?) after ‘holmas’, and begins a new sentence at the middle of the line. Translate: *What warriors are ye, clad in armor, who have thus come bringing the foaming vessel over the water way, hither over the seas? For some time on the wall I have been coast guard, etc.* S. endorses most of what B. says, but leaves out ‘on the wall’ in the last sentence. If W.’s ‘hringed stefnan’ be accepted, change [line 51](#) above to, *A ring-stemmed vessel hither o’ersea.*
- [4] ‘Seld-guma’ (249) is variously rendered: (1) *housecarle*; (2) *home-stayer*; (3) *common man*. Dr. H. Wood suggests *a man-at-arms in another’s house*.

V.

THE GEATS REACH HEOROT.

The chief of the strangers rendered him answer, War-troopers' leader, and word- treasure opened: "We are sprung from the lineage of the people of Geatland, And Higelac's hearth-friends. To heroes unnumbered 5 My father was known, a noble head- warrior Ecgtheow titled; many a winter He lived with the people, ere he passed on his journey, Old from his dwelling; each of the counsellors Widely mid world-folk well remembers him. 10 We, kindly of spirit, the lord of thy people, The son of King Healfdene, have come here to visit, Folk-troop's defender: be free in thy counsels! To the noble one bear we a weighty commission, The helm of the Danemen; we shall hide, I ween, 15 Naught of our message. Thou know'st if it happen, As we soothly heard say, that some savage despoiler, Some hidden pursuer, on nights that are murky	Beowulf courteously replies. We are Geats. My father Ecgtheow was well-known in his day. Our intentions towards King Hrothgar are of the kindest. Is it true that a monster is slaying Danish heroes?
---	--

By deeds very direful 'mid the Danemen exhibits
Hatred unheard of, horrid destruction

20

And the falling of dead. From feelings least selfish

I am able to render counsel to

Hrothgar,

How he, wise and worthy, may worst
the destroyer,

I can help your
king to free
himself from
this horrible
creature.

If the anguish of sorrow should ever be lessened,¹

Comfort come to him, and care-waves grow cooler,

25

Or ever hereafter he agony suffer

And troublous distress, while towereth upward

The handsomest of houses high on the summit.”

Bestriding his stallion, the strand-
watchman answered,

The doughty retainer: “The difference
surely

The coast-
guard reminds
Beowulf that it
is easier to say
than to do.

30

'Twixt words and works, the warlike shield-bearer

Who judgeth wisely well shall determine.

This band, I hear, beareth no malice

To the prince of the Scyldings. Pass ye
then onward

With weapons and armor. I shall lead
you in person;

I am satisfied
of your good
intentions, and
shall lead you
to the palace.

35

To my war-trusty vassals command I shall issue

To keep from all injury your excellent vessel,

Your fresh-tarred craft, 'gainst every
opposer

Close by the sea-shore, till the curved-
neckèd bark shall

Your boat shall
be well cared
for during your
stay here.

Waft back again the well-beloved hero

40

O'er the way of the water to Weder dominions.

To warrior so great 'twill be granted
sure

He again
compliments
Beowulf.

In the storm of strife to stand secure."

Onward they fared then (the vessel lay quiet,

The broad-bosomed bark was bound by its cable,

45

Firmly at anchor); the boar-signs glistened²

Bright on the visors vivid with gilding,

Blaze-hardened, brilliant; the boar acted warden.

The heroes hastened, hurried the liegemen,

Descended together, till they saw the
great palace,

The land is
perhaps
rolling.

50

The well-fashioned wassail-hall wondrous and
gleaming:

'Mid world-folk and kindreds that was
widest reputed

Heorot flashes
on their view.

Of halls under heaven which the hero abode in;

Its lustre enlightened lands without number.

Then the battle-brave hero showed them the
glittering

55

Court of the bold ones, that they easily thither

Might fare on their journey; the aforementioned
warrior

Turning his courser, quoth as he left them:

"'Tis time I were faring; Father
Almighty

The coast-
guard, having
discharged his
duty, bids them
God-speed.

Grant you His grace, and give you to
journey

60

Safe on your mission! To the sea I will get me

'Gainst hostile warriors as warden to stand."

- [1] 'Edwendan' (280) B. takes to be the subs. 'edwenden' (cf. 1775); and 'bisigu' he takes as gen. sing., limiting 'edwenden': *If reparation for sorrows is ever to come*. This is supported by t.B.
- [2] Combining the emendations of B. and t.B., we may read: *The boar-images glistened ... brilliant, protected the life of the war-mooded man*. They read 'ferh-wearde' (305) and 'gúðmódgum men' (306).

VI.

BEOWULF INTRODUCES HIMSELF AT THE PALACE.

The highway glistened with many-hued pebble,
A by-path led the liegemen together.

¹Firm and hand-locked the war-burnie glistened,
The ring-sword radiant rang 'mid the armor

5

As the party was approaching the palace together
In warlike equipments. 'Gainst the wall They set their
 of the building arms and
Their wide-fashioned war-shields they armor against
 weary did set then, the wall.

Battle-shields sturdy; benchward they turned then;
Their battle-sarks rattled, the gear of the heroes;

10

The lances stood up then, all in a cluster,
The arms of the seamen, ashen-shafts mounted
With edges of iron: the armor-clad troopers

Were decked with weapons. Then a A Danish hero
 proud-mooded hero asks them
Asked of the champions questions of whence and
 lineage: why they are
 come.

15

“From what borders bear ye your battle-shields
 plated,
Gilded and gleaming, your gray-colored burnies,
Helmets with visors and heap of war-lances?—
To Hrothgar the king I am servant and liegeman.
'Mong folk from far-lands found I have never

20

Men so many of mien more
courageous.
I ween that from valor, nowise as
outlaws,
But from greatness of soul ye sought for King
Hrothgar.”

He expresses
no little
admiration for
the strangers.

Then the strength-famous earlman
answer rendered,
The proud-mooded Wederchief replied to his
question,

Beowulf
replies.

25
Hardy 'neath helmet: “Higelac’s mates
are we;
Beowulf hight I. To the bairn of
Healfdene,
The famous folk-leader, I freely will
tell

We are
Higelac’s
table-
companions,
and bear an
important
commission to
your prince.

To thy prince my commission, if pleasantly hearing
He’ll grant we may greet him so gracious to all
men.”

30
Wulfgar replied then (he was prince of the Wendels,
His boldness of spirit was known unto many,
His prowess and prudence): “The prince of the
Scyldings,

The friend-lord of Danemen, I will ask
of thy journey,
The giver of rings, as thou urgest me
do it,

Wulfgar, the
thane, says that
he will go and
ask Hrothgar
whether he will
see the
strangers.

35
The folk-chief famous, and inform thee
early

What answer the good one mindeth to render me.”
He turned then hurriedly where Hrothgar was sitting,

²Old and hoary, his earlmen attending him;

The strength-famous went till he stood at the
shoulder

40

Of the lord of the Danemen, of courteous thanemen
The custom he minded. Wulfgar addressed then
His friendly liegelord: "Folk of the Geatmen

O'er the way of the waters are wafted
hither,

Faring from far-lands: the foremost in
rank

He thereupon
urges his
liegelord to
receive the
visitors
courteously.

45

The battle-champions Beowulf title.

They make this petition: with thee, O my chieftain,
To be granted a conference; O gracious King
Hrothgar,

Friendly answer refuse not to give them!

In war-trappings weeded worthy they
seem

Hrothgar, too,
is struck with
Beowulf's
appearance.

50

Of earls to be honored; sure the
atheling is doughty

Who headed the heroes hitherward coming."

[1] Instead of the punctuation given by H.-So, S. proposed to insert a comma after 'scír' (322), and to take 'hring-íren' as meaning 'ring-mail' and as parallel with 'gúð-byrne.' The passage would then read: *The firm and hand-locked war-burnie shone, bright ring-mail, rang 'mid the armor, etc.*

[2] Gr. and others translate 'unhár' by 'bald'; *old and bald*.

VII.

HROTHGAR AND BEOWULF.

Hrothgar answered, helm of the
Scyldings:

“I remember this man as the merest of
striplings.

His father long dead now was
Ecgtheow titled,

Him Hrethel the Geatman granted at home his

5

One only daughter; his battle-brave son

Is come but now, sought a trustworthy friend.

Seafaring sailors asserted it then,

Who valuable gift-gems of the
Geatmen¹ carried

As peace-offering thither, that he thirty
men’s grapple

10

Has in his hand, the hero-in-battle.

The holy Creator usward sent him,

To West-Dane warriors, I ween, for to
render

’Gainst Grendel’s grimness gracious assistance:

I shall give to the good one gift-gems for courage.

15

Hasten to bid them hither to speed them,²

To see assembled this circle of kinsmen;

Tell them expressly they’re welcome in sooth to

The men of the Danes.” To the door of the building

Wulfgar went then, this word-message
shouted:

Hrothgar
remembers
Beowulf as a
youth, and also
remembers his
father.

Beowulf is
reported to
have the
strength of
thirty men.

God hath sent
him to our
rescue.

Wulfgar invites
the strangers
in.

20

“My victorious liegeland bade me to tell you,
The East-Danes’ atheling, that your origin knows he,
And o’er wave-billows wafted ye welcome are
hither,

Valiant of spirit. Ye straightway may enter
Clad in corslets, cased in your helmets,

25

To see King Hrothgar. Here let your battle-boards,
Wood-spears and war-shafts, await your conferring.”
The mighty one rose then, with many a liegeman,
An excellent thane-group; some there did await
them,

And as bid of the brave one the battle-gear guarded.

30

Together they hied them, while the hero did guide
them,

’Neath Heorot’s roof; the high-minded went then
Sturdy ’neath helmet till he stood in the building.

Beowulf spake (his burnie did glisten,

His armor seamed over by the art of the craftsman):

35

“Hail thou, Hrothgar! I am Higelac’s
kinsman

And vassal forsooth; many a wonder

I dared as a stripling. The doings of
Grendel,

Beowulf
salutes
Hrothgar, and
then proceeds
to boast of his
youthful
achievements.

In far-off fatherland I fully did know of:

Sea-farers tell us, this hall-building standeth,

40

Excellent edifice, empty and useless

To all the earlmen after evenlight’s glimmer

’Neath heaven’s bright hues hath hidden its glory.

To bear a blade or a broad-fashioned target, A shield to the onset; only with hand-grip The foe I must grapple, fight for my life then, Foeman with foeman; he fain must rely on The doom of the Lord whom death layeth hold of.	I, too, shall disdain to use any.
70 I ween he will wish, if he win in the struggle, To eat in the war-hall earls of the Geat- folk, Boldly to swallow ⁴ them, as of yore he did often The best of the Hrethmen! Thou needest not trouble A head-watch to give me; ⁵ he will have me dripping	Should he crush me, he will eat my companions as he has eaten thy thanes.
75 And dreary with gore, if death overtake me, ⁶ Will bear me off bleeding, biting and mouthing me, The hermit will eat me, heedless of pity, Marking the moor-fens; no more wilt thou need then Find me my food. ⁷ If I fall in the battle,	In case of my defeat, thou wilt not have the trouble of burying me.
80 Send to Higelac the armor that serveth To shield my bosom, the best of equipments, Richest of ring-mails; 'tis the relic of Hrethla, The work of Wayland. Goes Weird as she must go!"	Should I fall, send my armor to my lord, King Higelac. Weird is supreme

[1] Some render 'gif-sceattas' by 'tribute.'—'Géata' B. and Th. emended to 'Géatum.' If this be accepted, change 'of the Geatmen' to 'to the Geatmen.'

[2] If t.B.'s emendation of vv. 386, 387 be accepted, the two lines, 'Hasten ... kinsmen' will read: *Hasten thou, bid the throng of*

kinsmen go into the hall together.

- [3] For 420 (b) and 421 (a), B. suggests: *Þær ic (on) fífelgeban ýðde eotena cyn = where I in the ocean destroyed the eoten-race.*—t.B. accepts B.'s "brilliant" 'fífelgeban,' omits 'on,' emends 'cyn' to 'hám,' arranging: *Þær ic fífelgeban ýðde, eotena hám = where I desolated the ocean, the home of the eotens.*—This would be better but for changing 'cyn' to 'hám.'—I suggest: *Þær ic fífelgeband* (cf. nhd. *Bande*) *ýðde, eotena cyn = where I conquered the monster band, the race of the eotens.* This makes no change except to read 'fífel' for 'fífe.'
- [4] 'Unforhte' (444) is much disputed.—H.-So. wavers between adj. and adv. Gr. and B. take it as an adv. modifying *etan*: *Will eat the Geats fearlessly.*—Kl. considers this reading absurd, and proposes 'anforhte' = timid.—Understanding 'unforhte' as an adj. has this advantage, viz. that it gives a parallel to 'Geátena leóde': but to take it as an adv. is more natural. Furthermore, to call the Geats 'brave' might, at this point, seem like an implied thrust at the Danes, so long helpless; while to call his own men 'timid' would be befouling his own nest.
- [5] For 'head-watch,' cf. H.-So. notes and cf. v. 2910.—Th. translates: *Thou wilt not need my head to hide* (i.e., thou wilt have no occasion to bury me, as Grendel will devour me whole).—Simrock imagines a kind of dead-watch.—Dr. H. Wood suggests: *Thou wilt not have to bury so much as my head* (for Grendel will be a thorough undertaker),—grim humor.
- [6] S. proposes a colon after 'nimeð' (l. 447). This would make no essential change in the translation.
- [7] Owing to the vagueness of 'feorme' (451), this passage is variously translated. In our translation, H.-So.'s glossary has been quite closely followed. This agrees substantially with B.'s translation (P. and B. XII. 87). R. translates: *Thou needst not take care longer as to the consumption of my dead body.* 'Líc' is also a crux here, as it may mean living body or dead body.

VIII.

HROTHGAR AND BEOWULF.— *Continued.*

Hrothgar discoursed, helm of the
Scyldings:

Hrothgar
responds.

“To defend our folk and to furnish assistance,¹
Thou soughtest us hither, good friend Beowulf.

The fiercest of feuds thy father
engaged in,

Reminiscences
of Beowulf’s
father,
Ecgtheow.

5

Heatholaf killed he in hand-to-hand
conflict

’Mid Wilfingish warriors; then the Wederish people
For fear of a feud were forced to disown him.

Thence flying he fled to the folk of the South-Danes,
The race of the Scyldings, o’er the roll of the waters;

10

I had lately begun then to govern the Danemen,
The hoard-seat of heroes held in my youth,
Rich in its jewels: dead was Heregar,
My kinsman and elder had earth-joys forsaken,
Healfdene his bairn. He was better than I am!

15

That feud thereafter for a fee I compounded;
O’er the weltering waters to the Wilfings I sent
Ornaments old; oaths did he swear me.

It pains me in spirit to any to tell it,
What grief in Heorot Grendel hath
caused me,

Hrothgar
recounts to
Beowulf the
horrors of
Grendel’s
persecutions.

20

What horror unlooked-for, by hatred unceasing.
Waned is my war-band, wasted my hall-troop;
Weird hath offcast them to the clutches of Grendel.
God can easily hinder the scather
From deeds so direful. Oft drunken with beer

25

O'er the ale-vessel promised warriors
in armor

My thanes
have made
many boasts,
but have not
executed them.

They would willingly wait on the
wassailing-benches

A grapple with Grendel, with grimmest of edges.
Then this mead-hall at morning with murder was
reeking,

The building was bloody at breaking of daylight,

30

The bench-deals all flooded, dripping and bloodied,
The folk-hall was gory: I had fewer retainers,
Dear-beloved warriors, whom death had laid hold of.

Sit at the feast now, thy intents unto
heroes,²

Sit down to the
feast, and give
us comfort.

Thy victor-fame show, as thy spirit
doth urge thee!"

35

For the men of the Geats then together
assembled,

A bench is
made ready for
Beowulf and
his party.

In the beer-hall blithesome a bench
was made ready;

There warlike in spirit they went to be seated,
Proud and exultant. A liegeman did service,
Who a beaker embellished bore with decorum,

40

And gleaming-drink poured. The
gleeman sang whilom

The gleeman
sings

The heroes all
rejoice

Hearty in Heorot; there was heroes' together.
rejoicing,
A numerous war-band of Weders and Danemen.

- [1] B. and S. reject the reading given in H.-So., and suggested by Grtvg. B. suggests for 457-458:

wáere-ryhtum þú, wine mín Béowulf,
and for ár-stafum úsic sóhtest.

This means: *From the obligations of clientage, my friend Beowulf, and for assistance thou hast sought us.*—This gives coherence to Hrothgar's opening remarks in VIII., and also introduces a new motive for Beowulf's coming to Hrothgar's aid.

- [2] *Sit now at the feast, and disclose thy purposes to the victorious heroes, as thy spirit urges.*—Kl. reaches the above translation by erasing the comma after 'meoto' and reading 'sige-hrèðsecgum.'—There are other and bolder emendations and suggestions. Of these the boldest is to regard 'meoto' as a verb (imperative), and read 'on sæl': *Think upon gayety, etc.*—All the renderings are unsatisfactory, the one given in our translation involving a zeugma.

IX.

UNFERTH TAUNTS BEOWULF.

Unferth spoke up, Ecglaf his son,
Who sat at the feet of the lord of the
Scyldings,
Opened the jousting (the journey¹ of
Beowulf,

Unferth, a
thane of
Hrothgar, is
jealous of
Beowulf, and
undertakes to
twit him.

Sea-farer doughty, gave sorrow to Unferth

5

And greatest chagrin, too, for granted he never
That any man else on earth should attain to,
Gain under heaven, more glory than he):

“Art thou that Beowulf with Breca did
struggle,
On the wide sea-currents at swimming
contended,

Did you take
part in a
swimming-
match with
Breca?

10

Where to humor your pride the ocean ye tried,
From vainest vaunting adventured your
bodies

In care of the waters? And no one was
able

'Twas mere
folly that
actuated you
both to risk
your lives on
the ocean.

Nor lief nor loth one, in the least to
dissuade you

Your difficult voyage; then ye ventured a-swimming,

15

Where your arms outstretching the streams ye did
cover,

The mere-ways measured, mixing and stirring them,
Glided the ocean; angry the waves were,

With the weltering of winter. In the water's
possession,
Ye toiled for a seven-night; he at swimming outdid
thee,

20

In strength excelled thee. Then early at morning
On the Heathoremes' shore the holm-currents tossed
him,
Sought he thenceward the home of his fathers,
Beloved of his liegemen, the land of the Brondings,
The peace-castle pleasant, where a people he
wielded,

25

Had borough and jewels. The pledge that he made
thee

The son of Beanstan hath soothly
accomplished.

Breca outdid
you entirely.

Then I ween thou wilt find thee less fortunate issue,
Though ever triumphant in onset of
battle,
A grim grappling, if Grendel thou
darest

Much more
will Grendel
outdo you, if
you vie with
him in
prowess.

30

For the space of a night near-by to wait for!"

Beowulf answered, offspring of
Ecgtheow:

Beowulf
retaliates.

"My good friend Unferth, sure freely and wildly,
Thou fuddled with beer of Breca hast
spoken,

Hast told of his journey! A fact I allege
it,

O friend
Unferth, you
are fuddled
with beer, and
cannot talk
coherently.

35

That greater strength in the waters I had then,
Ills in the ocean, than any man else had.
We made agreement as the merest of striplings

Promised each other (both of us then were	
Younkers in years) that we yet would	We simply
adventure	kept an
40	engagement
	made in early
Out on the ocean; it all we	life.
accomplished.	
While swimming the sea-floods, sword-blade	
unscabbarded	
Boldly we brandished, our bodies expected	
To shield from the sharks. He sure was unable	
To swim on the waters further than I	He <i>could</i> not
could,	excel me, and I
45	<i>would</i> not
	excel him.
More swift on the waves, nor <i>would</i> I	
from him go.	
Then we two companions stayed in the ocean	
Five nights together, till the currents	After five days
did part us,	the currents
The weltering waters, weathers the	separated us.
bleakest,	
And nethermost night, and the north-wind whistled	
50	
Fierce in our faces; fell were the billows.	
The mere fishes' mood was mightily ruffled:	
And there against foemen my firm-knotted corslet,	
Hand-jointed, hardy, help did afford me;	
My battle-sark braided, brilliantly gilded,	
55	A horrible sea-
Lay on my bosom. To the bottom then	beast attacked
dragged me,	me, but I slew
A hateful fiend-scather, seized me and	him.
held me,	
Grim in his grapple: 'twas granted me, nathless,	
To pierce the monster with the point of my weapon,	
My obedient blade; battle offcarried	

The mighty mere-creature by means of my hand-
blow.

[1] It has been plausibly suggested that ‘síð’ (in 501 and in 353) means ‘arrival.’ If so, translate the bracket: *(the arrival of Beowulf, the brave seafarer, was a source of great chagrin to Unferth, etc.)*.

X.

**BEOWULF SILENCES
UNFERTH.—GLEE IS HIGH.**

"So ill-meaning enemies often did cause me
Sorrow the sorest. I served them, in quittance,
With my dear-lovèd sword, as in sooth My dear sword
 it was fitting; always served
They missed the pleasure of feasting me faithfully.
 abundantly,

5
Ill-doers evil, of eating my body,
Of surrounding the banquet deep in the ocean;
But wounded with edges early at morning
They were stretched a-high on the strand of the
ocean,

Put to sleep with the sword, that sea-
going travelers

10 I put a stop to
the outrages of
the sea-
monsters.

No longer thereafter were hindered
from sailing
The foam-dashing currents. Came a light from the
east,

God's beautiful beacon; the billows subsided,
That well I could see the nesses projecting,
The blustering crags. Weird often Fortune helps
sayeth the brave earl.

15
The undoomed hero if doughty his valor!
But me did it fortune¹ to fell with my weapon
Nine of the nickers. Of night-struggle harder
'Neath dome of the heaven heard I but rarely,

Nor of wight more woful in the waves of the ocean;

20

Yet I 'scaped with my life the grip of the monsters,

Weary from travel. Then the waters

bare me

After that
escape I drifted
to Finland.

To the land of the Finns, the flood with
the current,

The weltering waves. Not a word hath
been told me

I have never
heard of your
doing any such
bold deeds.

Of deeds so daring done by thee,
Unferth,

25

And of sword-terror none; never hath Breca

At the play of the battle, nor either of you two,

Feat so fearless performèd with weapons

Glinting and gleaming

. I utter no boasting;

30

Though with cold-blooded cruelty thou
killedst thy brothers,

You are a
slayer of
brothers, and
will suffer
damnation,
wise as you
may be.

Thy nearest of kin; thou needs must in
hell get

Direful damnation, though doughty thy
wisdom.

I tell thee in earnest, offspring of Ecglaf,

Never had Grendel such numberless horrors,

35

The direful demon, done to thy liegelord,

Harrying in Heorot, if thy heart were as sturdy,

Thy mood as ferocious as thou dost
describe them.

Had your acts
been as brave
as your words,
Grendel had
not ravaged
your land so
long.

He hath found out fully that the fierce-
burning hatred,

The edge-battle eager, of all of your
kindred,

40

Of the Victory-Scyldings, need little dismay him:

Oaths he exacteth, not any he spares

Of the folk of the Danemen, but

fighteth with pleasure,

Killeth and feasteth, no contest

expecteth

From Spear-Danish people. But the

prowess and valor

45

Of the earls of the Geatmen early shall

venture

To give him a grapple. He shall go who is able

Bravely to banquet, when the bright-light of morning

Which the second day bringeth, the sun

in its ether-robes,

O'er children of men shines from the

southward!"

50

Then the gray-haired, war-famed giver of treasure

Was blithesome and joyous, the Bright-

Danish ruler

Expected assistance; the people's

protector

Heard from Beowulf his bold

resolution.

There was laughter of heroes; loud was

the clatter,

55

The words were winsome. Wealhtheow advanced

then,

Consort of Hrothgar, of courtesy

mindful,

Gold-decked saluted the men in the

building,

The monster is
not afraid of
the Danes,

but he will
soon learn to
dread the
Geats.

On the second
day, any
warrior may go
unmolested to
the mead-
banquet.

Hrothgar's
spirits are
revived.

The old king
trusts Beowulf.
The heroes are
joyful.

Queen
Wealhtheow
plays the
hostess.

And the freeborn woman the beaker presented
To the lord of the kingdom, first of the East-Danes,
60

She offers the
cup to her
husband first.

Bade him be blithesome when beer was a-flowing,
Lief to his liegemen; he lustily tasted
Of banquet and beaker, battle-famed ruler.
The Helmingish lady then graciously circled
'Mid all the liegemen lesser and greater:

65
Treasure-cups tendered, till time was
afforded

She gives
presents to the
heroes.

That the decorous-mooded, diademed folk-queen
Might bear to Beowulf the bumper
o'errunning;
She greeted the Geat-prince, God she
did thank,

Then she offers
the cup to
Beowulf,
thanking God
that aid has
come.

Most wise in her words, that her wish
was accomplished,

70

That in any of earlmen she ever should look for
Solace in sorrow. He accepted the beaker,
Battle-bold warrior, at Wealhtheow's giving,
Then equipped for combat quoth he in
measures,

Beowulf spake, offspring of Ecgtheow:

Beowulf states
to the queen
the object of
his visit.

75

"I purposed in spirit when I mounted the ocean,
When I boarded my boat with a band
of my liegemen,

I determined to
do or die.

I would work to the fullest the will of your people
Or in foe's-clutches fastened fall in the battle.
Deeds I shall do of daring and prowess,

80

Or the last of my life-days live in this mead-hall.”
These words to the lady were welcome and pleasing,
The boast of the Geatman; with gold trappings
 broidered
Went the freeborn folk-queen her fond-lord to sit by.
Then again as of yore was heard in the Glee is high.
 building

85

Courtly discussion, conquerors’ shouting,
Heroes were happy, till Healfdene’s son would
Go to his slumber to seek for refreshing;
For the horrid hell-monster in the hall-building knew
 he
A fight was determined,² since the light of the sun
 they

90

No longer could see, and lowering darkness
O’er all had descended, and dark under heaven
Shadowy shapes came shying around them.
The liegemen all rose then. One saluted Hrothgar
 the other, retires, leaving
Hrothgar Beowulf, in rhythmical Beowulf in
 measures, charge of the
 hall.

95

Wishing him well, and, the wassail-hall giving
To his care and keeping, quoth he departing:
“Not to any one else have I ever entrusted,
But thee and thee only, the hall of the Danemen,
Since high I could heave my hand and my buckler.

100

Take thou in charge now the noblest of houses;
Be mindful of honor, exhibiting prowess,
Watch ’gainst the foeman! Thou shalt want no
 enjoyments,

Survive thou safely adventure so glorious!”

- [1] The repetition of ‘hwæðere’ (574 and 578) is regarded by some scholars as a defect. B. suggests ‘swá þær’ for the first: *So there it befell me, etc.* Another suggestion is to change the second ‘hwæðere’ into ‘swá þær’: *So there I escaped with my life, etc.*
- [2] Kl. suggests a period after ‘determined.’ This would give the passage as follows: *Since they no longer could see the light of the sun, and lowering darkness was down over all, dire under the heavens shadowy beings came going around them.*

XI.

ALL SLEEP SAVE ONE.

Then Hrothgar departed, his earl-
throng attending him,
Folk-lord of Scyldings, forth from the building;
The war-chieftain wished then Wealhtheow to look
for,

Hrothgar
retires.

The queen for a bedmate. To keep away Grendel

5

The Glory of Kings had given a hall-
watch,

God has
provided a
watch for the
hall.

As men heard recounted: for the king
of the Danemen

He did special service, gave the giant a watcher:

And the prince of the Geatmen implicitly trusted

His warlike strength and the Wielder's
protection.

Beowulf is
self-confident

10

His armor of iron off him he did then,

He prepares for
rest.

His helmet from his head, to his henchman
committed

His chased-handled chain-sword, choicest of
weapons,

And bade him bide with his battle-equipments.

The good one then uttered words of defiance,

15

Beowulf Geatman, ere his bed he upmounted:

"I hold me no meaner in matters of
prowess,

Beowulf boasts
of his ability to
cope with
Grendel.

In warlike achievements, than Grendel
does himself;

Hence I seek not with sword-edge to sooth him to
slumber,

Of life to bereave him, though well I am able.

20

No battle-skill¹ has he, that blows he
should strike me,

We will fight
with nature's
weapons only.

To shatter my shield, though sure he is mighty
In strife and destruction; but struggling by night we
Shall do without edges, dare he to look for
Weaponless warfare, and wise-mooded Father

25

The glory apportion, God ever-holy,
On which hand soever to him seemeth
proper.”

God may
decide who
shall conquer

Then the brave-mooded hero bent to
his slumber,

The pillow received the cheek of the noble;

And many a martial mere-thane
attending

The Geatish
warriors lie
down.

30

Sank to his slumber. Seemed it unlikely
That ever thereafter any should hope to
Be happy at home, hero-friends visit
Or the lordly troop-castle where he
lived from his childhood;

They thought it
very unlikely
that they
should ever see
their homes
again.

They had heard how slaughter had
snatched from the wine-hall,

35

Had recently ravished, of the race of the Scyldings

Too many by far. But the Lord to them
granted

But God raised
up a deliverer.

The weaving of war-speed, to Wederish heroes
Aid and comfort, that every opponent

By one man's war-might they worsted and
vanquished,

40

God rules the
world.

By the might of himself; the truth is
established

That God Almighty hath governed for ages
Kindreds and nations. A night very lurid

The trav'ler-at-twilight came tramping
and striding.

Grendel comes
to Heorot.

The warriors were sleeping who should watch the
horned-building,

45

Only one
warrior is
awake.

One only excepted. 'Mid earthmen
'twas 'stablished,

Th' implacable foeman was powerless to hurl them
To the land of shadows, if the Lord were unwilling;
But serving as warder, in terror to foemen,
He angrily bided the issue of battle.²

[1] Gr. understood 'gódra' as meaning 'advantages in battle.' This rendering H.-So. rejects. The latter takes the passage as meaning that Grendel, though mighty and formidable, has no skill in the art of war.

[2] B. in his masterly articles on Beowulf (P. and B. XII.) rejects the division usually made at this point, 'Ðá.' (711), usually rendered 'then,' he translates 'when,' and connects its clause with the foregoing sentence. These changes he makes to reduce the number of 'cóm's' as principal verbs. (Cf. 703, 711, 721.) With all deference to this acute scholar, I must say that it seems to me that the poet is exhausting his resources to bring out clearly the supreme event on which the whole subsequent action turns. First, he (Grendel) came *in the wan night*; second, he came *from the moor*; third, he came *to the hall*. Time, place from which, place to which, are all given.

XII.

GRENDEL AND BEOWULF.

'Neath the cloudy cliffs came from the
moor then

Grendel comes
from the fens.

Grendel going, God's anger bare he.
The monster intended some one of earthmen
In the hall-building grand to entrap and make way
with:

5

He went under welkin where well he
knew of

He goes
towards the
joyous
building.

The wine-joyous building, brilliant
with plating,

Gold-hall of earthmen. Not the earliest occasion

He the home and manor of Hrothgar
had sought:

This was not
his first visit
there.

Ne'er found he in life-days later nor
earlier

10

Hardier hero, hall-thanes¹ more sturdy!

Then came to the building the warrior marching,

Bereft of his joyance. The door quickly
opened

His horrid
fingers tear the
door open.

On fire-hinges fastened, when his
fingers had touched it;

The fell one had flung then—his fury so bitter—

15

Open the entrance. Early thereafter

The foeman trod the shining hall-pavement,

Strode he angrily; from the eyes of him
glimmered

He strides
furiously into
the hall.

A lustre unlovely likest to fire.

He beheld in the hall the heroes in numbers,

20

A circle of kinsmen sleeping together,

A throng of thanemen: then his

thoughts were exultant,

He exults over
his supposed
prey.

He minded to sunder from each of the

thanemen

The life from his body, horrible demon,

Ere morning came, since fate had allowed him

25

The prospect of plenty. Providence

willed not

Fate has
decreed that he
shall devour no
more heroes.
Beowulf
suffers from
suspense.

To permit him any more of men under

heaven

To eat in the night-time. Higelac's

kinsman

Great sorrow endured how the dire-mooded creature

In unlooked-for assaults were likely to bear him.

30

No thought had the monster of deferring the matter,

But on earliest occasion he quickly laid

hold of

Grendel
immediately
seizes a
sleeping
warrior, and
devours him.

A soldier asleep, suddenly tore him,

Bit his bone-prison, the blood drank in

currents,

Swallowed in mouthfuls: he soon had the dead

man's

35

Feet and hands, too, eaten entirely.

Nearer he strode then, the stout-hearted warrior

Snatched as he slumbered, seizing with

hand-grip,

Beowulf and
Grendel
grapple.

Forward the foeman foined with his

hand;

Caught he quickly the cunning deviser,

40

On his elbow he rested. This early discovered
The master of malice, that in middle-earth's regions,
'Neath the whole of the heavens, no hand-grapple
greater

In any man else had he ever
encountered:

The monster is
amazed at
Beowulf's
strength.

Fearful in spirit, faint-mooded waxed
he,

45

Not off could betake him; death he was pondering,
Would fly to his covert, seek the devils' assembly:

He is anxious
to flee.

His calling no more was the same he had followed
Long in his lifetime. The liege-kinsman worthy
Of Higelac minded his speech of the
evening,

Beowulf
recalls his
boast of the
evening, and
determines to
fulfil it.

50

Stood he up straight and stoutly did
seize him.

His fingers crackled; the giant was outward,
The earl stepped farther. The famous one minded
To flee away farther, if he found an occasion,
And off and away, avoiding delay,

55

To fly to the fen-moors; he fully was ware of
The strength of his grapple in the grip of the foeman.

'Twas an ill-taken journey that the
injury-bringing,

'Twas a
luckless day
for Grendel.

Harrying harmer to Heorot wandered:

The palace re-echoed; to all of the
Danemen,

The hall
groans.

60

Dwellers in castles, to each of the bold ones,

Earlmen, was terror. Angry they both were,
Archwarders raging.² Rattled the building;
'Twas a marvellous wonder that the wine-hall
withstood then

The bold-in-battle, bent not to earthward,

65

Excellent earth-hall; but within and without it
Was fastened so firmly in fetters of iron,
By the art of the armorer. Off from the sill there
Bent mead-benches many, as men have informed
me,

Adorned with gold-work, where the grim ones did
struggle.

70

The Scylding wise men weened ne'er before
That by might and main-strength a man under
heaven

Might break it in pieces, bone-decked, resplendent,
Crush it by cunning, unless clutch of the fire
In smoke should consume it. The sound mounted
upward

75

Novel enough; on the North Danes
fastened

Grendel's cries
terrify the
Danes.

A terror of anguish, on all of the men there
Who heard from the wall the weeping and plaining,
The song of defeat from the foeman of heaven,
Heard him hymns of horror howl, and his sorrow

80

Hell-bound bewailing. He held him too firmly
Who was strongest of main-strength of men of that
era.

[1] B. and t.B. emend so as to make lines 9 and 10 read: *Never in his life, earlier or later, had he, the hell-thane, found a braver hero.*—

They argue that Beowulf's companions had done nothing to merit such encomiums as the usual readings allow them.

- [2] For 'réðe rén-weardas' (771), t.B. suggests 'réðe, rénhearde.'
Translate: *They were both angry, raging and mighty.*

XIII.

GRENDL IS VANQUISHED.

For no cause whatever would the
earlmen's defender

Leave in life-joys the loathsome
newcomer,

Beowulf has
no idea of
letting Grendel
live.

He deemed his existence utterly useless
To men under heaven. Many a noble

5

Of Beowulf brandished his battle-sword old,
Would guard the life of his lord and protector,
The far-famous chieftain, if able to do so;
While waging the warfare, this wist they but little,
Brave battle-thanes, while his body intending

10

To slit into slivers, and seeking his
spirit:

No weapon
would harm
Grendel; he
bore a charmed
life.

That the relentless foeman nor finest of
weapons

Of all on the earth, nor any of war-bills
Was willing to injure; but weapons of victory
Swords and suchlike he had sworn to dispense with.

15

His death at that time must prove to be wretched,
And the far-away spirit widely should journey
Into enemies' power. This plainly he saw then
Who with mirth¹ of mood malice no little
Had wrought in the past on the race of the earthmen

20

(To God he was hostile), that his body would fail
him,

But Higelac's hardy henchman and kinsman	
Held him by the hand; hateful to other	
Was each one if living. A body-wound	Grendel is
suffered	sorely
The direful demon, damage incurable	wounded.
25	
Was seen on his shoulder, his sinews	His body
were shivered,	bursts.
His body did burst. To Beowulf was given	
Glory in battle; Grendel from thenceward	
Must flee and hide him in the fen-cliffs and marshes,	
Sick unto death, his dwelling must look for	
30	
Unwinsome and woful; he wist the more fully	
The end of his earthly existence was	The monster
nearing,	flees away to
His life-days' limits. At last for the	hide in the
Danemen,	moors.
When the slaughter was over, their wish was	
accomplished.	
The comer-from-far-land had cleansed then of evil,	
35	
Wise and valiant, the war-hall of Hrothgar,	
Saved it from violence. He joyed in the night-work,	
In repute for prowess; the prince of the Geatmen	
For the East-Danish people his boast had	
accomplished,	
Bettered their burdensome bale-sorrows fully,	
40	
The craft-begot evil they erstwhile had suffered	
And were forced to endure from crushing	
oppression,	
Their manifold misery. 'Twas a manifest token,	
	Beowulf
	suspends

When the hero-in-battle the hand
suspended,

Grendel's hand
and arm in
Heorot.

The arm and the shoulder (there was all
of the claw

45

Of Grendel together) 'neath great-stretching hall-
roof.

[1] It has been proposed to translate 'myrðe' by *with sorrow*; but there seems no authority for such a rendering. To the present translator, the phrase 'módes myrðe' seems a mere padding for *gladly*; i.e., *he who gladly harassed mankind*.

XIV.

REJOICING OF THE DANES.

In the mist of the morning many a warrior Stood round the gift-hall, as the story is told me: Folk-princes fared then from far and from near	At early dawn, warriors from far and near come together to hear of the night's adventures.
---	--

Through long-stretching journeys to look at the
wonder,

5

The footprints of the foeman. Few of the warriors Who gazed on the foot-tracks of the inglorious creature His parting from life pained very deeply,	Few warriors lamented Grendel's destruction.
---	---

How, weary in spirit, off from those regions
In combats conquered he carried his traces,

10

Fated and flying, to the flood of the nickers.

There in bloody billows bubbled the currents,	Grendel's blood dyes the waters.
--	--

The angry eddy was everywhere
mingled

And seething with gore, welling with sword-blood;¹
He death-doomed had hid him, when reaved of his
joyance

15

He laid down his life in the lair he had fled to,
His heathenish spirit, where hell did receive him.
Thence the friends from of old backward turned
them,

And many a younker from merry adventure,
Striding their stallions, stout from the seaward,

20

Heroes on horses. There were heard very often

Beowulf's praises; many often asserted

Beowulf is the
hero of the
hour.

That neither south nor north, in the
circuit of waters,

O'er outstretching earth-plain, none
other was better

He is regarded
as a probable
successor to
Hrothgar.

'Mid bearers of war-shields, more
worthy to govern,

25

'Neath the arch of the ether. Not any, however,

'Gainst the friend-lord muttered, mocking-words
uttered

Of Hrothgar the gracious (a good king
he).

But no word is
uttered to
derogate from
the old king

Oft the famed ones permitted their
fallow-skinned horses

To run in rivalry, racing and chasing,

30

Where the fieldways appeared to them fair and
inviting,

Known for their excellence; oft athane of the folk-
lord,²

³A man of celebrity, mindful of
rhythms,

The gleeman
sings the deeds
of heroes.

Who ancient traditions treasured in
memory,

New word-groups found properly bound:

35

The bard after 'gan then Beowulf's venture

Wisely to tell of, and words that were
clever

He sings in
alliterative
measures of

To utter skilfully, earnestly speaking,

Everything told he that he heard as to
Sigmund's

Beowulf's
prowess.

Mighty achievements, many things
hidden,

Also of
Sigemund,
who has slain a
great fire-
dragon.

40

The strife of the Wælsing, the wide-
going ventures

The children of men knew of but little,

The feud and the fury, but Fitela with him,

When suchlike matters he minded to speak of,

Uncle to nephew, as in every contention

45

Each to other was ever devoted:

A numerous host of the race of the scathers

They had slain with the sword-edge. To Sigmund
accrued then

No little of glory, when his life-days were over,

Since he sturdy in struggle had destroyed the great
dragon,

50

The hoard-treasure's keeper; 'neath the hoar-grayish
stone he,

The son of the atheling, unaided adventured

The perilous project; not present was Fitela,

Yet the fortune befell him of forcing his weapon

Through the marvellous dragon, that it stood in the
wall,

55

Well-honored weapon; the worm was slaughtered.

The great one had gained then by his glorious
achievement

To reap from the ring-hoard richest enjoyment,

As best it did please him: his vessel he loaded,

Shining ornaments on the ship's bosom carried,

60

Kinsman of Wæls: the drake in heat melted.

He was farthest famed of fugitive
pilgrims,

Sigemund was
widely famed.

Mid wide-scattered world-folk, for works of great
prowess,

War-troopers' shelter: hence waxed he in honor.⁴

Afterward Heremod's hero-strength
failed him,

Heremod, an
unfortunate
Danish king, is
introduced by
way of
contrast.

65

His vigor and valor. 'Mid venomous
haters

To the hands of foemen he was foully delivered,
Offdriven early. Agony-billows

Oppressed him too long, to his people
he became then,

Unlike
Sigemund and
Beowulf,
Heremod was a
burden to his
people.

To all the athelings, an ever-great
burden;

70

And the daring one's journey in days of yore

Many wise men were wont to deplore,

Such as hoped he would bring them help in their
sorrow,

That the son of their ruler should rise into power,
Holding the headship held by his fathers,

75

Should govern the people, the gold-hoard and
borough,

The kingdom of heroes, the realm of the Scyldings.

He to all men became then far more
beloved,

Beowulf is an
honor to his
race.

Higelac's kinsman, to kindreds and
races,

To his friends much dearer; him malice assaulted.—

80

The story is
resumed.

Oft running and racing on roadsters they measured
The dun-colored highways. Then the light of the
morning

Was hurried and hastened. Went henchmen in
numbers

To the beautiful building, bold ones in spirit,
To look at the wonder; the liegelord himself then

85

From his wife-bower wending, warden of treasures,
Glorious trod with troopers unnumbered,
Famed for his virtues, and with him the queen-wife
Measured the mead-ways, with maidens attending.

- [1] S. emends, suggesting ‘déop’ for ‘déog,’ and removing semicolon after ‘wéol.’ The two half-lines ‘welling ... hid him’ would then read: *The bloody deep welled with sword-gore*. B. accepts ‘déop’ for ‘déog,’ but reads ‘déað-fæges’: *The deep boiled with the sword-gore of the death-doomed one*.
- [2] Another and quite different rendering of this passage is as follows:
Oft a liegeman of the king, a fame-covered man mindful of songs, who very many ancient traditions remembered (he found other word-groups accurately bound together) began afterward to tell of Beowulf’s adventure, skilfully to narrate it, etc.
- [3] Might ‘guma gilp-hladen’ mean ‘a man laden with boasts of the deeds of others’?
- [4] t.B. accepts B.’s ‘hé þæs áron þáh’ as given by H.-So., but puts a comma after ‘þáh,’ and takes ‘siððan’ as introducing a dependent clause: *He throve in honor since Heremod’s strength ... had decreased*.

XV.

HROTHGAR'S GRATITUDE.

Hrothgar discoursed (to the hall-building went he,
He stood by the pillar,¹ saw the steep-rising hall-roof
Gleaming with gold-gems, and Grendel his hand
there):

“For the sight we behold now, thanks
to the Wielder

Hrothgar gives
thanks for the
overthrow of
the monster.

5

Early be offered! Much evil I bided,
Snaring from Grendel:² God can e'er 'complish
Wonder on wonder, Wielder of Glory!

But lately I reckoned ne'er under
heaven

I had given up
all hope, when
this brave
liegeman came
to our aid.

Comfort to gain me for any of sorrows,

10

While the handsomest of houses horrid with
bloodstain

Gory uptowered; grief had offfrightened³

Each of the wise ones who weened not that ever
The folk-troop's defences 'gainst foes they should
strengthen,

'Gainst sprites and monsters. Through the might of
the Wielder

15

A doughty retainer hath a deed now accomplished
Which erstwhile we all with our excellent wisdom
Failed to perform. May affirm very
truly

If his mother
yet liveth, well
may she thank
God for this
son.

What woman soever in all of the
nations

Gave birth to the child, if yet she surviveth,

20

That the long-ruling Lord was lavish to herward

In the birth of the bairn. Now, Beowulf dear,

Most excellent hero, I'll love thee in

spirit

As bairn of my body; bear well

henceforward

Hereafter,
Beowulf, thou
shalt be my
son.

The relationship new. No lack shall befall thee

25

Of earth-joys any I ever can give thee.

Full often for lesser service I've given

Hero less hardy hoard-treasure precious,

To a weaker in war-strife. By works of

distinction

Thou hast won
immortal
distinction.

Thou hast gained for thyself now that

thy glory shall flourish

30

Forever and ever. The All-Ruler quite thee

With good from His hand as He hitherto did thee!"

Beowulf answered, Ecgtheow's

offspring:

"That labor of glory most gladly

achieved we,

Beowulf
replies: I was
most happy to
render thee this
service.

The combat accomplished, unquailing we ventured

35

The enemy's grapple; I would grant it much rather

Thou wert able to look at the creature in person,

Faint unto falling, the foe in his trappings!

On murder-bed quickly I minded to bind him,

With firm-holding fetters, that forced by my grapple

40

Low he should lie in life-and-death struggle

'Less his body escape; I was wholly unable,

Since God did not will it, to keep him
from going,
Not held him that firmly, hated
opposer;
Too swift was the foeman. Yet safety
regarding

I could not
keep the
monster from
escaping, as
God did not
will that I
should.

45

He suffered his hand behind him to linger,
His arm and shoulder, to act as watcher;
No shadow of solace the woe-begone
creature

He left his
hand and arm
behind.

Found him there nathless: the hated
destroyer

Liveth no longer, lashed for his evils,

50

But sorrow hath seized him, in snare-meshes hath
him

Close in its clutches, keepeth him writhing

In baleful bonds: there banished for evil

The man shall wait for the mighty tribunal,

How the God of glory shall give him
his earnings.”

God will give
him his
deserts.

55

Then the soldier kept silent, son of old Ecglaf,

From boasting and bragging of battle-
achievements,

Since the princes beheld there the hand
that depended

Unferth has
nothing more
to say, for
Beowulf's
actions speak
louder than
words.

'Neath the lofty hall-timbers by the
might of the nobleman,

Each one before him, the enemy's fingers;

60

Each finger-nail strong steel most resembled,
The heathen one's hand-spur, the hero-in-battle's
Claw most uncanny; quoth they agreeing,

That not any excellent edges of brave
ones

No sword will
harm the
monster.

Was willing to touch him, the terrible
creature's

65

Battle-hand bloody to bear away from him.

[1] B. and t.B. read 'stapole,' and translate *stood on the floor*.

[2] For 'snaring from Grendel,' 'sorrows at Grendel's hands' has been suggested. This gives a parallel to 'láðes.' 'Grynna' may well be gen. pl. of 'gyrn,' by a scribal slip.

[3] The H.-So punctuation has been followed; but B. has been followed in understanding 'gehwylcne' as object of 'wíd-scofen (hæfde).' Gr. construes 'wéa' as nom abs.

XVI.

HROTHGAR LAVISHES GIFTS UPON HIS DELIVERER.

Then straight was ordered that Heorot
inside¹

Heorot is
adorned with
hands.

With hands be embellished: a host of
them gathered,

Of men and women, who the wassailing-building
The guest-hall be geared. Gold-flashing sparkled

5

Webs on the walls then, of wonders a many
To each of the heroes that look on such objects.

The beautiful building was broken to
pieces

The hall is
defaced,
however.

Which all within with irons was
fastened,

Its hinges torn off: only the roof was

10

Whole and uninjured when the horrible creature
Outlawed for evil off had betaken him,
Hopeless of living. 'Tis hard to avoid it

(Whoever will do it!); but he doubtless
must come to²

[A vague
passage of five
verses.]

The place awaiting, as Wyrd hath
appointed,

15

Soul-bearers, earth-dwellers, earls under heaven,
Where bound on its bed his body shall slumber

When feasting is finished. Full was the
time then

Hrothgar goes
to the banquet.

That the son of Healfdene went to the building;

The excellent atheling would eat of the banquet.

20

Ne'er heard I that people with hero-band larger
Bare them better tow'rds their bracelet-bestower.
The laden-with-glory stooped to the bench then
(Their kinsmen-companions in plenty were joyful,
Many a cupful quaffing complaisantly),

25

Doughty of spirit in the high-tow'ring palace,

Hrothgar and Hrothulf. Heorot then
inside

Hrothgar's
nephew,
Hrothulf, is
present.

Was filled with friendly ones;
falsehood and treachery

The Folk-Scyldings now nowise did practise.

Then the offspring of Healfdene
offered to Beowulf

Hrothgar
lavishes gifts
upon Beowulf.

30

A golden standard, as reward for the victory,
A banner embossed, burnie and helmet;
Many men saw then a song-famous weapon
Borne 'fore the hero. Beowulf drank of
The cup in the building; that treasure-bestowing

35

He needed not blush for in battle-men's presence.

Ne'er heard I that many men on the
ale-bench

Four
handsomer
gifts were
never
presented.

In friendlier fashion to their fellows
presented

Four bright jewels with gold-work embellished.

'Round the roof of the helmet a head-guarder outside

40

Braided with wires, with bosses was furnished,
That swords-for-the-battle fight-hardened might fail
Boldly to harm him, when the hero proceeded

Forth against foemen. The defender of
earls then

Commanded that eight steeds with
bridles

45

Gold-plated, gleaming, be guided to
hallward,

Inside the building; on one of them stood then
An art-broidered saddle embellished with jewels;
'Twas the sovereign's seat, when the son of King
Healfdene

Was pleased to take part in the play of the edges;

50

The famous one's valor ne'er failed at the front
when

Slain ones were bowing. And to Beowulf granted
The prince of the Ingwins, power over both,
O'er war-steeds and weapons; bade him well to
enjoy them.

In so manly a manner the mighty-famed chieftain,

55

Hoard-ward of heroes, with horses and jewels
War-storms requited, that none e'er condemneth
Who willeth to tell truth with full justice.

Hrothgar
commands that
eight finely
caparisoned
steeds be
brought to
Beowulf.

[1] Kl. suggests 'hroden' for 'háten,' and renders: *Then quickly was Heorot adorned within, with hands bedecked.*—B. suggests 'gefrætwon' instead of 'gefrætwod,' and renders: *Then was it commanded to adorn Heorot within quickly with hands.*—The former has the advantage of affording a parallel to 'gefrætwod': both have the disadvantage of altering the text.

[2] The passage 1005-1009 seems to be hopeless. One difficult point is to find a subject for 'gesacan.' Some say 'he'; others supply 'each,' i.e., *every soul-bearer ... must gain the inevitable place.* The genitives in this case are partitive.—If 'he' be subj., the genitives are dependent on 'gearwe' (= prepared).—The 'he' itself is disputed, some referring it to Grendel; but B. takes it as involved in the parenthesis.

XVII.

BANQUET (*continued*).—THE SCOP'S SONG OF FINN AND HNÆF.

And the atheling of earlmen to each of the heroes	Each of Beowulf's companions
Who the ways of the waters went with Beowulf,	receives a costly gift.
A costly gift-token gave on the mead-bench, Offered an heirloom, and ordered that that man	
5	The warrior
With gold should be paid for, whom	killed by
Grendel had erstwhile	Grendel is to
Wickedly slaughtered, as he more of	be paid for in
them had done	gold.
Had far-seeing God and the mood of the hero The fate not averted: the Father then governed All of the earth-dwellers, as He ever is doing;	
10	
Hence insight for all men is everywhere fittest, Forethought of spirit! much he shall suffer Of lief and of loathsome who long in this present Useth the world in this woful existence.	
There was music and merriment mingling together	
15	Hrothgar's
Touching Healfdene's leader; the joy-	scop recalls
wood was fingered,	events in the
Measures recited, when the singer of	reign of his
Hrothgar	lord's father.
On mead-bench should mention the merry hall- joyance	

Of the kinsmen of Finn, when onset surprised them:

“The Half-Danish hero, Hnæf of the
Scyldings,

20

On the field of the Frisians was fated to
perish.

Sure Hildeburg needed not mention
approving

The faith of the Jutemen: though blameless entirely,

When shields were shivered she was
shorn of her darlings,

Of bairns and brothers: they bent to
their fate

25

With war-spear wounded; woe was that
woman.

Not causeless lamented the daughter of Hoce

The decree of the Wielder when morning-light came
and

She was able 'neath heaven to behold the destruction
Of brothers and bairns, where the brightest of earth-
joys

30

She had hitherto had: all the henchmen
of Finn

War had oftaken, save a handful remaining,

That he nowise was able to offer resistance¹

To the onset of Hengest in the parley of
battle,

Nor the wretched remnant to rescue in
war from

35

The earl of the atheling; but they offered conditions,

Another great building to fully make
ready,

Hnæf, the
Danish
general, is
treacherously
attacked while
staying at
Finn's castle.

Queen
Hildeburg is
not only wife
of Finn, but a
kinswoman of
the murdered
Hnæf.

Finn's force is
almost
exterminated.

Hengest
succeeds Hnæf
as Danish
general.

Compact
between the

A hall and a high-seat, that half they Frisians and
might rule with the Danes.

The sons of the Jutemen, and that Folcwalda's son
would

Day after day the Danemen honor

40

When gifts were giving, and grant of his ring-store
To Hengest's earl-troop ever so freely,
Of his gold-plated jewels, as he encouraged the
Frisians

On the bench of the beer-hall. On both Equality of
sides they swore then gifts agreed on.

A fast-binding compact; Finn unto Hengest

45

With no thought of revoking vowed then most
solemnly

The woe-begone remnant well to take charge of,
His Witan advising; the agreement should no one
By words or works weaken and shatter,
By artifice ever injure its value,

50

Though reaved of their ruler their ring-giver's slayer
They followed as vassals, Fate so requiring:

Then if one of the Frisians the quarrel No one shall
should speak of refer to old
grudges.

In tones that were taunting, terrible
edges

Should cut in requital. Accomplished the oath was,

55

And treasure of gold from the hoard was uplifted.

The best of the Scylding braves was Danish
then fully warriors are
burned on a

Prepared for the pile; at the pyre was funeral-pyre.
seen clearly

The blood-gory burnie, the boar with his gilding,

The iron-hard swine, athelings many

60

Fatally wounded; no few had been slaughtered.

Hildeburg bade then, at the burning of Hnæf,

The bairn of her bosom to bear to the
fire,

Queen
Hildeburg has
her son burnt
along with
Hnæf.

That his body be burned and borne to
the pyre.

The woe-stricken woman wept on his shoulder,²

65

In measures lamented; upmounted the hero.³

The greatest of dead-fires curled to the welkin,

On the hill's-front crackled; heads were a-melting,

Wound-doors bursting, while the blood was a-
coursing

From body-bite fierce. The fire devoured them,

70

Greediest of spirits, whom war had offcarried

From both of the peoples; their bravest were fallen.

[1] For 1084, R. suggests 'wiht Hengeste wið gefeohtan.'—K. suggests 'wið Hengeste wiht gefeohtan.' Neither emendation would make any essential change in the translation.

[2] The separation of adjective and noun by a phrase (cf. v. 1118) being very unusual, some scholars have put 'earme on eaxle' with the foregoing lines, inserting a semicolon after 'eaxle.' In this case 'on eaxe' (*i.e.*, on the ashes, cinders) is sometimes read, and this affords a parallel to 'on bæl.' Let us hope that a satisfactory rendering shall yet be reached without resorting to any tampering with the text, such as Lichtenheld proposed: 'earme ides on eaxle gnornode.'

[3] For 'gúð-rinc,' 'gúð-réc,' *battle-smoke*, has been suggested.

XVIII.

THE FINN EPISODE (*continued*). —THE BANQUET CONTINUES.

“Then the warriors departed to go to
their dwellings,
Reaved of their friends, Friesland to
visit,

The survivors
go to
Friesland, the
home of Finn.

Their homes and high-city. Hengest continued

Biding with Finn the blood-tainted
winter,

Hengest
remains there
all winter,
unable to get
away.

5

Wholly unsundered;¹ of fatherland
thought he

Though unable to drive the ring-stemmèd vessel
O’er the ways of the waters; the wave-deeps were
tossing,

Fought with the wind; winter in ice-bonds
Closed up the currents, till there came to the
dwelling

10

A year in its course, as yet it revolveth,
If season propitious one alway regardeth,
World-cheering weathers. Then winter was gone,
Earth’s bosom was lovely; the exile would get him,

The guest from the palace; on
grewsomet vengeance

He devises
schemes of
vengeance.

15

He brooded more eager than on oversea journeys,
Whe’r onset-of-anger he were able to ’complish,
The bairns of the Jutemen therein to remember.
Nowise refused he the duties of liegeman

When Hun of the Frisians the battle-sword Láfing,

20

Fairest of falchions, friendly did give him:

Its edges were famous in folk-talk of Jutland.

And savage sword-fury seized in its clutches

Bold-mooded Finn where he bode in his palace,

When the grewsome grapple Guthlaf
and Oslaf

Guthlaf and
Oslaf revenge
Hnæf's
slaughter.

25

Had mournfully mentioned, the mere-
journey over,

For sorrows half-blamed him; the flickering spirit

Could not bide in his bosom. Then the building was
covered²

With corpses of foemen, and Finn too
was slaughtered,

Finn is slain.

The king with his comrades, and the queen made a
prisoner.

30

The troops of the Scyldings bore to
their vessels

The jewels of
Finn, and his
queen are
carried away
by the Danes.

All that the land-king had in his palace,

Such trinkets and treasures they took as, on
searching,

At Finn's they could find. They ferried to Daneland

The excellent woman on oversea journey,

35

Led her to their land-folk." The lay
was concluded,

The lay is
concluded, and
the main story
is resumed.

The gleeman's recital. Shouts again
rose then,

Bench-glee resounded, bearers then offered

Wine from wonder-vats. Wealhtheo
advanced then

Skinkers carry
round the
beaker.

Going 'neath gold-crown, where the good ones were
seated

40

Uncle and nephew; their peace was yet
mutual,

True each to the other. And Unferth the
spokesman

Sat at the feet of the lord of the
Scyldings:

Each trusted his spirit that his mood was courageous,
Though at fight he had failed in faith to his kinsmen.

45

Said the queen of the Scyldings: "My lord and
protector,

Treasure-bestower, take thou this beaker;
Joyance attend thee, gold-friend of heroes,

And greet thou the Geatmen with
gracious responses!

Queen
Wealhtheow
greet
Hrothgar, as he
sits beside
Hrothulf, his
nephew.

Be generous to
the Geats.

So ought one to do. Be kind to the Geatmen,

50

In gifts not niggardly; anear and afar now
Peace thou enjoyest. Report hath informed me
Thou'lt have for a bairn the battle-brave hero.

Now is Heorot cleansèd, ring-palace gleaming;

Give while thou mayest many rewards,

55

And bequeath to thy kinsmen kingdom
and people,

Have as much
joy as possible
in thy hall,
once more
purified.

On wending thy way to the Wielder's splendor.

I know good Hrothulf, that the noble young troopers

He'll care for and honor, lord of the
Scyldings,

If earth-joys thou endest earlier than he
doth;

I know that
Hrothulf will
prove faithful
if he survive
thee.

60

I reckon that recompense he'll render with kindness
 Our offspring and issue, if that all he remember,
 What favors of yore, when he yet was an infant,
 We awarded to him for his worship and pleasure."
 Then she turned by the bench where her sons were
 carousing,

65

Hrethric and Hrothmund, and the heroes' offspring,
 The war-youth together; there the good Beowulf is
 one was sitting sitting by the
 'Twixt the brothers twain, Beowulf two royal sons.
 Geatman.

[1] For 1130 (1) R. and Gr. suggest 'elne unflitme' as 1098 (1) reads. The latter verse is undisputed; and, for the former, 'elne' would be as possible as 'ealles,' and 'unflitme' is well supported. Accepting 'elne unflitme' for both, I would suggest '*very peaceably*' for both places: (1) *Finn to Hengest very peaceably vowed with oaths*, etc. (2) *Hengest then still the slaughter-stained winter remained there with Finn very peaceably*. The two passages become thus correlatives, the second a sequel of the first. 'Elne,' in the sense of very (swíðe), needs no argument; and 'unflitme' (from 'flítan') can, it seems to me, be more plausibly rendered 'peaceful,' 'peaceable,' than 'contestable,' or 'conquerable.'

[2] Some scholars have proposed 'roden'; the line would then read: *Then the building was reddened*, etc., instead of 'covered.' The 'h' may have been carried over from the three alliterating 'h's.'

XIX.

BEOWULF RECEIVES FURTHER HONOR.

A beaker was borne him, and bidding
to quaff it

More gifts are
offered
Beowulf.

Graciously given, and gold that was
twisted

Pleasantly proffered, a pair of arm-jewels,
Rings and corslet, of collars the greatest

5

I've heard of 'neath heaven. Of heroes not any
More splendid from jewels have I heard 'neath the
welkin,

Since Hama off bore the Brosingmen's
necklace,

A famous
necklace is
referred to, in
comparison
with the gems
presented to
Beowulf.

The bracteates and jewels, from the
bright-shining city,¹

Eormenric's cunning craftiness fled
from,

10

Chose gain everlasting. Geatish Higelac,
Grandson of Swerting, last had this jewel
When tramping 'neath banner the treasure he
guarded,

The field-spoil defended; Fate offcarried him
When for deeds of daring he endured tribulation,

15

Hate from the Frisians; the ornaments bare he
O'er the cup of the currents, costly gem-treasures,
Mighty folk-leader, he fell 'neath his target;
The² corpse of the king then came into charge of

The race of the Frankmen, the mail-shirt and collar:

20

Warmen less noble plundered the fallen,
When the fight was finished; the folk of the
Geatmen

The field of the dead held in possession.

The choicest of mead-halls with cheering resounded.

Wealhtheo discoursed, the war-troop addressed she:

25

“This collar enjoy thou, Beowulf
worthy,

Young man, in safety, and use thou this
armor,

Queen
Wealhtheow
magnifies
Beowulf’s
achievements.

Gems of the people, and prosper thou fully,
Show thyself sturdy and be to these liegemen
Mild with instruction! I’ll mind thy requital.

30

Thou hast brought it to pass that far and near
Forever and ever earthmen shall honor thee,
Even so widely as ocean surroundeth
The blustering bluffs. Be, while thou livest,
A wealth-blessèd atheling. I wish thee most truly

35

Jewels and treasure. Be kind to my son,
thou

May gifts
never fail thee.

Living in joyance! Here each of the nobles
Is true unto other, gentle in spirit,
Loyal to leader. The liegemen are peaceful,
The war-troops ready: well-drunk heroes,³

40

Do as I bid ye.” Then she went to the settle.
There was choicest of banquets, wine drank the
heroes:

Weird they knew not, destiny cruel,

They little
know of the

As to many an earlman early it
happened,

When evening had come and Hrothgar had parted

Off to his manor, the mighty to slumber.

As erst they did often: the ale-settle bared they,

Doomed unto death, down to his
slumber

A doomed
thane is there
with them.

50

Bright-shining targets, up by their heads then;

Battle-high helmet, burnie of ring-mail,

55

[1] C. suggests a semicolon after 'city,' with 'he' as supplied subject of 'fled' and 'chose.'

[3] S. suggests ‘wine-joyous heroes,’ ‘warriors elated with wine.’

‘on’; cf. B. 1110 (*ready for the pyre*), El. 222 (*ready for the glad journey*). Moreover, what has the idea of single combat to do with B. 1247 ff.? The poet is giving an inventory of the arms and armor which they lay aside on retiring, and he closes his narration by saying that they were *always prepared for battle both at home and on the march*.

XX.

THE MOTHER OF GRENDEL.

They sank then to slumber. With sorrow one paid for
His evening repose, as often betid them

While Grendel was holding¹ the gold-bedecked
palace,

Ill-deeds performing, till his end overtook him,

5

Death for his sins. 'Twas seen very clearly,

Known unto earth-folk, that still an
avenger

Grendel's
mother is
known to be
thirsting for
revenge.

Outlived the loathed one, long since
the sorrow

Caused by the struggle; the mother of Grendel,
Devil-shaped woman, her woe ever minded,

10

Who was held to inhabit the horrible waters,

The cold-flowing currents, after Cain
had become a

[Grendel's
progenitor,
Cain, is again
referred to.]

Slayer-with-edges to his one only
brother,

The son of his sire; he set out then banished,

Marked as a murderer, man-joys avoiding,

15

Lived in the desert. Thence demons unnumbered

Fate-sent awoke; one of them Grendel,

Sword-cursèd, hateful, who at Heorot
met with

The poet again
magnifies
Beowulf's
valor.

A man that was watching, waiting the struggle,

Where a horrid one held him with hand-grapple
sturdy;

20

Nathless he minded the might of his body,
The glorious gift God had allowed him,
And folk-ruling Father's favor relied on,
His help and His comfort: so he conquered the
foeman,

The hell-spirit humbled: he unhappy departed then,

25

Reaved of his joyance, journeying to death-haunts,
Foeman of man. His mother moreover

Eager and gloomy was anxious to go
on

Grendel's
mother comes
to avenge her
son.

Her mournful mission, mindful of
vengeance

For the death of her son. She came then to Heorot

30

Where the Armor-Dane earlmen all through the
building

Were lying in slumber. Soon there became then
Return² to the nobles, when the mother of Grendel
Entered the folk-hall; the fear was less grievous
By even so much as the vigor of maidens,

35

War-strength of women, by warrior is reckoned,
When well-carved weapon, worked with the
hammer,

Blade very bloody, brave with its edges,
Strikes down the boar-sign that stands on the helmet.
Then the hard-edgèd weapon was heaved in the
building,³

40

The brand o'er the benches, broad-lindens many
Hand-fast were lifted; for helmet he recked not,
For armor-net broad, whom terror laid hold of.

She went then hastily, outward would get her
Her life for to save, when some one did spy her;

45

Soon she had grappled one of the
athelings

She seizes a
favorite
liegemen of
Hrothgar's.

Fast and firmly, when fenward she hied
her;

That one to Hrothgar was liefest of heroes
In rank of retainer where waters encircle,
A mighty shield-warrior, whom she murdered at
slumber,

50

A broadly-famed battle-knight. Beowulf was absent,
But another apartment was erstwhile
devoted
To the glory-decked Geatman when
gold was distributed.

Beowulf was
asleep in
another part of
the palace.

There was hubbub in Heorot. The hand that was
famous

She grasped in its gore;⁴ grief was renewed then

55

In homes and houses: 'twas no happy arrangement
In both of the quarters to barter and purchase
With lives of their friends. Then the well-aged ruler,
The gray-headed war-thane, was woful in spirit,
When his long-trusted liegeman lifeless he knew of,

60

His dearest one gone. Quick from a
room was

Beowulf is sent
for.

Beowulf brought, brave and triumphant.

As day was dawning in the dusk of the morning,

Went then that earlman, champion
noble,

He comes at
Hrothgar's
summons.

Came with comrades, where the clever one bided

65

Whether God all gracious would grant him a respite
After the woe he had suffered. The war-worthy hero
With a troop of retainers trod then the pavement
(The hall-building groaned), till he greeted the wise
one,

The earl of the Ingwins;⁵ asked if the
night had

70

Fully refreshed him, as fain he would
have it.

Beowulf
inquires how
Hrothgar had
enjoyed his
night's rest.

[1] Several eminent authorities either read or emend the MS. so as to make this verse read, *While Grendel was wasting the gold-bedecked palace*. So 20 15 below: *ravaged the desert*.

[2] For 'sóna' (1281), t.B. suggests 'sára,' limiting 'edhwyrft.' Read then: *Return of sorrows to the nobles, etc.* This emendation supplies the syntactical gap after 'edhwyrft.'

[3] Some authorities follow Grein's lexicon in treating 'heard ecg' as an adj. limiting 'sweord': H.-So. renders it as a subst. (So v. 1491.) The sense of the translation would be the same.

[4] B. suggests 'under hróf genam' (v. 1303). This emendation, as well as an emendation with (?) to v. 739, he offers, because 'under' baffles him in both passages. All we need is to take 'under' in its secondary meaning of 'in,' which, though not given by Grein, occurs in the literature. Cf. Chron. 876 (March's A.-S. Gram. § 355) and Oro. Amaz. I. 10, where 'under' = *in the midst of*. Cf. modern Eng. 'in such circumstances,' which interchanges in good usage with 'under such circumstances.'

[5] For 'néod-laðu' (1321) C. suggests 'néad-láðum,' and translates: *asked whether the night had been pleasant to him after crushing-hostility*.

XXI.

HROTHGAR'S ACCOUNT OF THE MONSTERS.

Hrothgar rejoined, helm of the
Scyldings:
“Ask not of joyance! Grief is renewed
to

Hrothgar
laments the
death of
Æschere, his
shoulder-
companion.

The folk of the Danemen. Dead is
Æschere,

Yrmenlaf's brother, older than he,

5

My true-hearted counsellor, trusty adviser,
Shoulder-companion, when fighting in battle
Our heads we protected, when troopers were
clashing,

And heroes were dashing; such an earl
should be ever,

He was my
ideal hero.

An erst-worthy atheling, as Æschere proved him.

10

The flickering death-spirit became in Heorot
His hand-to-hand murderer; I can not tell whither
The cruel one turned in the carcass exulting,

By cramming discovered.¹ The quarrel
she wreaked then,

This horrible creature came to avenge Grendel's death.

That last night igone Grendel thou
killedst

15

In grewsomest manner, with grim-holding clutches,
Since too long he had lessened my liege-troop and
wasted

My folk-men so foully. He fell in the battle

With forfeit of life, and another has followed,
A mighty crime-worker, her kinsman avenging,

20

And henceforth hath 'stablished her hatred
 unyielding,²

As it well may appear to many a liegeman,
Who mourneth in spirit the treasure-bestower,
Her heavy heart-sorrow; the hand is now lifeless
Which³ availed you in every wish that you
 cherished.

25

Land-people heard I, liegemen, this
 saying,
Dwellers in halls, they had seen very
 often

I have heard
my vassals
speak of these
two uncanny
monsters who
lived in the
moors.

A pair of such mighty march-striding
 creatures,

Far-dwelling spirits, holding the moorlands:
One of them wore, as well they might notice,

30

The image of woman, the other one wretched
In guise of a man wandered in exile,
Except he was huger than any of earthmen;
Earth-dwelling people entitled him Grendel
In days of yore: they know not their father,

35

Whe'r ill-going spirits any were borne him
Ever before. They guard the wolf-
 coverts,

The inhabit the
most desolate
and horrible
places.

Lands inaccessible, wind-beaten
 nesses,

Fearfullest fen-deeps, where a flood from the
 mountains

'Neath mists of the nesses netherward rattles,

40

The stream under earth: not far is it henceward
Measured by mile-lengths that the mere-water
standeth,
Which forests hang over, with frost-whiting
covered,⁴

A firm-rooted forest, the floods overshadow.
There ever at night one an ill-meaning portent

45

A fire-flood may see; 'mong children of men
None liveth so wise that wot of the bottom;
Though harassed by hounds the heath-stepper seek
for,

Fly to the forest, firm-antlered he-deer,
Spurred from afar, his spirit he
yieldeth,

Even the
hounded deer
will not seek
refuge in these
uncanny
regions.

50

His life on the shore, ere in he will
venture

To cover his head. Uncanny the place is:
Thence upward ascendeth the surging of waters,
Wan to the welkin, when the wind is stirring
The weathers unpleasing, till the air groweth
gloomy,

55

And the heavens lower. Now is help to
be gotten

To thee only
can I look for
assistance.

From thee and thee only! The abode thou know'st
not,

The dangerous place where thou'rt able to meet with
The sin-laden hero: seek if thou darest!

For the feud I will fully fee thee with money,

60

With old-time treasure, as erstwhile I did thee,

With well-twisted jewels, if away thou shalt get
thee.”

- [1] For ‘gefrægnod’ (1334), K. and t.B. suggest ‘gefægnod,’ rendering ‘*rejoicing in her fill.*’ This gives a parallel to ‘æse wlanc’ (1333).
- [2] The line ‘And ... yielding,’ B. renders: *And she has performed a deed of blood-vengeance whose effect is far-reaching.*
- [3] ‘Sé þe’ (1345) is an instance of masc. rel. with fem. antecedent. So v. 1888, where ‘sé þe’ refers to ‘yldo.’
- [4] For ‘hrímge’ in the H.-So. edition, Gr. and others read ‘hrínde’ (=hrínende), and translate: *which rustling forests overhang.*

XXII.

BEOWULF SEEKS GRENDEL'S MOTHER.

Beowulf answered, Ecgtheow's son:

"Grieve not, O wise one! for each it is
better,

His friend to avenge than with
vehemence wail him;

Beowulf
exhorts the old
king to arouse
himself for
action.

Each of us must the end-day abide of

5

His earthly existence; who is able accomplish

Glory ere death! To battle-thane noble

Lifeless lying, 'tis at last most fitting.

Arise, O king, quick let us hasten

To look at the footprint of the kinsman of Grendel!

10

I promise thee this now: to his place he'll escape not,

To embrace of the earth, nor to mountainous forest,

Nor to depths of the ocean, wherever he wanders.

Practice thou now patient endurance

Of each of thy sorrows, as I hope for thee soothly!"

15

Then up sprang the old one, the All-

Wielder thanked he,

Hrothgar
rouses himself.
His horse is
brought.

Ruler Almighty, that the man had
outspoken.

Then for Hrothgar a war-horse was decked with a
bridle,

Curly-maned courser. The clever folk-leader

Stately proceeded: stepped then an
earl-troop

They start on
the track of the

20

female
monster.

Of linden-wood bearers. Her footprints
were seen then

Widely in wood-paths, her way o'er the bottoms,
Where she faraway fared o'er fen-country murky,
Bore away breathless the best of retainers
Who pondered with Hrothgar the welfare of country.

25

The son of the athelings then went o'er the stony,
Declivitous cliffs, the close-covered passes,
Narrow passages, paths unfrequented,
Nesses abrupt, nicker-haunts many;
One of a few of wise-mooded heroes,

30

He onward advanced to view the surroundings,
Till he found unawares woods of the mountain
O'er hoar-stones hanging, holt-wood unjoyful;
The water stood under, welling and gory.
'Twas irksome in spirit to all of the Danemen,

35

Friends of the Scyldings, to many a liegeman

Sad to be suffered, a sorrow unlittle

To each of the earlmen, when to

Æschere's head they

Came on the cliff. The current was

seething

With blood and with gore (the troopers gazed on it).

40

The horn anon sang the battle-song ready.

The troop were all seated; they saw 'long the water
then

Many a serpent, mere-dragons
wondrous

Trying the waters, nickers a-lying

The sight of
Æschere's
head causes
them great
sorrow.

The water is
filled with
serpents and
sea-dragons.

On the cliffs of the nesses, which at noonday full
often

45

Go on the sea-deeps their sorrowful journey,
Wild-beasts and wormkind; away then they hastened
Hot-mooded, hateful, they heard the One of them is
great clamor, killed by
Beowulf.

The war-trumpet winding. One did the
Geat-prince

Sunder from earth-joys, with arrow from bowstring,

50

From his sea-struggle tore him, that the trusty war-
missile

Pierced to his vitals; he proved in the The dead beast
currents is a poor
swimmer

Less doughty at swimming whom
death had offcarried.

Soon in the waters the wonderful swimmer
Was straitened most sorely with sword-pointed boar-
spears,

55

Pressed in the battle and pulled to the cliff-edge;
The liegemen then looked on the loath-fashioned
stranger.

Beowulf donned then his battle- Beowulf
equipments, prepares for a
struggle with
Cared little for life; inlaid and most the monster.
ample,

The hand-woven corslet which could cover his body,

60

Must the wave-deeps explore, that war might be
powerless

To harm the great hero, and the hating one's grasp
might

Not peril his safety; his head was protected

By the light-flashing helmet that should mix with the
bottoms,

Trying the eddies, treasure-emblazoned,

65

Encircled with jewels, as in seasons long past

The weapon-smith worked it, wondrously made it,

With swine-bodies fashioned it, that thenceforward
no longer

Brand might bite it, and battle-sword hurt it.

And that was not least of helpers in prowess

70

That Hrothgar's spokesman had lent
him when straitened;

He has
Unferth's
sword in his
hand.

And the hilted hand-sword was
Hrunting entitled,

Old and most excellent 'mong all of the treasures;

Its blade was of iron, blotted with poison,

Hardened with gore; it failed not in battle

75

Any hero under heaven in hand who it brandished,

Who ventured to take the terrible journeys,

The battle-field sought; not the earliest occasion

That deeds of daring 'twas destined to 'complish.

Ecglaf's kinsman minded not soothly,

80

Unferth has
little use for
swords.

Exulting in strength, what erst he had
spoken

Drunken with wine, when the weapon he lent to

A sword-hero bolder; himself did not venture

'Neath the strife of the currents his life to endanger,

To fame-deeds perform; there he forfeited glory,

85

Repute for his strength. Not so with the other

When he clad in his corslet had equipped him for
battle.

XXIII.

Beowulf spake, Ecgtheow's son:	Beowulf
"Recall now, oh, famous kinsman of	makes a
Healfdene,	parting speech
Prince very prudent, now to part I am	to Hrothgar.
ready,	
Gold-friend of earlmen, what erst we agreed on,	
5	If I fail, act as
Should I lay down my life in lending	a kind
thee assistance,	liiegelord to my
	thanes,
When my earth-joys were over, thou	
wouldst evermore serve me	
In stead of a father; my faithful thanemen,	
My trusty retainers, protect thou and care for,	
Fall I in battle: and, Hrothgar belovèd,	
10	and send
Send unto Higelac the high-valued	Higelac the
jewels	jewels thou
	hast given me
Thou to me hast allotted. The lord of	
the Geatmen	
May perceive from the gold, the Hrethling may see it	
When he looks on the jewels, that a	I should like
gem-giver found I	my king to
Good over-measure, enjoyed him while	know how
able.	generous a lord
	I found thee to
15	be.
And the ancient heirloom Unferth permit thou,	
The famed one to have, the heavy-sword splendid ¹	
The hard-edgèd weapon; with Hrunting to aid me,	

I shall gain me glory, or grim-death shall take me.”

The atheling of Geatmen uttered these
words and

Beowulf is
eager for the
fray.

20

Heroic did hasten, not any rejoinder

Was willing to wait for; the wave-current swallowed

The doughty-in-battle. Then a day's-
length elapsed ere

He is a whole
day reaching
the bottom of
the sea.

He was able to see the sea at its
bottom.

Early she found then who fifty of winters

25

The course of the currents kept in her fury,

Grisly and greedy, that the grim one's dominion

Some one of men from above was
exploring.

Grendel's
mother knows
that some one
has reached her
domains.

Forth did she grab them, grappled the
warrior

With horrible clutches; yet no sooner she injured

30

His body unscathed: the burnie out-guarded,

That she proved but powerless to pierce through the
armor,

The limb-mail locked, with loath-grabbing fingers.

The sea-wolf bare then, when bottomward came she,

The ring-prince homeward, that he
after was powerless

She grabs him,
and bears him
to her den.

35

(He had daring to do it) to deal with his weapons,

But many a mere-beast tormented him swimming,

Flood-beasts no few with fierce-biting
tusks did

Sea-monsters
bite and strike
him.

Break through his burnie, the brave one
pursued they.

The earl then discovered he was down in some
cavern

40

Where no water whatever anyway harmed him,
And the clutch of the current could come not anear
him,

Since the roofed-hall prevented; brightness a-
gleaming

Fire-light he saw, flashing resplendent.

The good one saw then the sea-bottom's monster,

45

The mighty mere-woman; he made a
great onset

Beowulf
attacks the
mother of
Grendel.

With weapon-of-battle, his hand not
desisted

From striking, that war-blade struck on her head then
A battle-song greedy. The stranger perceived then

The sword would not bite, her life
would not injure,

The sword will
not bite.

50

But the falchion failed the folk-prince when
straitened:

Erst had it often onsets encountered,

Oft cloven the helmet, the fated one's armor:

'Twas the first time that ever the excellent jewel
Had failed of its fame. Firm-mooded after,

55

Not heedless of valor, but mindful of glory,

Was Higelac's kinsman; the hero-chief angry

Cast then his carved-sword covered with jewels

That it lay on the earth, hard and steel-pointed;

He hoped in his strength, his hand-
grapple sturdy.

The hero
throws down
all weapons,
and again

60

So any must act whenever he thinketh

To gain him in battle glory unending,
And is reckless of living. The lord of
the War-Geats

trusts to his
hand-grip.

(He shrank not from battle) seized by the shoulder²
The mother of Grendel; then mighty in struggle

65

Swung he his enemy, since his anger was kindled,
That she fell to the floor. With furious grapple
She gave him requital³ early thereafter, Beowulf falls.
And stretched out to grab him; the strongest of
warriors

Faint-mooded stumbled, till he fell in his traces,

70

Foot-going champion. Then she sat on
the hall-guest

The monster
sits on him
with drawn
sword.

And wielded her war-knife wide-
bladed, flashing,

For her son would take vengeance, her one only
bairn.

His breast-armor woven bode on his
shoulder;

His armor
saves his life.

It guarded his life, the entrance defended

75

'Gainst sword-point and edges. Ecgtheow's son
there

Had fatally journeyed, champion of Geatmen,
In the arms of the ocean, had the armor not given,
Close-woven corslet, comfort and succor,
And had God most holy not awarded
the victory,

God arranged
for his escape.

80

All-knowing Lord; easily did heaven's
Ruler most righteous arrange it with justice;⁴
Uprose he erect ready for battle.

- [1] Kl. emends ‘wæl-sweord.’ The half-line would then read, ‘*the battle-sword splendid.*’—For ‘heard-ecg’ in next half-verse, see note to 20 39 above.
- [2] Sw., R., and t.B. suggest ‘feaxe’ for ‘eaxe’ (1538) and render: *Seized by the hair.*
- [3] If ‘hand-léan’ be accepted (as the MS. has it), the line will read: *She hand-reward gave him early thereafter.*
- [4] Sw. and S. change H.-So.’s semicolon (v. 1557) to a comma, and translate: *The Ruler of Heaven arranged it in justice easily, after he arose again.*

XXIV.

BEOWULF IS DOUBLE- CONQUEROR.

Then he saw mid the war-gems a
 weapon of victory,
 An ancient giant-sword, of edges a-
 doughty,

Beowulf
grasps a giant-
sword,

Glory of warriors: of weapons 'twas choicest,
Only 'twas larger than any man else was

5

Able to bear to the battle-encounter,
The good and splendid work of the giants.
He grasped then the sword-hilt, knight of the
Scyldings,

Bold and battle-grim, brandished his ring-sword,
 Hopeless of living, hotly he smote her,

10

That the fiend-woman's neck firmly it grappled,
Broke through her bone-joints, the bill and fells
fully pierced her female
monster

and fells the female monster.

Fate-cursèd body, she fell to the ground
then:

The hand-sword was bloody, the hero exulted.
The brand was brilliant, brightly it glimmered,

15

Just as from heaven gemlike shineth
The torch of the firmament. He glanced 'long the
building,

And turned by the wall then, Higelac's vassal
Raging and wrathful raised his battle-sword
Strong by the handle. The edge was not useless

20

To the hero-in-battle, but he speedily wished to
Give Grendel requital for the many assaults he
Had worked on the West-Danes not once, but often,
When he slew in slumber the subjects of Hrothgar,
Swallowed down fifteen sleeping retainers

25

Of the folk of the Danemen, and fully as many
Carried away, a horrible prey.

He gave him requital, grim-raging champion,

When he saw on his rest-place weary
of conflict

Beowulf sees
the body of
Grendel, and
cuts off his
head.

Grendel lying, of life-joys bereavèd,

30

As the battle at Heorot erstwhile had scathed him;
His body far bounded, a blow when he suffered,
Death having seized him, sword-smiting heavy,
And he cut off his head then. Early this noticed
The clever carles who as comrades of Hrothgar

35

Gazed on the sea-deeps, that the
surging wave-currents

The waters are
gory.

Were mightily mingled, the mere-flood was gory:
Of the good one the gray-haired together held
converse,

The hoary of head, that they hoped not
to see again

Beowulf is
given up for
dead.

The atheling ever, that exulting in
victory

40

He'd return there to visit the distinguished folk-
ruler:

Then many concluded the mere-wolf had killed
him.¹

The ninth hour came then. From the ness-edge
 departed
 The bold-mooded Scyldings; the gold-friend of
 heroes
 Homeward betook him. The strangers sat down then
 45
 Soul-sick, sorrowful, the sea-waves regarding:
 They wished and yet weened not their well-loved
 friend-lord
 To see any more. The sword-blade The giant-
 sword melts.
 began then,
 The blood having touched it, contracting and
 shriveling
 With battle-icicles; 'twas a wonderful marvel
 50
 That it melted entirely, likest to ice when
 The Father unbindeth the bond of the frost and
 Unwindeth the wave-bands, He who wieldeth
 dominion
 Of times and of tides: a truth-firm Creator.
 Nor took he of jewels more in the dwelling,
 55
 Lord of the Weders, though they lay all around him,
 Than the head and the handle handsome with jewels;
 The brand early melted, burnt was the weapon:²
 So hot was the blood, the strange-spirit poisonous
 That in it did perish. He early swam off The hero
 swims back to
 then the realms of
 60 day.
 Who had bided in combat the carnage
 of haters,
 Went up through the ocean; the eddies were
 cleansèd,
 The spacious expanses, when the spirit from farland

His life put aside and this short-lived existence.
The seamen's defender came swimming to land then
65

Doughty of spirit, rejoiced in his sea-gift,
The bulky burden which he bore in his keeping.
The excellent vassals advanced then to meet him,
To God they were grateful, were glad in their
chieftain,
That to see him safe and sound was granted them.

70
From the high-minded hero, then, helmet and burnie
Were speedily loosened: the ocean was putrid,
The water 'neath welkin weltered with gore.
Forth did they fare, then, their footsteps retracing,
Merry and mirthful, measured the earth-way,
75

The highway familiar: men very daring³
Bare then the head from the sea-cliff, burdening
Each of the earlmen, excellent-valiant.
Four of them had to carry with labor It takes four
The head of Grendel to the high men to carry
towering gold-hall Grendel's head
on a spear.

80
Upstuck on the spear, till fourteen most-valiant
And battle-brave Geatmen came there going
Straight to the palace: the prince of the people
Measured the mead-ways, their mood-brave
companion.

The atheling of earlmen entered the building,
85

Deed-valiant man, adorned with distinction,
Doughty shield-warrior, to address King Hrothgar:
Then hung by the hair, the head of Grendel

Was borne to the building, where beer-thanes were
drinking,

Loth before earlmen and eke 'fore the lady:

90

The warriors beheld then a wonderful sight.

[1] 'þæs monige gewearð' (1599) and 'hafað þæs geworden' (2027).—
In a paper published some years ago in one of the Johns Hopkins
University circulars, I tried to throw upon these two long-doubtful
passages some light derived from a study of like passages in
Alfred's prose.—The impersonal verb 'geweorðan,' with an accus.
of the person, and a þæt-clause is used several times with the
meaning 'agree.' See Orosius (Sweet's ed.) 1787; 204₃₄; 208₂₈;
210₁₅; 280₂₀. In the two Beowulf passages, the þæt-clause is
anticipated by 'þæs,' which is clearly a gen. of the thing agreed on.

The first passage (v. 1599 (b)-1600) I translate literally: *Then
many agreed upon this (namely), that the sea-wolf had killed him.*

The second passage (v. 2025 (b)-2027): *She is promised ...; to
this the friend of the Scyldings has agreed, etc.* By emending 'is'
instead of 'wæs' (2025), the tenses will be brought into perfect
harmony.

In v. 1997 ff. this same idiom occurs, and was noticed in B.'s
great article on Beowulf, which appeared about the time I
published my reading of 1599 and 2027. Translate 1997 then:
*Wouldst let the South-Danes themselves decide about their
struggle with Grendel.* Here 'Súð-Dene' is accus. of person, and
'gúðe' is gen. of thing agreed on.

With such collateral support as that afforded by B. (P. and B.
XII. 97), I have no hesitation in departing from H.-So., my usual
guide.

The idiom above treated runs through A.-S., Old Saxon, and
other Teutonic languages, and should be noticed in the lexicons.

[2] 'Bróden-mæl' is regarded by most scholars as meaning a
damaskeened sword. Translate: *The damaskeened sword burned
up.* Cf. 25 16 and note.

[3] 'Cyning-balde' (1635) is the much-disputed reading of K. and Th.
To render this, "*nobly bold*," "*excellently bold*," have been
suggested. B. would read 'cyning-holde' (cf. 290), and render:
Men well-disposed towards the king carried the head, etc.
'Cynebealde,' says t.B., endorsing Gr.

XXV.

BEOWULF BRINGS HIS TROPHIES.—HROTHGAR'S GRATITUDE.

Beowulf spake, offspring of Ecgtheow: Beowulf
"Lo! we blithely have brought thee, relates his last
 bairn of Healfdene, exploit.

Prince of the Scyldings, these presents from ocean
Which thine eye looketh on, for an emblem of glory.

5

I came off alive from this, narrowly 'scaping:
In war 'neath the water the work with great pains I
Performed, and the fight had been finished quite
 nearly,

Had God not defended me. I failed in the battle
Aught to accomplish, aided by Hrunting,

10

Though that weapon was worthy, but the Wielder of
 earth-folk

Gave me willingly to see on the wall a God was
Heavy old hand-sword hanging in fighting with
 splendor me.

(He guided most often the lorn and the friendless),
That I swung as a weapon. The wards of the house
 then

15

I killed in the conflict (when occasion was given
 me).

Then the battle-sword burned, the brand that was
 lifted,¹

As the blood-current sprang, hottest of war-sweats;

Seizing the hilt, from my foes I offbore it;
I avenged as I ought to their acts of malignity,

20

The murder of Danemen. I then make thee this
promise,

Thou'lt be able in Heorot careless to slumber

Heorot is freed
from monsters.

With thy throng of heroes and the thanes of thy
people

Every and each, of greater and lesser,
And thou needest not fear for them from the
selfsame direction

25

As thou formerly fearedst, oh, folk-lord of
Scyldings,

End-day for earlmen." To the age-hoary man then,

The gray-haired chieftain, the gold-
fashioned sword-hilt,

The famous
sword is
presented to

Old-work of giants, was thereupon
given;

Hrothgar.

Since the fall of the fiends, it fell to the keeping

30

Of the wielder of Danemen, the wonder-smith's
labor,

And the bad-mooded being abandoned this world
then,

Opponent of God, victim of murder,

And also his mother; it went to the keeping

Of the best of the world-kings, where waters
encircle,

35

Who the scot divided in Scylding dominion.

Hrothgar discoursed, the hilt he
regarded,

Hrothgar looks
closely at the
old sword.

The ancient heirloom where an old-time contention's
Beginning was graven: the gurgling currents,
The flood slew thereafter the race of the giants,

40

They had proved themselves daring: that people was
loth to

The Lord everlasting, through lash of
the billows

It had belonged
to a race
hateful to God.

The Father gave them final requital.

So in letters of rune on the clasp of the handle
Gleaming and golden, 'twas graven exactly,

45

Set forth and said, whom that sword had been made
for,

Finest of irons, who first it was wrought for,
Wreathed at its handle and gleaming with serpents.

The wise one then said (silent they all were)

Son of old Healfdene: "He may say
unrefuted

Hrothgar
praises
Beowulf.

50

Who performs 'mid the folk-men fairness and truth
(The hoary old ruler remembers the past),

That better by birth is this bairn of the nobles!

Thy fame is extended through far-away countries,

Good friend Beowulf, o'er all of the races,

55

Thou holdest all firmly, hero-like strength with

Prudence of spirit. I'll prove myself grateful

As before we agreed on; thou granted for long shalt

Become a great comfort to kinsmen and comrades,

A help unto heroes. Heremod became
not

Heremod's
career is again
contrasted with
Beowulf's.

60

Such to the Scyldings, successors of Ecgwela;
He grew not to please them, but grievous
destruction,
And dire some death-woes to Danemen attracted;
He slew in anger his table-companions,
Trustworthy counsellors, till he turned off lonely

65

From world-joys away, wide-famous ruler:
Though high-ruling heaven in hero-strength raised
him,

In might exalted him, o'er men of all nations
Made him supreme, yet a murderous spirit
Grew in his bosom: he gave then no ring-gems

70

To the Danes after custom; endured he
unjoyful

Standing the straits from strife that was
raging,

A wretched
failure of a
king, to give
no jewels to
his retainers.

Longsome folk-sorrow. Learn then from this,
Lay hold of virtue! Though laden with winters,
I have sung thee these measures. 'Tis a marvel to tell
it,

75

How all-ruling God from greatness of
spirit

Hrothgar
moralizes.

Giveth wisdom to children of men,
Manor and earlship: all things He ruleth.
He often permitteth the mood-thought of man of
The illustrious lineage to lean to possessions,

80

Allows him earthly delights at his manor,
A high-burg of heroes to hold in his keeping,
Maketh portions of earth-folk hear him,

And a wide-reaching kingdom so that, wisdom
failing him,

He himself is unable to reckon its boundaries;

85

He liveth in luxury, little debars him,

Nor sickness nor age, no treachery-sorrow

Becloudeth his spirit, conflict nowhere,

No sword-hate, appeareth, but all of the world doth

Wend as he wisheth; the worse he knoweth not,

90

Till arrant arrogance inward pervading,

Waxeth and springeth, when the warder is sleeping,

The guard of the soul: with sorrows encompassed,

Too sound is his slumber, the slayer is near him,

Who with bow and arrow aimeth in malice.

[1] Or rather, perhaps, '*the inlaid, or damaskeened weapon.*' Cf. [24 57](#) and note.

XXVI.

HROTHGAR MORALIZES.— REST AFTER LABOR.

“Then bruised in his bosom he with A wounded
bitter-toothed missile spirit.

Is hurt 'neath his helmet: from harmful pollution
He is powerless to shield him by the wonderful
mandates

Of the loath-cursèd spirit; what too long he hath
holden

5

Him seemeth too small, savage he hoardeth,
Nor boastfully giveth gold-plated rings,¹
The fate of the future flouts and forgetteth
Since God had erst given him greatness no little,
Wielder of Glory. His end-day anear,

10

It afterward happens that the bodily-dwelling
Fleetingly fadeth, falls into ruins;
Another lays hold who doleth the ornaments,
The nobleman's jewels, nothing lamenting,
Heedeth no terror. Oh, Beowulf dear,

15

Best of the heroes, from bale-strife defend thee,
And choose thee the better, counsels eternal;

Beware of arrogance, world-famous
champion!

But a little-while lasts thy life-vigor's
fulness;

Be not over
proud: life is
fleeting, and its
strength soon
wasteth away.

'Twill after hap early, that illness or sword-edge

20

Shall part thee from strength, or the grasp of the fire,
Or the wave of the current, or clutch of the edges,
Or flight of the war-spear, or age with its horrors,
Or thine eyes' bright flashing shall fade into
darkness:

'Twill happen full early, excellent hero,

25

Hrothgar gives
an account of
his reign.

That death shall subdue thee. So the
Danes a half-century

I held under heaven, helped them in struggles

'Gainst many a race in middle-earth's regions,

With ash-wood and edges, that enemies none

On earth molested me. Lo! offsetting change, now,

30

Sorrow after
joy.

Came to my manor, grief after joyance,

When Grendel became my constant visitor,

Inveterate hater: I from that malice

Continually travailed with trouble no little.

Thanks be to God that I gained in my lifetime,

35

To the Lord everlasting, to look on the gory

Head with mine eyes, after long-lasting sorrow!

Go to the bench now, battle-adornèd

Joy in the feasting: of jewels in common

We'll meet with many when morning appeareth."

40

The Geatman was gladsome, ganged he immediately

To go to the bench, as the clever one bade him.

Then again as before were the famous-for-prowess,

Hall-inhabiters, handsomely banqueted,

Feasted anew. The night-veil fell then

45

Dark o'er the warriors. The courtiers rose then;

The gray-haired was anxious to go to his slumbers,

The hoary old Scylding. Hanked the Geatman,
The champion doughty, greatly, to rest Beowulf is
him: fagged, and
seeks rest.

An earlman early outward did lead
him,

50

Fagged from his faring, from far-country springing,
Who for etiquette's sake all of a liegeman's
Needs regarded, such as seamen at that time
Were bounden to feel. The big-hearted rested;
The building uptowered, spacious and gilded,

55

The guest within slumbered, till the sable-clad raven
Blithely foreboded the beacon of heaven.
Then the bright-shining sun o'er the bottoms came
going;²

The warriors hastened, the heads of the peoples
Were ready to go again to their peoples,

60

The high-mooded farer would faraway
thenceward The Geats
prepare to
leave Dane-
land.

Look for his vessel. The valiant one
bade then,³

Offspring of Ecglaf, off to bear
Hrunting, Unferth asks
Beowulf to
accept his
sword as a gift.
Beowulf
thanks him.

To take his weapon, his well-beloved
iron;

He him thanked for the gift, saying
good he accounted

65

The war-friend and mighty, nor chid he with words
then

The blade of the brand: 'twas a brave-mooded hero.

When the warriors were ready, arrayed in their
trappings,
The atheling dear to the Danemen advanced then
On to the dais, where the other was sitting,
70
Grim-mooded hero, greeted King Hrothgar.

- [1] K. says 'proudly giveth.'—Gr. says, 'And gives no gold-plated rings, in order to incite the recipient to boastfulness.'—B. suggests 'gyld' for 'gylp,' and renders: *And gives no beaten rings for reward.*
- [2] If S.'s emendation be accepted, v. 57 will read: *Then came the light, going bright after darkness: the warriors, etc.*
- [3] As the passage stands in H.-So., Unferth presents Beowulf with the sword Hrunting, and B. thanks him for the gift. If, however, the suggestions of Grdtvg. and M. be accepted, the passage will read: *Then the brave one (i.e. Beowulf) commanded that Hrunting be borne to the son of Ecglaf (Unferth), bade him take his sword, his dear weapon; he (B.) thanked him (U.) for the loan, etc.*

XXVII.

SORROW AT PARTING.

Beowulf spake, Ecgtheow's offspring:
"We men of the water wish to declare
now

Beowulf's
farewell.

Fared from far-lands, we're firmly determined
To seek King Higelac. Here have we fitly

5
 Been welcomed and feasted, as heart would desire it;
 Good was the greeting. If greater affection
 I am anywise able ever on earth to
 Gain at thy hands, ruler of heroes,
 Than yet I have done, I shall quickly be ready

10
For combat and conflict. O'er the
course of the waters

I shall be ever
ready to aid
thee.

Learn I that neighbors alarm thee with terror,
As haters did whilom, I hither will bring thee
For help unto heroes henchmen by thousands.

I know as to Higelac, the lord of the Geatmen,	My liegelord will encourage me in aiding thee.
15	

Though young in years, he yet will
permit me,

By words and by works, ward of the people,
Fully to furnish thee forces and bear thee
My lance to relieve thee, if liegemen shall fail thee,
And help of my hand-strength; if Hrethric be
treating,

20
Bairn of the king, at the court of the Geatmen,

He thereat may find him friends in abundance:
Faraway countries he were better to seek for
Who trusts in himself.” Hrothgar discoursed then,
Making rejoinder: “These words thou hast uttered

25

All-knowing God hath given thy spirit!

Ne’er heard I an earlman thus early in
life

O Beowulf,
thou art wise
beyond thy
years.

More clever in speaking: thou’rt
cautious of spirit,

Mighty of muscle, in mouth-answers prudent.

I count on the hope that, happen it ever

30

That missile shall rob thee of Hrethel’s descendant,

Edge-horrid battle, and illness or weapon

Deprive thee of prince, of people’s protector,

And life thou yet holdest, the Sea-
Geats will never

Should Higelac
die, the Geats
could find no
better
successor than
thou wouldst
make.

Find a more fitting folk-lord to choose
them,

35

Gem-ward of heroes, than *thou*
mightest prove thee,

If the kingdom of kinsmen thou carest to govern.

Thy mood-spirit likes me the longer the better,

Beowulf dear: thou hast brought it to pass that

To both these peoples peace shall be common,

40

To Geat-folk and Danemen, the strife
be suspended,

Thou hast
healed the
ancient breach
between our
races.

The secret assailings they suffered in
yore-days;

And also that jewels be shared while I govern

The wide-stretching kingdom, and that many shall
visit

Others o'er the ocean with excellent gift-gems:

45

The ring-adorned bark shall bring o'er the currents
Presents and love-gifts. This people I know

Tow'rd foeman and friend firmly established,¹

After ancient etiquette everywise blameless."

Then the warden of earlmen gave him still farther,

50

Parting gifts

Kinsman of Healfdene, a dozen of jewels,

Bade him safely seek with the presents

His well-beloved people, early returning.

Then the noble-born king kissed the

distinguished,

Hrothgar

kisses

Beowulf, and

weeps.

Dear-lovèd liegeman, the Dane-prince

saluted him,

55

And claspèd his neck; tears from him fell,

From the gray-headed man: he two things expected,

Agèd and reverend, but rather the second,

²That bold in council they'd meet thereafter.

The man was so dear that he failed to suppress the

60

Emotions that moved him, but in mood-fetters

fastened

The long-famous hero longeth in secret

Deep in his spirit for the dear-beloved

man

The old king is

deeply grieved

to part with his

benefactor.

Though not a blood-kinsman. Beowulf thenceward,

Gold-splendid warrior, walked o'er the meadows

65

Exulting in treasure: the sea-going vessel

Riding at anchor awaited its owner.

As they pressed on their way then, the present of
Hrothgar

Was frequently referred to: a folk-king
indeed that

Giving
liberally is the
true proof of
kingship.

Everyway blameless, till age did debar
him

70

The joys of his might, which hath many oft injured.

[1] For 'geworhte,' the crux of this passage, B. proposes 'geþóhte,' rendering: *I know this people with firm thought every way blameless towards foe and friends.*

[2] S. and B. emend so as to negative the verb 'meet.' "Why should Hrothgar weep if he expects to meet Beowulf again?" both these scholars ask. But the weeping is mentioned before the 'expectations': the tears may have been due to many emotions, especially gratitude, struggling for expression.

XXVIII.

THE HOMEWARD JOURNEY.— THE TWO QUEENS.

Then the band of very valiant retainers
Came to the current; they were clad all in armor,
In link-woven burnies. The land- The coast-
warder noticed guard again.

The return of the earlmen, as he erstwhile had seen
them;

5

Nowise with insult he greeted the strangers
From the naze of the cliff, but rode on to meet them;
Said the bright-armored visitors¹ vesselward traveled
Welcome to Weders. The wide-bosomed craft then
Lay on the sand, laden with armor,

10

With horses and jewels, the ring-stemmèd sailer:
The mast uptowered o'er the treasure of Hrothgar.
To the boat-ward a gold-bound brand Beowulf gives
he presented, the guard a
That he was afterwards honored on the handsome
ale-bench more highly sword.

As the heirloom's owner. ²Set he out on his vessel,

15

To drive on the deep, Dane-country left he.
Along by the mast then a sea-garment fluttered,
A rope-fastened sail. The sea-boat resounded,
The wind o'er the waters the wave-floater nowise
Kept from its journey; the sea-goer traveled,

20

The foamy-necked floated forth o'er the currents,

The well-fashioned vessel o'er the ways of the
ocean,

Till they came within sight of the cliffs
of the Geatmen,

The Geats see
their own land
again.

The well-known headlands. The wave-
goer hastened

Driven by breezes, stood on the shore.

25

Prompt at the ocean, the port-ward was
ready,

The port-
warden is
anxiously
looking for
them.

Who long in the past outlooked in the
distance,³

At water's-edge waiting well-lovèd heroes;

He bound to the bank then the broad-bosomed vessel

Fast in its fetters, lest the force of the waters

30

Should be able to injure the ocean-wood winsome.

Bade he up then take the treasure of princes,

Plate-gold and fretwork; not far was it thence

To go off in search of the giver of jewels:

Hrethel's son Higelac at home there remaineth,⁴

35

Himself with his comrades close to the sea-coast.

The building was splendid, the king heroic,

Great in his hall, Hygd very young was,

Fine-mooded, clever, though few were
the winters

Hygd, the
noble queen of
Higelac, lavish
of gifts.

That the daughter of Hæreth had dwelt
in the borough;

40

But she nowise was cringing nor niggard of presents,

Of ornaments rare, to the race of the Geatmen.

Thrytho nursed anger, excellent⁵ folk-
queen,

Offa's consort,
Thrytho, is

Hot-burning hatred: no hero whatever
'Mong household companions, her
husband excepted

contrasted with
Hygd.

45

Dared to adventure to look at the
woman

She is a terror
to all save her
husband.

With eyes in the daytime;⁶ but he knew that death-
chains

Hand-wreathed were wrought him: early thereafter,
When the hand-strife was over, edges were ready,
That fierce-raging sword-point had to force a
decision,

50

Murder-bale show. Such no womanly custom
For a lady to practise, though lovely her person,
That a weaver-of-peace, on pretence of anger
A belovèd liegeman of life should deprive.
Soothly this hindered Heming's kinsman;

55

Other ale-drinking earlmen asserted
That fearful folk-sorrows fewer she wrought them,
Treacherous doings, since first she was given
Adorned with gold to the war-hero youthful,
For her origin honored, when Offa's great palace

60

O'er the fallow flood by her father's instructions
She sought on her journey, where she afterwards
fully,

Famed for her virtue, her fate on the king's-seat
Enjoyed in her lifetime, love did she hold with
The ruler of heroes, the best, it is told me,

65

Of all of the earthmen that oceans encompass,
Of earl-kindreds endless; hence Offa was famous

Far and widely, by gifts and by battles,
 Spear-valiant hero; the home of his fathers
 He governed with wisdom, whence Eomær did issue
 70
 For help unto heroes, Heming's kinsman,
 Grandson of Garmund, great in encounters.

- [1] For 'scawan' (1896), 'scaðan' has been proposed. Accepting this, we may render: *He said the bright-armored warriors were going to their vessel, welcome, etc.* (Cf. 1804.)
- [2] R. suggests, 'Gewát him on naca,' and renders: *The vessel set out, to drive on the sea, the Dane-country left.* 'On' bears the alliteration; cf. 'on hafu' (2524). This has some advantages over the H.-So. reading; viz. (1) It adds nothing to the text; (2) it makes 'naca' the subject, and thus brings the passage into keeping with the context, where the poet has exhausted his vocabulary in detailing the actions of the vessel.—B.'s emendation (cf. P. and B. XII. 97) is violent.
- [3] B. translates: *Who for a long time, ready at the coast, had looked out into the distance eagerly for the dear men.* This changes the syntax of 'léofra manna.'
- [4] For 'wunað' (v. 1924) several eminent critics suggest 'wunade' (=remained). This makes the passage much clearer.
- [5] Why should such a woman be described as an 'excellent' queen? C. suggests 'frécnu' = dangerous, bold.
- [6] For 'an dæges' various readings have been offered. If 'and-éges' be accepted, the sentence will read: *No hero ... dared look upon her, eye to eye.* If 'án-dæges' be adopted, translate: *Dared look upon her the whole day.*

XXIX.

BEOWULF AND HIGELAC.

Then the brave one departed, his band along with
him,

Seeking the sea-shore, the sea-marches Beowulf and
treading, his party seek
Higelac.

The wide-stretching shores. The world-
candle glimmered,

The sun from the southward; they proceeded then
onward,

5

Early arriving where they heard that the troop-lord,
Ongentheow's slayer, excellent, youthful

Folk-prince and warrior was distributing jewels,

Close in his castle. The coming of Beowulf

Was announced in a message quickly to Higelac,

10

That the folk-troop's defender forth to the palace

The linden-companion alive was advancing,

Secure from the combat courtward a-going.

The building was early inward made ready

For the foot-going guests as the good one had
ordered.

15

He sat by the man then who had lived
through the struggle,

Beowulf sits
by his
liegeland.

Kinsman by kinsman, when the king of the people

Had in lordly language saluted the dear one,

In words that were formal. The
daughter of Hæreth

Queen Hygd
receives the
heroes.

Coursed through the building, carrying mead-cups:¹

20

She loved the retainers, tendered the beakers

To the high-minded Geatmen. Higelac 'gan then

Pleasantly plying his companion with questions

Higelac is greatly interested in Beowulf's adventures.

In the high-towering palace. A curious interest

Tormented his spirit, what meaning to see in

25

The Sea-Geats' adventures: "Beowulf worthy,

How throve your journeying, when thou thoughtest suddenly

Give an account of thy adventures, Beowulf dear.

Far o'er the salt-streams to seek an encounter,

A battle at Heorot? Hast bettered for Hrothgar,

The famous folk-leader, his far-published sorrows

30

Any at all? In agony-billows

I mused upon torture, distrusted the journey

My suspense has been great.

Of the belovèd liegeman; I long time did pray thee

By no means to seek out the murderous spirit,

To suffer the South-Danes themselves to decide on²

35

Grappling with Grendel. To God I am thankful

To be suffered to see thee safe from thy journey."

Beowulf answered, bairn of old

Beowulf narrates his adventures.

Ecgtheow:

"'Tis hidden by no means, Higelac chieftain,

From many of men, the meeting so famous,

40

What mournful moments of me and of Grendel

Were passed in the place where he pressing affliction
On the Victory-Scyldings scathefully brought,
Anguish forever; that all I avengèd,
So that any under heaven of the kinsmen of Grendel

45

Needeth not boast of that cry-in-the-
morning,

Grendel's
kindred have
no cause to
boast.

Who longest liveth of the loth-going
kindred,³

Encompassed by moorland. I came in my journey
To the royal ring-hall, Hrothgar to greet there:

Soon did the famous scion of
Healfdene,

Hrothgar
received me
very cordially.

50

When he understood fully the spirit that led me,
Assign me a seat with the son of his bosom.

The troop was in joyance; mead-glee greater
'Neath arch of the ether not ever beheld I

'Mid hall-building holders. The highly-
famed queen,

The queen also
showed up no
little honor.

55

Peace-tie of peoples, oft passed through the building,
Cheered the young troopers; she oft tendered a hero
A beautiful ring-band, ere she went to her sitting.

Oft the daughter of Hrothgar in view of
the courtiers

Hrothgar's
lovely
daughter.

To the earls at the end the ale-vessel
carried,

60

Whom Freaware I heard then hall-sitters title,
When nail-adorned jewels she gave to the heroes:
Gold-bedecked, youthful, to the glad
son of Froda

She is
betrothed to
Ingeld, in order
to unite the

Her faith has been plighted; the friend
of the Scyldings,

Danes and
Heathobards.

The guard of the kingdom, hath given his sanction,⁴

65

And counts it a vantage, for a part of the quarrels,
A portion of hatred, to pay with the woman.

⁵Somewhere not rarely, when the ruler has fallen,
The life-taking lance relaxeth its fury
For a brief breathing-spell, though the bride be
charming!

- [1] ‘Meodu-scencum’ (1981) some would render ‘with mead-pourers.’ Translate then: *The daughter of Hæreth went through the building accompanied by mead-pourers.*
- [2] See my note to 1599, supra, and B. in P. and B. XII. 97.
- [3] For ‘fenne,’ supplied by Grdtvg., B. suggests ‘fácne’ (cf. Jul. 350). Accepting this, translate: *Who longest lives of the hated race, steeped in treachery.*
- [4] See note to v. 1599 above.
- [5] This is perhaps the least understood sentence in the poem, almost every word being open to dispute. (1) The ‘nó’ of our text is an emendation, and is rejected by many scholars. (2) ‘Seldan’ is by some taken as an adv. (= *seldom*), and by others as a noun (= *page, companion*). (3) ‘Léod-hryre,’ some render ‘*fall of the people*’; others, ‘*fall of the prince*.’ (4) ‘Búgeð,’ most scholars regard as the intrans. verb meaning ‘*bend*,’ ‘*rest*’; but one great scholar has translated it ‘*shall kill*.’ (5) ‘Hwær,’ Very recently, has been attacked, ‘wære’ being suggested. (6) As a corollary to the above, the same critic proposes to drop ‘oft’ out of the text.—t.B. suggests: *Oft seldan wære after léodhryre: lýtle hwíle bongár búgeð, þeah séo brýd duge = often has a treaty been (thus) struck, after a prince had fallen: (but only) a short time is the spear (then) wont to rest, however excellent the bride may be.*

XXX.

BEOWULF NARRATES HIS ADVENTURES TO HIGELAC.

“It well may discomfit the prince of the Heathobards
And each of the thanemen of earls that attend him,
When he goes to the building escorting the woman,
That a noble-born Daneman the knights should be
feasting:

5

There gleam on his person the leavings of elders
Hard and ring-bright, Heathobards’ treasure,
While they wielded their arms, till they misled to the
battle

Their own dear lives and beloved companions.
He saith at the banquet who the collar beholdeth,

10

An ancient ash-warrior who earlmen’s destruction
Clearly recalleth (cruel his spirit),
Sadly beginneth sounding the youthful
Thane-champion’s spirit through the thoughts of his
bosom,

War-grief to waken, and this word-answer speaketh:

15

‘Art thou able, my friend, to know
when thou seest it

Ingeld is
stirred up to
break the truce.

The brand which thy father bare to the conflict
In his latest adventure, ’neath visor of helmet,
The dearly-loved iron, where Danemen did slay him,
And brave-mooded Scyldings, on the fall of the
heroes,

20

(When vengeance was sleeping) the slaughter-place
wielded?

E'en now some man of the murderer's progeny
Exulting in ornaments enters the building,
Boasts of his blood-shedding, offbeareth the jewel
Which thou shouldst wholly hold in possession!'

25

So he urgeth and mindeth on every occasion
With woe-bringing words, till waxeth the season
When the woman's thane for the works of his father,
The bill having bitten, blood-gory sleepeth,
Fated to perish; the other one thenceward

30

'Scapeth alive, the land knoweth thoroughly.¹
Then the oaths of the earlmen on each side are
broken,

When rancors unresting are raging in Ingeld
And his wife-love waxeth less warm after sorrow.
So the Heathobards' favor not faithful I reckon,

35

Their part in the treaty not true to the Danemen,
Their friendship not fast. I further shall tell thee

More about Grendel, that thou fully
mayst hear,

Ornament-giver, what afterward came
from

The hand-rush of heroes. When
heaven's bright jewel

Having made
these
preliminary
statements, I
will now tell
thee of
Grendel, the
monster.

40

O'er earthfields had glided, the stranger came
raging,

The horrible night-fiend, us for to visit,

Where wholly unharmed the hall we were guarding.

Hondscio fell
first

To Hondscio happened a hopeless contention,
Death to the doomed one, dead he fell foremost,

45

Girded war-champion; to him Grendel became then,
To the vassal distinguished, a tooth-weaponed
murderer,

The well-beloved henchman's body all swallowed.

Not the earlier off empty of hand did

The bloody-toothed murderer, mindful of evils,

50

Wish to escape from the gold-giver's palace,

But sturdy of strength he strove to outdo me,

Hand-ready grappled. A glove was suspended

Spacious and wondrous, in art-fetters fastened,

Which was fashioned entirely by touch of the
craftman

55

From the dragon's skin by the devil's devices:

He down in its depths would do me unsadly

One among many, deed-doer raging,

Though sinless he saw me; not so could it happen

When I in my anger upright did stand.

60

'Tis too long to recount how requital I furnished

For every evil to the earlmen's destroyer;

'Twas there, my prince, that I proudly
distinguished

I reflected
honor upon my
people.

Thy land with my labors. He left and
retreated,

He lived his life a little while longer:

65

Yet his right-hand guarded his footstep in Heorot,

And sad-mooded thence to the sea-bottom fell he,

Mournful in mind. For the might-rush of battle

The friend of the Scyldings, with gold
that was plated,
With ornaments many, much requited
me,

King Hrothgar
lavished gifts
upon me.

70

When daylight had dawned, and down to the
banquet
We had sat us together. There was chanting and
joyance:
The age-stricken Scylding asked many questions
And of old-times related; oft light-ringing harp-
strings,
Joy-telling wood, were touched by the brave one;

75

Now he uttered measures, mourning and truthful,
Then the large-hearted land-king a legend of wonder
Truthfully told us. Now troubled with years
The age-hoary warrior afterward began
to
Mourn for the might that marked him
in youth-days;

The old king is
sad over the
loss of his
youthful vigor.

80

His breast within boiled, when burdened with
winters
Much he remembered. From morning till night then
We joyed us therein as etiquette suffered,
Till the second night season came unto earth-folk.
Then early thereafter, the mother of Grendel

85

Was ready for vengeance, wretched she
journeyed;

Grendel's
mother.

Her son had death ravished, the wrath of the
Geatmen.

The horrible woman avenged her offspring,
And with mighty mainstrenght murdered a hero.

There the spirit of Æschere, agèd
adviser,

Æschere falls a
prey to her
vengeance.

90

Was ready to vanish; nor when morn had lightened
Were they anywise suffered to consume him with
fire,

Folk of the Danemen, the death-weakened hero,
Nor the belovèd liegeman to lay on the pyre;

She the corpse had offcarried in the
clutch of the foeman²

She suffered
not his body to
be burned, but
ate it.

95

'Neath mountain-brook's flood. To Hrothgar 'twas
saddest

Of pains that ever had preyed on the chieftain;

By the life of thee the land-prince then me³

Besought very sadly, in sea-currents' eddies

To display my prowess, to peril my safety,

100

Might-deeds accomplish; much did he promise.

I found then the famous flood-current's
cruel,

I sought the
creature in her
den,

Horrible depth-warder. A while unto us
two

Hand was in common; the currents were seething

With gore that was clotted, and Grendel's fierce
mother's

105

Head I offhacked in the hall at the
bottom

and hewed her
head off.

With huge-reaching sword-edge, hardly I wrested

My life from her clutches; not doomed was I then,

But the warden of earlmen afterward
gave me

Jewels were
freely
bestowed upon
me.

Jewels in quantity, kinsman of Healfdene.

- [1] For 'lifigende' (2063), a mere conjecture, 'wígende' has been suggested. The line would then read: *Escapeth by fighting, knows the land thoroughly.*
- [2] For 'fæðmum,' Gr.'s conjecture, B. proposes 'færunga.' These three half-verses would then read: *She bore off the corpse of her foe suddenly under the mountain-torrent.*
- [3] The phrase 'þíne lýfe' (2132) was long rendered 'with thy (presupposed) permission.' The verse would read: *The land-prince then sadly besought me, with thy (presupposed) permission, etc.*

XXXI.

GIFT-GIVING IS MUTUAL.

“So the beloved land-prince lived in decorum;
I had missed no rewards, no meeds of my prowess,
But he gave me jewels, regarding my wishes,
Healfdene his bairn; I’ll bring them to thee, then,

5

Atheling of earlmen, offer them gladly.

All my gifts I
lay at thy feet.

And still unto thee is all my affection:¹

But few of my folk-kin find I surviving

But thee, dear Higelac!” Bade he in then to carry²

The boar-image, banner, battle-high helmet,

10

Iron-gray armor, the excellent weapon,

In song-measures said: “This suit-for-
the-battle

This armor I
have belonged
of yore to
Heregar.

Hrothgar presented me, bade me
expressly,

Wise-mooded atheling, thereafter to tell thee³

The whole of its history, said King Heregar owned it,

15

Dane-prince for long: yet he wished not to give then

The mail to his son, though dearly he loved him,

Hereward the hardy. Hold all in joyance!”

I heard that there followed hard on the jewels

Two braces of stallions of striking resemblance,

20

Dappled and yellow; he granted him usance

Of horses and treasures. So a kinsman should bear
him,

No web of treachery weave for another,

Nor by cunning craftiness cause the destruction
Of trusty companion. Most precious to Higelac loves
Higelac, his nephew
Beowulf.

25

The bold one in battle, was the bairn of his sister,
And each unto other mindful of favors.

I am told that to Hygd he proffered the Beowulf gives
necklace, Hygd the
Wonder-gem rare that Wealhtheow necklace that
gave him, Wealhtheow
had given him.

The troop-leader's daughter, a trio of horses

30

Slender and saddle-bright; soon did the jewel
Embellish her bosom, when the beer-feast was over.
So Ecgtheow's bairn brave did prove him,
War-famous man, by deeds that were Beowulf is
valiant, famous.

He lived in honor, beloved companions

35

Slew not carousing; his mood was not cruel,
But by hand-strength hugest of heroes then living
The brave one retained the bountiful gift that
The Lord had allowed him. Long was he wretched,
So that sons of the Geatmen accounted him
worthless,

40

And the lord of the liegemen loth was to do him
Mickle of honor, when mead-cups were passing;
They fully believed him idle and sluggish,

An indolent atheling: to the honor-blest He is requited
man there for the slights
Came requital for the cuts he had suffered in
suffered. earlier days.

45

Higelac
overwhelms
the conqueror
with gifts.

50

55

After
Heardred's
death, Beowulf
becomes king.

60

He fittingly ruled them a fifty of winters	He rules the Geats fifty years.
---	---------------------------------------

65

The fire-drake.

The heathenish hoard laid hold of with ardor;

70

*	*	*	*	*	*	*
*	*	*	*	*	*	*
*	*	*	*	*	*	*
*	*	*	*	*	*	*
*	*	*	*	*	*	*

- [1] This verse B. renders, ‘*Now serve I again thee alone as my gracious king.*’
- [2] For ‘eafor’ (2153), Kl. suggests ‘ealdor.’ Translate then: *Bade the prince then to bear in the banner, battle-high helmet, etc.* On the other hand, W. takes ‘eaforhéafodsegn’ as a compound, meaning ‘helmet’: *He bade them bear in the helmet, battle-high helm, gray armor, etc.*
- [3] The H.-So. rendering (ærest = *history, origin*; ‘eft’ for ‘est’), though liable to objection, is perhaps the best offered. ‘That I should very early tell thee of his favor, kindness’ sounds well; but ‘his’ is badly placed to limit ‘ést.’—Perhaps, ‘eft’ with verbs of saying may have the force of Lat. prefix ‘re,’ and the H.-So. reading mean, ‘that I should its origin rehearse to thee.’

XXXII.

THE HOARD AND THE DRAGON.

* * * * *

He sought of himself who sorely did harm him,
But, for need very pressing, the servant of one of
The sons of the heroes hate-blows evaded,

5

Seeking for shelter and the sin-driven warrior
Took refuge within there. He early looked in it,

* * * * *

* * * * *

* * * * * when the onset surprised him,

10

The hoard.

He a gem-vessel saw there: many of suchlike
Ancient ornaments in the earth-cave were lying,
As in days of yore some one of men of
Illustrious lineage, as a legacy monstrous,
There had secreted them, careful and thoughtful,

15

Dear-valued jewels. Death had offsnatched them,
In the days of the past, and the one man moreover
Of the flower of the folk who fared there the longest,
Was fain to defer it, friend-mourning warder,
A little longer to be left in enjoyment

20

Of long-lasting treasure.¹ A barrow all-ready
Stood on the plain the stream-currents nigh to,
New by the ness-edge, unneth of approaching:
The keeper of rings carried within a

²Ponderous deal of the treasure of nobles,

25

Of gold that was beaten, briefly he spake then:³

“Hold thou, O Earth, now heroes no
more may,

The ring-giver
bewails the
loss of
retainers.

The earnings of earlmen. Lo! erst in
thy bosom

Worthy men won them; war-death hath ravished,
Perilous life-bale, all my warriors,

30

Liegemen belovèd, who this life have forsaken,
Who hall-pleasures saw. No sword-bearer have I,
And no one to burnish the gold-plated vessel,
The high-valued beaker: my heroes are vanished.
The hardy helmet behung with gilding

35

Shall be reaved of its riches: the ring-cleansers
slumber

Who were charged to have ready visors-for-battle,
And the burnie that bided in battle-encounter
O’er breaking of war-shields the bite of the edges
Moulds with the hero. The ring-twisted armor,

40

Its lord being lifeless, no longer may journey
Hanging by heroes; harp-joy is vanished,
The rapture of glee-wood, no excellent falcon
Swoops through the building, no swift-footed
charger

Grindeth the gravel. A grievous destruction

45

No few of the world-folk widely hath scattered!”
So, woful of spirit one after all
Lamented mournfully, moaning in sadness
By day and by night, till death with its billows

Dashed on his spirit. Then the ancient The fire-
dusk-scather dragon

50

Found the great treasure standing all open,
He who flaming and fiery flies to the barrows,
Naked war-dragon, nightly escapeth
Encompassed with fire; men under heaven
Widely beheld him. 'Tis said that he looks for⁴

55

The hoard in the earth, where old he is guarding
The heathenish treasure; he'll be nowise the better.

So three-hundred winters the waster of The dragon
peoples meets his
match.

Held upon earth that excellent hoard-
hall,

Till the forementioned earlman angered him bitterly:

60

The beat-plated beaker he bare to his chieftain
And fullest remission for all his remissness
Begged of his liegelord. Then the hoard⁵ was
discovered,

The treasure was taken, his petition was granted

The lorn-mooded liegeman. His lord The hero
regarded plunders the
dragon's den

65

The old-work of earth-folk—'twas the earliest
occasion.

When the dragon awoke, the strife was renewed
there;

He snuffed 'long the stone then, stout-hearted found
he

The footprint of foeman; too far had he gone
With cunning craftiness close to the head of

70

The fire-spewing dragon. So undoomed he may
'scape from
Anguish and exile with ease who possesseth
The favor of Heaven. The hoard-warden eagerly
Searched o'er the ground then, would meet with the
person
That caused him sorrow while in slumber reclining:

75

Gleaming and wild he oft went round the cavern,
All of it outward; not any of earthmen
Was seen in that desert.⁶ Yet he joyed in the battle,
Rejoiced in the conflict: oft he turned to the barrow,
Sought for the gem-cup;⁷ this he soon perceived then

80

That some man or other had discovered
the gold,
The famous folk-treasure. Not fain did
the hoard-ward

The dragon
perceives that
some one has
disturbed his
treasure.

Wait until evening; then the ward of the barrow
Was angry in spirit, the loathèd one wished to
Pay for the dear-valued drink-cup with fire.

85

Then the day was done as the dragon would have it,
He no longer would wait on the wall, but departed
Fire-impelled, flaming. Fearful the
start was

The dragon is
infuriated.

To earls in the land, as it early thereafter
To their giver-of-gold was grievously ended.

[1] For 'long-gestréona,' B. suggests 'láengestréona,' and renders, *Of fleeting treasures*. S. accepts H.'s 'long-gestréona,' but renders, *The treasure long in accumulating*.

[2] For 'hard-fyrdne' (2246), B. first suggested 'hard-fyndne,' rendering: *A heap of treasures ... so great that its equal would be hard to find*. The same scholar suggests later 'hord-wynne dæl' = *A deal of treasure-joy*.

- [3] Some read 'fec-word' (2247), and render: *Banning words uttered.*
- [4] An earlier reading of H.'s gave the following meaning to this passage: *He is said to inhabit a mound under the earth, where he, etc.* The translation in the text is more authentic.
- [5] The repetition of 'hord' in this passage has led some scholars to suggest new readings to avoid the second 'hord.' This, however, is not under the main stress, and, it seems to me, might easily be accepted.
- [6] The reading of H.-So. is well defended in the notes to that volume. B. emends and renders: *Nor was there any man in that desert who rejoiced in conflict, in battle-work.* That is, the hoard-ward could not find any one who had disturbed his slumbers, for no warrior was there, t.B.'s emendation would give substantially the same translation.
- [7] 'Sinc-fæt' (2301): this word both here and in v. 2232, t.B. renders 'treasure.'

XXXIII.

BRAVE THOUGH AGED.— REMINISCENCES.

The stranger began then to vomit forth The dragon
fire, spits fire.

To burn the great manor; the blaze then glimmered
For anguish to earlmen, not anything living
Was the hateful air-goer willing to leave there.

5

The war of the worm widely was noticed,
The feud of the foeman afar and anear,
How the enemy injured the earls of the Geatmen,
Harried with hatred: back he hied to the treasure,
To the well-hidden cavern ere the coming of
daylight.

10

He had circled with fire the folk of those regions,
With brand and burning; in the barrow he trusted,
In the wall and his war-might: the weening deceived
him.

Then straight was the horror to Beowulf hears
Beowulf published, of the havoc
Early forsooth, that his own native wrought by the
homestead,¹ dragon.

15

The best of buildings, was burning and melting,
Gift-seat of Geatmen. 'Twas a grief to the spirit
Of the good-mooded hero, the greatest of sorrows:

The wise one weened then that He fears that
wielding his kingdom Heaven is
punishing him

'Gainst the ancient commandments, he
had bitterly angered

20

The Lord everlasting: with lorn meditations
His bosom welled inward, as was nowise his custom.
The fire-spewing dragon fully had wasted
The fastness of warriors, the water-land outward,
The manor with fire. The folk-ruling hero,

25

Prince of the Weders, was planning to wreak him.
The warmen's defender bade them to make him,
Earlmen's atheling, an excellent war-shield

Wholly of iron: fully he knew then	He orders an
That wood from the forest was helpless	iron shield to
to aid him,	be made from
	him, wood is
	useless.

30

Shield against fire. The long-worthy ruler
Must live the last of his limited earth-days,
Of life in the world and the worm along with him,
Though he long had been holding hoard-wealth in
plenty.

Then the ring-prince disdained to seek
with a war-band,

He determines
to fight alone.

35

With army extensive, the air-going ranger;
He felt no fear of the foeman's assaults and
He counted for little the might of the dragon,
His power and prowess: for previously dared he
A heap of hostility, hazarded dangers, Beowulf

40

War-thane, when Hrothgar's palace he
cleansèd,

Conquering combatant, clutched in the battle
The kinsmen of Grendel, of kindred detested.²

'Twas of hand-fights not least where Higelac's death
Higelac was slaughtered, recalled.

When the king of the Geatmen with clashings of
battle,

45

Friend-lord of folks in Frisian dominions,
Offspring of Hrethrel perished through sword-drink,
With battle-swords beaten; thence Beowulf came
then

On self-help relying, swam through the waters;
He bare on his arm, lone-going, thirty

50

Outfits of armor, when the ocean he mounted.
The Hetwars by no means had need to be boastful
Of their fighting afoot, who forward to meet him
Carried their war-shields: not many returned from
The brave-mooded battle-knight back to their
homesteads.

55

Ecgtheow's bairn o'er the bight-courses swam then,
Lone-goer lorn to his land-folk returning,
Where Hygd to him tendered treasure and kingdom,
Rings and dominion: her son she not Heardred's
trusted, lack of
To be able to keep the kingdom capacity to
devised him rule.

60

'Gainst alien races, on the death of King Higelac.
Yet the sad ones succeeded not in Beowulf's tact
persuading the atheling and delicacy
In any way ever, to act as a suzerain recalled.
To Heardred, or promise to govern the kingdom;
Yet with friendly counsel in the folk he sustained
him,

65

Gracious, with honor, till he grew to be older,	
Wielded the Weders. Wide-fleeing	Reference is
outlaws,	here made to a
Ohthere's sons, sought him o'er the	visit which
waters:	Beowulf
They had stirred a revolt 'gainst the	receives from
helm of the Scylfings,	Eanmund and
The best of the sea-kings, who in	Eadgils, why
Swedish dominions	they come is
	not known.

70

Distributed treasure, distinguished folk-leader.
'Twas the end of his earth-days; injury fatal³
By swing of the sword he received as a greeting,
Offspring of Higelac; Ongentheow's bairn
Later departed to visit his homestead,

75

When Heardred was dead; let Beowulf rule them,
Govern the Geatmen: good was that folk-king.

[1] 'Hám' (2326), the suggestion of B. is accepted by t.B. and other scholars.

[2] For 'láðan cynnes' (2355), t.B. suggests 'láðan cynne,' apposition to 'mægum.' From syntactical and other considerations, this is a most excellent emendation.

[3] Gr. read 'on feorme' (2386), rendering: *He there at the banquet a fatal wound received by blows of the sword.*

XXXIV.

BEOWULF SEEKS THE DRAGON.—BEOWULF'S REMINISCENCES.

He planned requital for the folk-leader's ruin
In days thereafter, to Eadgils the wretched
Becoming an enemy. Ohthere's son then
Went with a war-troop o'er the wide-stretching
currents

5

With warriors and weapons: with woe-journeys cold
he

After avenged him, the king's life he took.

So he came off uninjured from all of
his battles,

Beowulf has
been preserved
through many
perils.

Perilous fights, offspring of Ecgtheow,

From his deeds of daring, till that day most
momentous

10

When he fate-driven fared to fight with the dragon.

With eleven companions the prince of
the Geatmen

With eleven
comrades, he
seeks the
dragon.

Went lowering with fury to look at the
fire-drake:

Inquiring he'd found how the feud had arisen,

Hate to his heroes; the highly-famed gem-vessel

15

Was brought to his keeping through the hand of th'
informer.

That in the throng was thirteenth of
heroes,

A guide leads
the way, but

That caused the beginning of conflict so bitter,
Captive and wretched, must sad-mooded thenceward
Point out the place: he passed then very
unwillingly reluctantly.

20

25

30

Dragging aloof his life from his body:
Not flesh-hidden long was the folk-leader's spirit.
Beowulf spake, Ecgtheow's son:

“I survived in my youth-days many a
conflict,

High-lord of heroes, at the hands of my father,
Hrethel the hero-king had me in keeping,

40

Not ever was I *any* less dear to him
Knight in the boroughs, than the bairns He treated me
of his household, as a son.

Herebald and Hæthcyn and Higelac mine.
To the eldest unjustly by acts of a kinsman
45

Was murder-bed strewn, since him Hæthcyn from
horn-bow

His sheltering chieftain shot with an One of the
arrow, brothers
Erred in his aim and injured his accidentally
kinsman, kills another.

One brother the other, with blood-sprinkled spear:
'Twas a feeless fight, finished in
malice,

50 No fee could
compound for
such a
calamity.

Sad to his spirit; the folk-prince
however

Had to part from existence with vengeance untaken.
So to hoar-headed hero 'tis heavily [A parallel case
crushing¹ is supposed.]

To live to see his son as he rideth
Young on the gallows: then measures he chanteth,
55

A song of sorrow, when his son is hanging
For the raven's delight, and aged and hoary
He is unable to offer any assistance.

Every morning his offspring's departure
Is constant recalled: he cares not to wait for
60

The birth of an heir in his borough-enclosures,
Since that one through death-pain the deeds hath
experienced.

He heart-grieved beholds in the house of his son the

Wine-building wasted, the wind-lodging places
Reaved of their roaring; the riders are sleeping,

65

The knights in the grave; there's no sound of the
harp-wood,
Joy in the yards, as of yore were familiar.

- [1] 'Gomelum ceorle' (2445).—H. takes these words as referring to Hrethel; but the translator here departs from his editor by understanding the poet to refer to a hypothetical old man, introduced as an illustration of a father's sorrow.

Hrethrel had certainly never seen a son of his ride on the gallows to feed the crows.

The passage beginning 'swá bið géomorlic' seems to be an effort to reach a full simile, 'as ... so.' 'As it is mournful for an old man, etc. ... so the defence of the Weders (2463) bore heart-sorrow, etc.' The verses 2451 to 2463½ would be parenthetical, the poet's feelings being so strong as to interrupt the simile. The punctuation of the fourth edition would be better—a comma after 'galgan' (2447). The translation may be indicated as follows: *(Just) as it is sad for an old man to see his son ride young on the gallows when he himself is uttering mournful measures, a sorrowful song, while his son hangs for a comfort to the raven, and he, old and infirm, cannot render him any kelp—(he is constantly reminded, etc., 2451-2463)—so the defence of the Weders, etc.*

XXXV.

REMINISCENCES (*continued*).— BEOWULF'S LAST BATTLE.

“He seeks then his chamber, singeth a woe-song
One for the other; all too extensive
Seemed homesteads and plains. So the helm of the
Wegers

Mindful of Herebald heart-sorrow
carried,

Hrethel grieves
for Herebald.

5

Stirred with emotion, nowise was able
To wreak his ruin on the ruthless destroyer:
He was unable to follow the warrior with hatred,
With deeds that were direful, though dear he not held
him.

Then pressed by the pang this pain occasioned him,
10

He gave up glee, God-light elected;
He left to his sons, as the man that is rich does,
His land and fortress, when from life he departed.

Then was crime and hostility 'twixt
Swedes and Geatmen,

Strife between
Swedes and
Geats.

O'er wide-stretching water warring
was mutual,

15

Burdensome hatred, when Hrethel had perished,
And Ongentheow's offspring were active and
valiant,

Wished not to hold to peace oversea, but
Round Hreosna-beorh often accomplished
Cruellest massacre. This my kinsman avengèd,

The feud and fury, as 'tis found on inquiry,
Though one of them paid it with forfeit of life-joys,
With price that was hard: the struggle Hæthcyn's fall
 became then at
 Ravenswood.
Fatal to Hæthcyn, lord of the Geatmen.
Then I heard that at morning one brother the other

With edges of irons egged on to murder,
Where Ongentheow maketh onset on Eofor:
The helmet crashed, the hoary-haired Scylfing
Sword-smitten fell, his hand then remembered
Feud-hate sufficient, refused not the death-blow.

The gems that he gave me, with jewel-
bright sword I

'Quited in contest, as occasion was offered:
Land he allowed me, life-joy at homestead,
Manor to live on. Little he needed
From Gepids or Danes or in Sweden to look for

Trooper less true, with treasure to buy him;
'Mong foot-soldiers ever in front I would hie me,
Alone in the vanguard, and evermore gladly
Warfare shall wage, while this weapon endureth
That late and early often did serve me

When I proved before heroes the slayer
of Dæghrefn,
Knight of the Hugmen: he by no means
was suffered

To the king of the Frisians to carry the jewels,
The breast-decoration; but the banner-possessor
Bowed in the battle, brave-mooded atheling.

No weapon was slayer, but war-grapple broke then
 The surge of his spirit, his body destroying.
 Now shall weapon's edge make war for the treasure,
 And hand and firm-sword." Beowulf spake then,
 Boast-words uttered—the latest occasion:

50

"I braved in my youth-days battles
 unnumbered;
 Still am I willing the struggle to look
 for,

He boasts of
 his youthful
 prowess, and
 declares
 himself still
 fearless.

Fame-deeds perform, folk-warden prudent,
 If the hateful despoiler forth from his cavern
 Seeketh me out!" Each of the heroes,

55

Helm-bearers sturdy, he thereupon greeted
 Belovèd co-liegemen—his last
 salutation:

His last
 salutations.

"No brand would I bear, no blade for the dragon,
 Wist I a way my word-boast to 'complish¹
 Else with the monster, as with Grendel I did it;

60

But fire in the battle hot I expect there,
 Furious flame-burning: so I fixed on my body
 Target and war-mail. The ward of the barrow²
 I'll not flee from a foot-length, the foeman uncanny.
 At the wall 'twill befall us as Fate decreeth,

65

Each one's Creator. I am eager in spirit,
 With the wingèd war-hero to away with all boasting.
 Bide on the barrow with burnies protected,
 Earls in armor, which of *us* two may
 better

Let Fate decide
 between us.

Wait ye here
 till the battle is
 over.

Bear his disaster, when the battle is over.

70

'Tis no matter of yours, and man cannot do it,
But me and me only, to measure his strength with
The monster of malice, might-deeds to 'complish.
I with prowess shall gain the gold, or the battle,
Direful death-woe will drag off your ruler!"

75

The mighty champion rose by his shield then,
Brave under helmet, in battle-mail went he
'Neath steep-rising stone-cliffs, the strength he relied
on

Of one man alone: no work for a coward.

Then he saw by the wall who a great many battles

80

Had lived through, most worthy, when foot-troops
collided,

Stone-arches standing, stout-hearted
champion,

The place of
strife is
described.

Saw a brook from the barrow bubbling
out thenceward:

The flood of the fountain was fuming with war-
flame:

Not nigh to the hoard, for season the briefest

85

Could he brave, without burning, the abyss that was
yawning,

The drake was so fiery. The prince of the Weders
Caused then that words came from his bosom,
So fierce was his fury; the firm-hearted shouted:
His battle-clear voice came in resounding

90

'Neath the gray-colored stone. Stirred was his
hatred,

The hoard-ward distinguished the
speech of a man; Beowulf calls
out under the
stone arches.

Time was no longer to look out for
friendship.

The breath of the monster issued forth first,
Vapory war-sweat, out of the stone-cave:

95 The terrible
encounter.

The earth re-echoed. The earl 'neath
the barrow

Lifted his shield, lord of the Geatmen,
Tow'rd the terrible stranger: the ring-twisted
creature's

Heart was then ready to seek for a struggle.

The excellent battle-king first
brandished his weapon, Beowulf
brandishes his
sword,

100

The ancient heirloom, of edges unblunted,³
To the death-planners twain was terror from other.

The lord of the troopers intrepidly
stood then and stands
against his
shield.

'Gainst his high-rising shield, when the
dragon coiled him

Quickly together: in corslet he bided. The dragon
coils himself.

105

He went then in blazes, bended and striding,
Hasting him forward. His life and body
The targe well protected, for time-period shorter
Than wish demanded for the well-renowned leader,
Where he then for the first day was forced to be
victor,

110

Famous in battle, as Fate had not willed it.
The lord of the Geatmen uplifted his hand then,
Smiting the fire-drake with sword that was precious,

That bright on the bone the blade-edge did weaken,
Bit more feebly than his folk-leader needed,
115

Burdened with bale-griefs. Then the barrow-
protector,

When the sword-blow had fallen, was The dragon
fierce in his spirit, rages

Flinging his fires, flamings of battle

Gleamed then afar: the gold-friend of Weders

Boasted no conquests, his battle-sword Beowulf's
failed him sword fails
him.

120

Naked in conflict, as by no means it ought to,
Long-trusty weapon. 'Twas no slight undertaking
That Ecgtheow's famous offspring would leave
The drake-cavern's bottom; he must live in some
region

Other than this, by the will of the dragon,

125

As each one of earthmen existence must forfeit.

'Twas early thereafter the excellent warriors

Met with each other. Anew and afresh The combat is
The hoard-ward took heart (gasps renewed.
heaved then his bosom):

Sorrow he suffered encircled with fire The great hero
130 is reduced to
extremities.

Who the people erst governed. His
companions by no means

Were banded about him, bairns of the princes,

With valorous spirit, but they sped to His comrades
the forest, flee!

Seeking for safety. The soul-deeps of one were

Ruffled by care: kin-love can never Blood is
135 thicker than
water.

Aught in him waver who well doth consider.

- [1] The clause 2520(2)-2522(1), rendered by 'Wist I ... monster,' Gr., followed by S., translates substantially as follows: *If I knew how else I might combat the boastful defiance of the monster.*—The translation turns upon 'wiðgrípan,' a word not understood.
- [2] B. emends and translates: *I will not flee the space of a foot from the guard of the barrow, but there shall be to us a fight at the wall, as fate decrees, each one's Creator.*
- [3] The translation of this passage is based on 'unsláw' (2565), accepted by H.-So., in lieu of the long-standing 'ungléaw.' The former is taken as an adj. limiting 'sweord'; the latter as an adj. c. 'gúð-cyning': *The good war-king, rash with edges, brandished his sword, his old relic.* The latter gives a more rhetorical Anglo-Saxon (poetical) sentence.

XXXVI.

WIGLAF THE TRUSTY.— BEOWULF IS DESERTED BY FRIENDS AND BY SWORD.

The son of Weohstan was Wiglaf
entitled,
Shield-warrior precious, prince of the
Scylfings,
Ælfhere's kinsman: he saw his dear liegelord
Enduring the heat 'neath helmet and visor.

Wiglaf remains
true—the ideal
Teutonic
liegeman.

5
Then he minded the holding that erst he had given
him,

The Wægmunding warriors' wealth-
blessèd homestead,
Each of the folk-rights his father had
wielded;

Wiglaf recalls
Beowulf's
generosity.

He was hot for the battle, his hand seized the target,
The yellow-bark shield, he unsheathed his old
weapon,

10
Which was known among earthmen as the relic of
Eanmund,

Ohthere's offspring, whom, exiled and friendless,
Weohstan did slay with sword-edge in battle,
And carried his kinsman the clear-shining helmet,
The ring-made burnie, the old giant-weapon

15
That Onela gave him, his boon-fellow's armor,
Ready war-trappings: he the feud did not mention,
Though he'd fatally smitten the son of his brother.

Many a half-year held he the treasures,
The bill and the burnie, till his bairn became able,
20

Like his father before him, fame-deeds to 'complish;
Then he gave him 'mong Geatmen a goodly array of
Weeds for his warfare; he went from life then
Old on his journey. 'Twas the earliest time then

That the youthful champion might
charge in the battle

This is
Wiglaf's first
battle as
liegeman of
Beowulf.

25
Aiding his liegelord; his spirit was
dauntless.

Nor did kinsman's bequest quail at the battle:
This the dragon discovered on their coming together.
Wiglaf uttered many a right-saying,
Said to his fellows, sad was his spirit:

30
"I remember the time when, tasting the
mead-cup,

Wiglaf appeals
to the pride of
the cowards.

We promised in the hall the lord of us all
Who gave us these ring-treasures, that this battle-
equipment,
Swords and helmets, we'd certainly quite him,
Should need of such aid ever befall him:

35
In the war-band he chose us for this
journey spontaneously,

How we have
forfeited our
liegelord's
confidence!

Stirred us to glory and gave me these
jewels,

Since he held and esteemed us trust-worthy
spearmen,

Hardy helm-bearers, though this hero-achievement
Our lord intended alone to accomplish,

40

Ward of his people, for most of achievements,
Doings audacious, he did among earth-folk.
The day is now come when the ruler of earthmen Our lord is in
Needeth the vigor of valiant heroes: sore need of
Let us wend us towards him, the war-prince to us.
succor,

45

While the heat yet rageth, horrible fire-fight.
God wot in me, 'tis mickle the liefer I would rather
The blaze should embrace my body die than go
and eat it home with out
With my treasure-bestower. Meseemeth not proper my suzerain.
To bear our battle-shields back to our country,

50

'Less first we are able to fell and destroy the
Long-hating foeman, to defend the life of
The prince of the Weders. Well do I Surely he does
know 'tish't not deserve to
Earned by his exploits, he only of die alone.
Geatmen

Sorrow should suffer, sink in the battle:

55

Brand and helmet to us both shall be common,
¹Shield-cover, burnie." Through the bale-smoke he
stalked then,

Went under helmet to the help of his chieftain,
Briefly discoursing: "Beowulf dear, Wiglaf reminds
Perform thou all fully, as thou formerly Beowulf of his
saidst, youthful
boasts.

60

In thy youthful years, that while yet thou livedst
Thou wouldst let thine honor not ever be lessened.
Thy life thou shalt save, mighty in actions,

Atheling undaunted, with all of thy vigor;
I'll give thee assistance." The dragon The monster
came raging, advances on
65 them.

Wild-mooded stranger, when these words had been
uttered

('Twas the second occasion), seeking his enemies,
Men that were hated, with hot-gleaming fire-waves;
With blaze-billows burned the board to its edges:
The fight-armor failed then to furnish assistance

70
To the youthful spear-hero: but the young-aged
stripling

Quickly advanced 'neath his kinsman's war-target,
Since his own had been ground in the grip of the
fire.

Then the warrior-king was careful of Beowulf
glory, strikes at the
He soundly smote with sword-for-the- dragon.
battle,

75
That it stood in the head by hatred driven;
Nægling was shivered, the old and iron-made
Brand of Beowulf in battle deceived His sword fails
him. him.

'Twas denied him that edges of irons were able
To help in the battle; the hand was too mighty
80

²Which every weapon, as I heard on inquiry,
Outstruck in its stroke, when to struggle he carried
The wonderful war-sword: it waxed him no better.
Then the people-despoiler—third of his The dragon
onsets— advances on
Beowulf again.

Fierce-raging fire-drake, of feud-hate was mindful,

85

Charged on the strong one, when chance was
afforded,

Heated and war-grim, seized on his neck

With teeth that were bitter; he bloody did wax with
Soul-gore seething; sword-blood in waves boiled.

[1] The passage '*Brand ... burnie*,' is much disputed. In the first place, some eminent critics assume a gap of at least two half-verses. — '*Úrum*' (2660), being a peculiar form, has been much discussed. '*Byrdu-scrúd*' is also a crux. B. suggests '*býwdu-scrúd*' = *splendid vestments*. Nor is '*bám*' accepted by all, '*béon*' being suggested. Whatever the individual words, the passage must mean, "*I intend to share with him my equipments of defence.*"

[2] B. would render: *Which, as I heard, excelled in stroke every sword that he carried to the strife, even the strongest (sword).* For '*Þonne*' he reads '*Þone*,' rel. pr.

XXXVII.

THE FATAL STRUGGLE.— BEOWULF'S LAST MOMENTS.

Then I heard that at need of the king of Wiglaf defends
the people Beowulf.

The upstanding earlman exhibited prowess,
Vigor and courage, as suited his nature;

¹He his head did not guard, but the high-minded
liegeman's

5

Hand was consumed, when he succored his kinsman,
So he struck the strife-bringing strange-comer lower,
Earl-thane in armor, that *in* went the weapon

Gleaming and plated, that 'gan then the fire²

Later to lessen. The liegelord himself Beowulf draws
then his knife,

10

Retained his consciousness, brandished his war-
knife,

Battle-sharp, bitter, that he bare on his armor:

The Weder-lord cut the worm in the and cuts the
middle. dragon.

They had felled the enemy (life drove out then³

Puissant prowess), the pair had destroyed him,

15

Land-chiefs related: so a liegeman should prove him,
A thaneman when needed. To the prince 'twas the
last of

His era of conquest by his own great achievements,

The latest of world-deeds. The wound Beowulf's
then began wound swells

Which the earth-dwelling dragon
erstwhile had wrought him

20

To burn and to swell. He soon then discovered
That bitterest bale-woe in his bosom was raging,
Poison within. The atheling advanced then,
That along by the wall, he prudent of spirit He sits do
exhausted

Might sit on a settle; he saw the giant-work,

25

How arches of stone strengthened with pillars
The earth-hall eternal inward supported.
Then the long-worthy liegeman laved with his hand
the

Far-famous chieftain, gory from
sword-edge,

Wiglaf bathes
his lord's head.

Refreshing the face of his friend-lord and ruler,

30

Sated with battle, unbinding his helmet.
Beowulf answered, of his injury spake he,
His wound that was fatal (he was fully aware
He had lived his allotted life-days enjoying
The pleasures of earth; then past was entirely

35

His measure of days, death very near):

“My son I would give now my battle-
equipments,

Beowulf
regrets that he
has no son.

Had any of heirs been after me granted,
Along of my body. This people I governed
Fifty of winters: no king 'mong my neighbors

40

Dared to encounter me with comrades-in-battle,
Try me with terror. The time to me ordered
I bided at home, mine own kept fitly,

Sought me no snares, swore me not many	
Oaths in injustice. Joy over all this	I can rejoice in
45	a well-spent
	life.
I'm able to have, though ill with my	
death-wounds;	
Hence the Ruler of Earthmen need not charge me	
With the killing of kinsmen, when cometh my life	
out	
Forth from my body. Fare thou with haste now	
To behold the hoard 'neath the hoar-	Bring me the
grayish stone,	hoard, Wiglaf,
50	that my dying
	eyes may be
Well-lovèd Wiglaf, now the worm is a-	refreshed by a
lying,	sight of it.
Sore-wounded sleepeth, disseized of his treasure.	
Go thou in haste that treasures of old I,	
Gold-wealth may gaze on, together see lying	
The ether-bright jewels, be easier able,	
55	
Having the heap of hoard-gems, to yield my	
Life and the land-folk whom long I have governed."	

[1] B. renders: *He (W.) did not regard his (the dragon's) head* (since Beowulf had struck it without effect), *but struck the dragon a little lower down*.—One crux is to find out *whose head* is meant; another is to bring out the antithesis between 'head' and 'hand.'

[2] 'Ðæt þæt fyr' (2702), S. emends to 'þá þæt fyr' = *when the fire began to grow less intense afterward*. This emendation relieves the passage of a plethora of conjunctive *þæt*'s.

[3] For 'gefylðan' (2707), S. proposes 'gefylde.' The passage would read: *He felled the foe (life drove out strength), and they then both had destroyed him, chieftains related*. This gives Beowulf the credit of having felled the dragon; then they combine to annihilate him.—For 'ellen' (2707), Kl. suggests 'e(a)llne.'—The reading '*life drove out strength*' is very unsatisfactory and very peculiar. I would suggest as follows: Adopt S.'s emendation, remove H.'s parenthesis, read 'ferh-ellen wræc,' and translate: *He felled the foe, drove out his life-strength* (that is, made him *hors de combat*), and then they both, etc.

XXXVIII.

**WIGLAF PLUNDERS THE
DRAGON'S DEN.—BEOWULF'S
DEATH.**

Then heard I that Wihstan's son very
quickly,
These words being uttered, heeded his
liegelord

Wiglaf fulfils
his lord's
behest.

Wounded and war-sick, went in his armor,
His well-woven ring-mail, 'neath the roof of the
barrow.

5

Then the trusty retainer treasure-gems many
Victorious saw, when the seat he came The
near to, den

The dragon's
den.

Gold-treasure sparkling spread on the bottom,
Wonder on the wall, and the worm-creature's cavern,
The ancient dawn-flier's, vessels a-standing,

10

Cups of the ancients of cleansers bereavèd,
Robbed of their ornaments: there were helmets in
numbers,

Old and rust-eaten, arm-bracelets many,
Artfully woven. Wealth can easily,

Gold on the sea-bottom, turn into vanity¹

15

Each one of earthmen, arm him who pleaseth!
And he saw there lying an all-golden banner
High o'er the hoard, of hand-wonders greatest,
Linkèd with lacets: a light from it sparkled,

That the floor of the cavern he was able to look on,
20 The dragon is not there.

To examine the jewels. Sight of the
dragon

Not any was offered, but edge offcarried him.

Then I heard that the hero the hoard-
treasure plundered, Wiglaf bears the hoard away.

The giant-work ancient reaved in the
cavern,

Bare on his bosom the beakers and platters,

25

As himself would fain have it, and took off the
standard,

The brightest of beacons;² the bill had erst injured
(Its edge was of iron), the old-ruler's weapon,
Him who long had watched as ward of the jewels,
Who fire-terror carried hot for the treasure,

30

Rolling in battle, in middlemost darkness,
Till murdered he perished. The messenger hastened,
Not loth to return, hurried by jewels:

Curiosity urged him if, excellent-mooded,
Alive he should find the lord of the Weders

35

Mortally wounded, at the place where he left him.
'Mid the jewels he found then the famous old
chieftain,

His liegelord beloved, at his life's-end gory:
He thereupon 'gan to lave him with water,
Till the point of his word piercèd his breast-hoard.

40

Beowulf spake (the gold-gems he noticed),

The old one in sorrow: "For the jewels
I look on Beowulf is rejoiced to see the jewels.

Thanks do I utter for all to the Ruler,
Wielder of Worship, with words of devotion,
The Lord everlasting, that He let me such treasures

45

Gain for my people ere death overtook me.
Since I've bartered the aged life to me granted
For treasure of jewels, attend ye henceforward

The wants of the war-thanes; I can wait He desires to
 here no longer. be held in
 memory by his

The battle-famed bid ye to build them a people.
 grave-hill,

50

Bright when I'm burned, at the brim-current's limit;
As a memory-mark to the men I have governed,
Aloft it shall tower on Whale's-Ness uprising,
That earls of the ocean hereafter may call it
Beowulf's barrow, those who barks ever-dashing

55

From a distance shall drive o'er the darkness of
 waters."

The bold-mooded troop-lord took from The hero's last
 his neck then gift

The ring that was golden, gave to his liegeman,
The youthful war-hero, his gold-flashing helmet,
His collar and war-mail, bade him well to enjoy
 them:

60

and last words.

"Thou art latest left of the line of our kindred,
Of Wægmunding people: Weird hath offcarried
All of my kinsmen to the Creator's glory,
Earls in their vigor: I shall after them fare."

'Twas the aged liegelord's last-spoken word in

65

His musings of spirit, ere he mounted the fire,

The battle-waves burning: from his bosom departed
His soul to seek the sainted ones' glory.

- [1] The word 'oferhígian' (2767) being vague and little understood, two quite distinct translations of this passage have arisen. One takes 'oferhígian' as meaning 'to exceed,' and, inserting 'hord' after 'gehwone,' renders: *The treasure may easily, the gold in the ground, exceed in value every hoard of man, hide it who will.* The other takes 'oferhígian' as meaning 'to render arrogant,' and, giving the sentence a moralizing tone, renders substantially as in the body of this work. (Cf. 28 13 et seq.)
- [2] The passage beginning here is very much disputed. 'The bill of the old lord' is by some regarded as Beowulf's sword; by others, as that of the ancient possessor of the hoard. 'Ær gescód' (2778), translated in this work as verb and adverb, is by some regarded as a compound participial adj. = *sheathed in brass.*

XXXIX.

THE DEAD FOES.—WIGLAF'S BITTER TAUNTS.

It had wofully chanced then the
youthful retainer
To behold on earth the most ardent-
belovèd

Wiglaf is
sorely grieved
to see his lord
look so un-
warlike.

At his life-days' limit, lying there helpless.
The slayer too lay there, of life all bereavèd,

5

Horrible earth-drake, harassed with sorrow:

The round-twisted monster was
permitted no longer

The dragon has
plundered his
last hoard.

To govern the ring-hoards, but edges of
war-swords

Mightily seized him, battle-sharp, sturdy
Leavings of hammers, that still from his wounds

10

The flier-from-farland fell to the earth
Hard by his hoard-house, hopped he at midnight
Not e'er through the air, nor exulting in jewels
Suffered them to see him: but he sank then to
earthward

Through the hero-chief's handwork. I heard sure it
throve then

15

But few in the land of liegemen of
valor,

Few warriors
dared to face
the monster.

Though of every achievement bold he had proved
him,

To run 'gainst the breath of the venomous scather,

Or the hall of the treasure to trouble with hand-
blows,

If he watching had found the ward of the hoard-hall

20

On the barrow abiding. Beowulf's part of
The treasure of jewels was paid for with death;
Each of the twain had attained to the end of
Life so unlasting. Not long was the time till

The tardy-at-battle returned from the
thicket,

The cowardly
thanes come
out of the
thicket.

25

The timid truce-breakers ten all
together,

Who durst not before play with the lances
In the prince of the people's pressing emergency;

But blushing with shame, with shields
they betook them,

They are
ashamed of
their desertion.

With arms and armor where the old
one was lying:

30

They gazed upon Wiglaf. He was sitting exhausted,
Foot-going fighter, not far from the shoulders
Of the lord of the people, would rouse him with
water;

No whit did it help him; though he hoped for it
keenly,

He was able on earth not at all in the leader

35

Life to retain, and nowise to alter

The will of the Wielder; the World-Ruler's power¹

Would govern the actions of each one of heroes,

As yet He is doing. From the young
one forthwith then

Wiglaf is ready
to excoriate
them.

Could grim-worded greeting be got for him quickly

40

Whose courage had failed him. Wiglaf discoursed
then,

Weohstan his son, sad-mooded hero,

Looked on the hated: "He who
soothness will utter

He begins to
taunt them.

Can say that the liegelord who gave you the jewels,
The ornament-armor wherein ye are standing,

45

When on ale-bench often he offered to hall-men
Helmet and burnie, the prince to his liegemen,
As best upon earth he was able to find him,—

That he wildly wasted his war-gear
undoubtedly

Surely our lord
wasted his
armor on
poltroons.

When battle o'ertook him.² The troop-
king no need had

50

To glory in comrades; yet God permitted him,

Victory-Wielder, with weapon unaided

Himself to avenge, when vigor was
needed.

He, however,
got along
without you

I life-protection but little was able

To give him in battle, and I 'gan, notwithstanding,

55

Helping my kinsman (my strength
overtaxing):

With some aid,
I could have
saved our
liegelord

He waxed the weaker when with
weapon I smote on

My mortal opponent, the fire less strongly

Flamed from his bosom. Too few of protectors

Came round the king at the critical moment.

60

Gift-giving is
over with your
people: the

Now must ornament-taking and	ring-lord is
weapon-bestowing,	dead.
Home-joyance all, cease for your kindred,	
Food for the people; each of your warriors	
Must needs be bereavèd of rights that he holdeth	
In landed possessions, when faraway nobles	
65	
Shall learn of your leaving your lord so basely,	
The dastardly deed. Death is more	What is life
pleasant	without honor?
To every earlman than infamous life is!"	

[1] For 'dædum rædan' (2859) B. suggests 'déað árædan,' and renders:
The might (or judgment) of God would determine death for every man, as he still does.

[2] Some critics, H. himself in earlier editions, put the clause, 'When ... him' (A.-S. 'þá ... beget') with the following sentence; that is, they make it dependent upon 'þorfte' (2875) instead of upon 'forwurpe' (2873).

XL.

THE MESSENGER OF DEATH.

Then he charged that the battle be
announced at the hedge
Up o'er the cliff-edge, where the earl-
troopers bided
The whole of the morning, mood-
wretched sat them,

Wiglaf sends
the news of
Beowulf's
death to
liegemen near
by.

Bearers of battle-shields, both things expecting,

5

The end of his lifetime and the coming again of
The liegelord belovèd. Little reserved he
Of news that was known, who the ness-cliff did
travel,

But he truly discoursed to all that could hear him:

“Now the free-giving friend-lord of the
folk of the Weders,

The messenger
speaks.

10

The folk-prince of Geatmen, is fast in his death-bed,
By the deeds of the dragon in death-bed abideth;
Along with him lieth his life-taking foeman
Slain with knife-wounds: he was wholly unable
To injure at all the ill-planning monster

15

With bite of his sword-edge. Wiglaf is
sitting,

Wiglaf sits by
our dead lord.

Offspring of Wihstan, up over Beowulf,
Earl o'er another whose end-day hath reached him,
Head-watch holdeth o'er heroes unliving,¹

For friend and for foeman. The folk
now expecteth

Our lord's
death will lead

20

A season of strife when the death of the
folk-king

to attacks from
our old foes.

To Frankmen and Frisians in far-lands is published.
The war-hatred waxed warm 'gainst the Hugmen,
When Higelac came with an army of
vessels

Higelac's death
recalled.

Faring to Friesland, where the Frankmen in battle

25

Humbled him and bravely with overnight
'complished

That the mail-clad warrior must sink in the battle,
Fell 'mid his folk-troop: no fret-gems presented
The atheling to earlmen; aye was denied us
Merewing's mercy. The men of the Swedelands

30

For truce or for truth trust I but little;
But widely 'twas known that near Ravenswood
Ongentheow

Sundered Hæthcyn the Hrethling from
life-joys,

Hæthcyn's fall
referred to.

When for pride overweening the War-Scylfings first
did

Seek the Geatmen with savage intentions.

35

Early did Ohthere's age-laden father,
Old and terrible, give blow in requital,
Killing the sea-king, the queen-mother rescued,
The old one his consort deprived of her gold,
Onela's mother and Ohthere's also,

40

And then followed the feud-nursing foemen till
hardly,
Reaved of their ruler, they Ravenswood entered.

Then with vast-numbered forces he assaulted the
remnant,

Weary with wounds, woe often promised
The livelong night to the sad-hearted war-troop:

45

Said he at morning would kill them with edges of
weapons,

Some on the gallows for glee to the fowls.

Aid came after to the anxious-in-spirit

At dawn of the day, after Higelac's bugle

And trumpet-sound heard they, when the good one
proceeded

50

And faring followed the flower of the troopers.

[1] 'Hige-méðum' (2910) is glossed by H. as dat. plu. (= for the dead). S. proposes 'hige-méðe,' nom. sing. limiting Wigláf; i.e. W., *mood-weary, holds head-watch o'er friend and foe*.—B. suggests taking the word as dat. inst. plu. of an abstract noun in -'u.' The translation would be substantially the same as S.'s.

XLI.

THE MESSENGER'S RETROSPECT.

“The blood-stained trace of Swedes
and Geatmen,
The death-rush of warmen, widely was
noticed,
How the folks with each other feud did
awaken.

The messenger
continues, and
refers to the
feuds of
Swedes and
Geats.

The worthy one went then¹ with well-beloved
comrades,

5

Old and dejected to go to the fastness,
Ongentheo earl upward then turned him;
Of Higelac's battle he'd heard on inquiry,
The exultant one's prowess, despaired of resistance,
With earls of the ocean to be able to struggle,

10

'Gainst sea-going sailors to save the hoard-treasure,
His wife and his children; he fled after thenceward
Old 'neath the earth-wall. Then was offered
pursuance

To the braves of the Swedemen, the banner² to
Higelac.

They fared then forth o'er the field-of-protection,

15

When the Hrethling heroes hedgeward had thronged
them.

Then with edges of irons was Ongentheow driven,
The gray-haired to tarry, that the troop-ruler had to
Suffer the power solely of Eofor:

Wulf then wildly with weapon
assaulted him,

Wulf wounds
Ongentheow.

20

Wonred his son, that for swinge of the edges
The blood from his body burst out in currents,
Forth 'neath his hair. He feared not however,
Gray-headed Scylfing, but speedily quited

The wasting wound-stroke with worse
exchange,

Ongentheow
gives a stout
blow in return.

25

When the king of thethane-troop thither did turn
him:

The wise-mooded son of Wonred was powerless
To give a return-blow to the age-hoary man,
But his head-shielding helmet first hewed he to
pieces,

That flecked with gore perforce he did totter,

30

Fell to the earth; not fey was he yet then,
But up did he spring though an edge-wound had
reached him.

Then Higelac's vassal, valiant and
dauntless,

Eofor smites
Ongentheow
fiercely.

When his brother lay dead, made his
broad-bladed weapon,

Giant-sword ancient, defence of the giants,

35

Bound o'er the shield-wall; the folk-prince
succumbed then,

Shepherd of people, was pierced to the
vitals.

Ongentheow is
slain.

There were many attendants who bound up his
kinsman,

Carried him quickly when occasion was granted

That the place of the slain they were suffered to
manage.

40

This pending, one hero plundered the other,
His armor of iron from Ongentheow ravished,
His hard-sword hilted and helmet together;

The old one's equipments he carried to Higelac.

Eofor takes the
old king's war-
gear to
Higelac.

He the jewels received, and rewards
'mid the troopers

45

Graciously promised, and so did accomplish:
The king of the Weders requited the war-rush,
Hrethel's descendant, when home he repaired him,

To Eofor and Wulf with wide-lavished
treasures,

Higelac
rewards the
brothers.

To each of them granted a hundred of
thousands

50

In land and rings wrought out of wire:

None upon mid-earth needed to twit
him³

His gifts were
beyond cavil.

With the gifts he gave them, when glory they
conquered;

And to Eofor then gave he his one only
daughter,

To Eofor he
also gives his
only daughter
in marriage.

The honor of home, as an earnest of
favor.

55

That's the feud and hatred—as ween I 'twill happen
—

The anger of earthmen, that earls of the Swedemen
Will visit on us, when they hear that our leader
Lifeless is lying, he who longtime protected
His hoard and kingdom 'gainst hating assailers,

60

Who on the fall of the heroes defended of yore
The deed-mighty Scyldings,⁴ did for the troopers
What best did avail them, and further moreover
Hero-deeds 'complished. Now is haste
 most fitting,
That the lord of liegemen we look upon
 yonder,

It is time for us
to pay the last
marks of
respect to our
lord.

65

And *that* one carry on journey to death-pyre
Who ring-presents gave us. Not aught of it all
Shall melt with the brave one—there's a mass of
 bright jewels,
Gold beyond measure, grewsomely purchased
And ending it all ornament-rings too

70

Bought with his life; these fire shall devour,
Flame shall cover, no earlman shall wear
A jewel-memento, nor beautiful virgin
Have on her neck rings to adorn her,
But wretched in spirit bereaved of gold-gems

75

She shall oft with others be exiled and banished,
Since the leader of liegemen hath laughter forsaken,
Mirth and merriment. Hence many a war-spear
Cold from the morning shall be clutched in the
 fingers,

Heaved in the hand, no harp-music's sound shall

80

Waken the warriors, but the wan-coated raven
Fain over fey ones freely shall gabble,
Shall say to the eagle how he sped in the eating,
When, the wolf his companion, he plundered the
 slain."

So the high-minded hero was rehearsing these
stories

85

Loathsome to hear; he lied as to few of
Weirds and of words. All the war-troop
arose then,
'Neath the Eagle's Cape sadly betook
them,

The warriors
go sadly to
look at
Beowulf's
lifeless body.

Weeping and woful, the wonder to look at.
They saw on the sand then soulless a-lying,

90

His slaughter-bed holding, him who rings had given
them

In days that were done; then the death-bringing
moment

Was come to the good one, that the king very
warlike,

Wielder of Weders, with wonder-death perished.

First they beheld there a creature more wondrous,

95

The worm on the field, in front of them
lying,

They also see
the dragon.

The foeman before them: the fire-spewing dragon,

Ghostly and grisly guest in his terrors,

Was scorched in the fire; as he lay there he measured

Fifty of feet; came forth in the night-time⁵

100

To rejoice in the air, thereafter departing

To visit his den; he in death was then fastened,

He would joy in no other earth-hollowed caverns.

There stood round about him beakers and vessels,

Dishes were lying and dear-valued weapons,

105

With iron-rust eaten, as in earth's mighty bosom

A thousand of winters there they had rested:
That mighty bequest then with magic The hoard was
was guarded, under a magic
Gold of the ancients, that earlman not spell.
any
The ring-hall could touch, save Ruling-God only,
110
Sooth-king of Vict'ries gave whom He wished to
6(He is earth-folk's protector) to open God alone
the treasure, could give
E'en to such among mortals as seemed access to it.
to Him proper.

- [1] For ‘góða,’ which seems a surprising epithet for a Geat to apply to the “terrible” Ongentheow, B. suggests ‘gomela.’ The passage would then stand: *‘The old one went then,’ etc.*
- [2] For ‘segn Higeláce,’ K., Th., and B. propose ‘segn Higeláces,’ meaning: *Higelac’s banner followed the Swedes (in pursuit).*—S. suggests ‘sæcc Higeláces,’ and renders: *Higelac’s pursuit.*—The H.-So. reading, as translated in our text, means that the banner of the enemy was captured and brought to Higelac as a trophy.
- [3] The rendering given in this translation represents the king as being generous beyond the possibility of reproach; but some authorities construe ‘him’ (2996) as plu., and understand the passage to mean that no one reproached the two brothers with having received more reward than they were entitled to.
- [4] The name ‘Scyldingas’ here (3006) has caused much discussion, and given rise to several theories, the most important of which are as follows: (1) After the downfall of Hrothgar’s family, Beowulf was king of the Danes, or Scyldings. (2) For ‘Scyldingas’ read ‘Scylfingas’—that is, after killing Eadgils, the Scylfing prince, Beowulf conquered his land, and held it in subjection. (3) M. considers 3006 a thoughtless repetition of 2053. (Cf. H.-So.)
- [5] B. takes ‘nihtes’ and ‘hwílum’ (3045) as separate adverbial cases, and renders: *Joy in the air had he of yore by night, etc.* He thinks that the idea of vanished time ought to be expressed.
- [6] The parenthesis is by some emended so as to read: (1) (*He* (i.e. *God*) *is the hope of men*); (2) (*he is the hope of heroes*). Gr.’s reading has no parenthesis, but says: ... *could touch, unless God himself, true king of victories, gave to whom he would to open the treasure, the secret place of enchanters, etc.* The last is rejected on many grounds.

XLII.

WIGLAF'S SAD STORY.—THE HOARD CARRIED OFF.

Then 'twas seen that the journey prospered him little
Who wrongly within had the ornaments hidden¹
Down 'neath the wall. The warden erst slaughtered
Some few of the folk-troop: the feud then thereafter
5

Was hotly avengèd. 'Tis a wonder where,²
When the strength-famous trooper has attained to the
end of

Life-days allotted, then no longer the man may
Remain with his kinsmen where mead-cups are
flowing.

So to Beowulf happened when the ward of the
barrow,

10
Assaults, he sought for: himself had no knowledge
How his leaving this life was likely to happen.
So to doomsday, famous folk-leaders down did
Call it with curses—who 'complished it there—
That that man should be ever of ill-deeds convicted,
15

Confined in foul-places, fastened in hell-bonds,
Punished with plagues, who this place should e'er
ravage.³

He cared not for gold: rather the Wielder's
Favor preferred he first to get sight of.⁴

Wiglaf discoursed then, Wihstan his
son:

Wiglaf
addresses his
comrades.

20

“Oft many an earlman on one man’s account must
Sorrow endure, as to us it hath happened.
The liegelord belovèd we could little prevail on,
Kingdom’s keeper, counsel to follow,
Not to go to the guardian of the gold-hoard, but let
him

25

Lie where he long was, live in his dwelling
Till the end of the world. Met we a destiny
Hard to endure: the hoard has been looked at,
Been gained very grimly; too grievous the fate that⁵
The prince of the people pricked to come thither.

30

I was therein and all of it looked at,
The building’s equipments, since access was given
me,

Not kindly at all entrance permitted

Within under earth-wall. Hastily seized

I

And held in my hands a huge-weighing
burden

He tells them
of Beowulf’s
last moments.

35

Of hoard-treasures costly, hither out bare them
To my liegelord belovèd: life was yet in him,
And consciousness also; the old one discoursed then
Much and mournfully, commanded to greet you,
Bade that remembering the deeds of
your friend-lord

Beowulf’s
dying request.

40

Ye build on the fire-hill of corpses a lofty
Burial-barrow, broad and far-famous,
As ’mid world-dwelling warriors he was widely
most honored

While he reveled in riches. Let us rouse us and
hasten

Again to see and seek for the treasure,

45

The wonder 'neath wall. The way I will show you,
That close ye may look at ring-gems sufficient
And gold in abundance. Let the bier with
promptness

Fully be fashioned, when forth we shall come,
And lift we our lord, then, where long he shall tarry,

50

Well-beloved warrior, 'neath the Wielder's
protection."

Then the son of Wihstan bade orders be
given,

Wiglaf charges
them to build a
funeral-pyre.

Mood-valiant man, to many of heroes,
Holders of homesteads, that they hither from far,
⁶Leaders of liegemen, should look for the good one

55

With wood for his pyre: "The flame shall now
swallow

(The wan fire shall wax⁷) the warriors' leader

Who the rain of the iron often abided,
When, sturdily hurled, the storm of the arrows
Leapt o'er linden-wall, the lance rendered service,

60

Furnished with feathers followed the arrow."

Now the wise-mooded son of Wihstan did summon

The best of the braves from the band of the ruler

Seven together; 'neath the enemy's
roof he

He takes seven
thanes, and
enters the den.

Went with the seven; one of the heroes

65

Who fared at the front, a fire-blazing torch-light

Bare in his hand. No lot then decided
Who that hoard should havoc, when hero-earls saw
it

Lying in the cavern uncared-for entirely,
Rusting to ruin: they rued then but little

70

That they hastily hence hauled out the treasure,

The dear-valued jewels; the dragon eke They push the
pushed they, dragon over
the wall.

The worm o'er the wall, let the wave-
currents take him,

The waters enwind the ward of the treasures.

There wounden gold on a wain was The hoard is
uploaded, laid on a wain.

75

A mass unmeasured, the men-leader off then,
The hero hoary, to Whale's-Ness was carried.

- [1] For 'gehýdde,' B. suggests 'gehýðde': the passage would stand as above except the change of 'hidden' (v. 2) to 'plundered.' The reference, however, would be to the thief, not to the dragon.
- [2] The passage 'Wundur ... búan' (3063-3066), M. took to be a question asking whether it was strange that a man should die when his appointed time had come.—B. sees a corruption, and makes emendations introducing the idea that a brave man should not die from sickness or from old age, but should find death in the performance of some deed of daring.—S. sees an indirect question introduced by 'hwár' and dependent upon 'wundur': *A secret is it when the hero is to die, etc.*—Why may the two clauses not be parallel, and the whole passage an Old English cry of '*How wonderful is death!*'?—S.'s is the best yet offered, if 'wundor' means 'mystery.'
- [3] For 'strude' in H.-So., S. suggests 'stride.' This would require 'ravage' (v. 16) to be changed to 'tread.'
- [4] 'He cared ... sight of' (17, 18), S. emends so as to read as follows: *He (Beowulf) had not before seen the favor of the avaricious possessor.*
- [5] B. renders: *That which drew the king thither (i.e. the treasure) was granted us, but in such a way that it overcomes us.*

- [6] 'Folc-ágende' (3114) B. takes as dat. sing. with 'gódum,' and refers it to Beowulf; that is, *Should bring fire-wood to the place where the good folk-ruler lay.*
- [7] C. proposes to take 'weaxan' = L. 'vescor,' and translate *devour*. This gives a parallel to 'fretan' above. The parenthesis would be discarded and the passage read: *Now shall the fire consume, the wan-flame devour, the prince of warriors, etc.*

XLIII.

THE BURNING OF BEOWULF.

The folk of the Geatmen got him then Beowulf's
ready pyre.

A pile on the earth strong for the burning,
Behung with helmets, hero-knights' targets,
And bright-shining burnies, as he begged they
should have them;

5

Then wailing war-heroes their world-famous
chieftain,

Their liegelord beloved, laid in the middle.

Soldiers began then to make on the The funeral-
barrow flame.

The largest of dead-fires: dark o'er the vapor
The smoke-cloud ascended, the sad-roaring fire,

10

Mingled with weeping (the wind-roar subsided)

Till the building of bone it had broken to pieces,

Hot in the heart. Heavy in spirit

They mood-sad lamented the men-leader's ruin;

And mournful measures the much-grieving widow

15

*	*	*	*	*	*	*
*	*	*	*	*	*	*
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20

*	*	*	*	*	*	*
---	---	---	---	---	---	---

The Weders
carry out their

The men of the Weders made
accordingly

lord's last
request.

A hill on the height, high and extensive,
Of sea-going sailors to be seen from a distance,
And the brave one's beacon built where the fire was,
25

In ten-days' space, with a wall surrounded it,
As wisest of world-folk could most worthily plan it.
They placed in the barrow rings and jewels,

All such ornaments as erst in the
treasure

Rings and
gems are laid
in the barrow.

War-mooded men had won in
possession:

30

The earnings of earlmen to earth they entrusted,
The gold to the dust, where yet it remaineth
As useless to mortals as in foregoing eras.
'Round the dead-mound rode then the doughty-in-
battle,

Bairns of all twelve of the chiefs of the people,

35

More would they mourn, lament for
their ruler,

They mourn
for their lord,
and sing his
praises.

Speak in measure, mention him with
pleasure,

Weighed his worth, and his warlike achievements
Mightily commended, as 'tis meet one praise his
Liegelord in words and love him in spirit,

40

When forth from his body he fares to destruction.
So lamented mourning the men of the Geats,
Fond-loving vassals, the fall of their lord,
Said he was kindest of kings under
heaven,

An ideal king.

Gentlest of men, most winning of manner,

45

Friendliest to folk-troops and fondest of honor.

ADDENDA.

SEVERAL discrepancies and other oversights have been noticed in the H.-So. glossary. Of these a good part were avoided by Harrison and Sharp, the American editors of *Beowulf*, in their last edition, 1888. The rest will, I hope, be noticed in their fourth edition. As, however, this book may fall into the hands of some who have no copy of the American edition, it seems best to notice all the principal oversights of the German editors.

From hámb (194).—Notes and glossary conflict; the latter not having been altered to suit the conclusions accepted in the former.

Þær gelyfan sceal dryhtnes dóme (440).—Under ‘dóm’ H. says ‘the might of the Lord’; while under ‘gelyfan’ he says ‘the judgment of the Lord.’

Eal bencþelu (486).—Under ‘benc-þelu’ H. says *nom. plu.*; while under ‘eal’ he says *nom. sing.*

Heatho-ræmas (519).—Under ‘ætberan’ H. translates ‘to the Heathoremes’; while under ‘Heatho-ræmas’ he says ‘Heathoræmas reaches Breca in the swimming-match with *Beowulf*.’ Harrison and Sharp (3d edition, 1888) avoid the discrepancy.

Fáh féond-scaða (554).—Under ‘féond-scaða’ H. says ‘a gleaming sea-monster’; under ‘fáh’ he says ‘hostile.’

Onfeng hraðe inwit-þancum (749).—Under ‘onfón’ H. says ‘he *received* the maliciously-disposed one’; under ‘inwit-þanc’ he says ‘he *grasped*,’ etc.

Níð-wundor séon (1366).—Under ‘níð-wundor’ H. calls this word itself *nom. sing.*; under ‘séon’ he translates it as *accus. sing.*, understanding ‘man’ as subject of ‘séon.’ H. and S. (3d edition) make the correction.

Forgeaf hilde-bille (1521).—H., under the second word, calls it *instr. dat.*; while under ‘forgifan’ he makes it the *dat. of indir. obj.* H. and S. (3d edition) make the change.

Brád and **brún-ecg** (1547).—Under ‘brád’ H. says ‘das breite Hüftmesser mit bronzener Klinge’; under ‘brún-ecg’ he says ‘ihr breites Hüftmesser mit blitzender Klinge.’

Yðelíce (1557).—Under this word H. makes it modify ‘ástód.’ If this be right, the punctuation of the fifth edition is wrong. See H. and S., appendix.

Sélan gesóhte (1840).—Under ‘sél’ and ‘gesécan’ H. calls these two words *accus. plu.*; but this is clearly an error, as both are *nom. plu.*, *pred. nom.* H. and S. correct under ‘sél.’

Wið sylfne (1978).—Under ‘wið’ and ‘gesittan’ H. says ‘wið = near, by’; under ‘self’ he says ‘opposite.’

þéow (2225) is omitted from the glossary.

For duguðum (2502).—Under ‘duguð’ H. translates this phrase, ‘in Tüchtigkeit’; under ‘for,’ by ‘vor der edlen Kriegerschaar.’

þær (2574).—Under ‘wealdan’ H. translates *þær* by ‘wo’; under ‘mótan,’ by ‘da.’ H. and S. suggest ‘if’ in both passages.

Wunde (2726).—Under ‘wund’ H. says ‘dative,’ and under ‘wæl-bléate’ he says ‘accus.’ It is without doubt *accus.*, parallel with ‘benne.’

Strengum gebæded (3118).—Under ‘strengo’ H. says ‘Strengum’ = mit Macht; under ‘gebæded’ he translates ‘von den Sehnen.’ H. and S. correct this discrepancy by rejecting the second reading.

Bronda be láfe (3162).—A recent emendation. The fourth edition had ‘bronda betost.’ In the fifth edition the editor neglects to change the glossary to suit the new emendation. See ‘bewyrcan.’

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